

The Body You Left

A Case for the Church in an Age That Walked Away

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LIVEWELL BY JAMES BELL

*Now you are the body of Christ, and individually
members of it.*

— Paul, First Corinthians 12

Introduction: I Am Writing to the People Who Left

I have stood at the front of a sanctuary on a Sunday morning and watched the seats. Not the people. The seats. The empty ones, mostly, because a room built for four hundred that holds eighty on a good week teaches you to count what is not there. I know the names that used to fill some of them. I know why a few of those names are gone. I helped chase one or two of them out, though it took me years to admit it, and I am still not sure I have admitted all of it.

This is a book about the people who left. It is written by a man who runs the kind of building they left. That is the first thing you should know, because it should make you suspicious. A pastor writing a book asking people to come back to church is like a car salesman writing a book about the deep spiritual meaning of the sedan. You have every reason to assume the argument was rigged before it started. I would assume it too. I have read those books. They begin with a soft apology and end with an altar call, and the apology was always just the runway for the ask.

I am not going to do that. Or I am going to try not to, and you can tell me later whether I managed it. Because I do not actually want the thing those books want. I do not want to fill my seats with people who left for good reasons and were argued back in by a clever man. That would be a worse sin than the empty room. The empty room is at least honest. It tells the truth about what happened. A room full of people who came back because they were guilty or frightened or flattered into it is a room that has

learned to lie again, and the church has done quite enough lying.

Here is what I believe, and I will say it plainly so you can decide right now whether to keep reading. I believe most of the people who left the church were telling the truth about why. I believe the abuse was real. I believe the hypocrisy was real. I believe the church sold itself to politics and to money and to the smallness of its own comfort, and I believe the people who smelled that and walked out the door had a working nose. The prophets in Scripture said harder things about the people of God than any deconstructing exile has said on the internet, and God put their words in the book we call holy. If you left because the thing calling itself the body of Christ did not look or smell or act anything like Christ, you are not the villain of this book. You may be closer to its hero.

And. There is an and. If there were no and, I would not have written the book, because the first half would just be me joining the pile-on, and the pile-on does not need me. The and is this. I do not think the thing you left is the thing itself. I think you left a building, a brand, a personality, a political action committee that met on Sundays, a machine that ran on your attendance and your money and your silence. I think you were right to leave that. But underneath that thing, older than it, is a body. Paul called it the body of Christ. He did not call it a helpful community for people who share your values. He called it a body, with a head, with parts that cannot say to each other I have no need of you, with a life that runs through all of it whether the parts like each other or not. And I do not think you can have Christ without it. I think that is the hardest, least sellable thing I believe, and I am going to spend this book trying to earn the right to say it to you.

So this is the shape of the thing. First I am going to take your leaving seriously. Not as a phase, not as a wound to be managed

until you feel ready to return, but as a verdict that the church earned. I am going to name what we did. I am inside that we. I am not going to point at other pastors and other churches and other decades as though I have clean hands, because I do not, and you would smell it if I tried. Then, having granted you as much of the case as it deserves, which is most of it, I am going to make the other case. Not louder. Not with more feeling. With more truth, if I can find it. That Christianity was never a solo practice. That the New Testament does not know what to do with a Christian who has no church, the way English does not know what to do with a sentence that has no verb. That the body you left is still, somehow, the body you belong to, and that this is not good news yet but might become good news by the end.

I am a strange person to write this. I came to Christ from atheism, as a grown man, with all my arguments still loaded. Nobody raised me in this. I did not have a childhood church to be wounded by or nostalgic for. I met the faith as an adversary meets it, looking for the weak seam, and I have never fully lost the habit. I was also raised without a father, which means I know what it is to be the empty seat in someone else's life, to be the absence someone counts. And I have five sons, which means I now know the terror of being a father who could become that absence himself. Those three things, the atheism, the missing father, the five boys, are why I cannot write about the church cheaply. The church is where I was fathered, late, by broken men who did it badly and did it anyway. I am not going to pretend it was clean. I am also not going to let you tell me it was nothing.

You do not have to come back. Let me say that once, clearly, so it sits under everything else in the book. I am not writing to get you back in a seat. If you finish this and stay gone, but you stay gone with a truer picture of what you left, I will consider it time

well spent. What I am after is not your attendance. It is your honesty, and mine. The church has lied to you and about you for a long time. I would like, for the length of one book, to try telling the truth instead. Let us see what is left standing when we do.

Chapter One: The Empty Seats

Start with the numbers, because the numbers are the part nobody argues with anymore. For most of American history, the question researchers asked was whether you attended church weekly or monthly. The interesting shift, the one that broke the old models, came when the answer became never. In the early 1990s, the share of Americans who claimed no religion at all sat around five or six percent, roughly where it had been for decades. By the 2020s it was pushing thirty. That is not a wobble. That is a generation walking out of a building their grandparents built and locking the door behind them.

The researcher Ryan Burge, who has spent his working life counting these people, gave them a name that stuck. The Nones. Not atheists, mostly. Most of them still believe in God, still pray, still feel the pull of something. They have simply stopped affiliating, stopped attending, stopped calling themselves anything at all. And alongside the Nones there is a second group that matters more for this book, because they are not blank slates. They are the dechurched. People who did believe, who did attend, who were formed inside a congregation, and who left. The pollsters Jim Davis and Michael Graham, working with the sociologist Ryan Burge, estimated that around forty million American adults have stopped attending church in the last twenty-five years. Forty million. That is the largest and fastest religious shift in the history of this country, and it happened to us, on our watch, in the churches I and men like me were paid to lead.

I could hide behind the numbers. Pastors love to do that. We turn

the exodus into a chart, and a chart is a way of not looking at a face. The chart says secularization. The chart says cultural forces. The chart says the tide of modernity, as though the sea were leaving us and not the other way around. And there is something to the cultural story, I will grant it later in this book, because the frame that makes belief feel optional is real and it is bigger than any one church. But I have noticed that pastors reach for the cultural story the way a man reaches for it was the economy when his marriage ends. It is true enough to be comforting and vague enough to be useless, and it has the great advantage of putting the cause somewhere I am not.

So let me get out from behind the chart. When Davis and Graham actually asked the dechurched why they left, the answers were not what the culture-war sermon predicted. The single largest group did not leave because they stopped believing. They did not leave to sin freely, or because a professor talked them out of the resurrection, or because the culture seduced them with its glittering nothing. They left because they moved, or their schedule changed, or they had a baby, or they got divorced, and the church did not come find them. They drifted, and no one noticed the drift, and one Sunday became four Sundays became a year, and the door that had been open was now just a door they used to walk through. They were not chased out. They were let go. Nobody called. That is its own kind of verdict, and it is quieter and more damning than any scandal.

But there is a second group, and this is the group I want to sit with, because this is the group the culture-war sermon really cannot handle. These are the people who did not drift. They ran. They were pushed. Something happened to them inside a church, and it was bad enough that leaving felt like survival. A pastor's affair covered up by the elders. A youth leader who should have

been in prison. A season of genuine grief met with a casserole and a Bible verse and then a pointed question about why they were not over it yet. A marriage falling apart in full view of a congregation that had a lot of opinions about marriage and no capacity to help save one. A question asked out loud and punished as rebellion. These people can tell you the date. They can tell you the room. Grief does not have a date. Trauma does.

I have watched the church respond to these two groups with the same tone-deaf reflex, and the reflex is the reason I am writing. We treat the person who was wounded as though they were the person who drifted. We assume that under the anger is just a lapsed commitment, that if we can get them back for a nice service and a warm handshake they will remember why they loved it. We treat a broken bone like a missed appointment. And the wounded person feels, correctly, that they have not been seen at all, that the institution which failed to protect them the first time is now trying to reabsorb them without ever once admitting what it did. So they leave again, harder, and this time they take their children.

I did this. I want to be precise, because a general confession is a way of confessing nothing. There was a woman in my church, years ago, whose husband was cruel to her in ways that stayed inside the house and inside the marriage, the ways that do not leave marks a deacon can see. She came to me. And I, who had a theology of marriage as tight and shining as a new car, told her about covenant and about God hating divorce and about her witness to her husband through her patient suffering. I quoted Scripture at a woman who was drowning, and I called the Scripture I quoted at her faithfulness. She stopped coming. I told myself she had backslidden. It was years before I understood that I had been one more man in a life full of men explaining to her

why her pain was the price of somebody else's principle. She did not leave the church. I helped remove her from it. She is one of the forty million. I put her there.

So when I look at the empty seats now, I try not to see a marketing problem. A marketing problem is what we made of it. We ran the numbers and concluded we had a branding issue, a relevance issue, a worship-style issue, a parking issue, and we spent twenty years fixing the parking. The seats are empty because the people who sat in them were, many of them, telling the truth about what happened to them there, and we answered the truth with a strategy. The prophet Jeremiah said it about a different set of shepherds in a different century, and it has not stopped being true. They have healed the wound of my people lightly, saying peace, peace, when there is no peace. We put a bandage on a severed limb and printed a nice graphic about it. And then we wondered why the room got quiet.

I am not going to spend this book proving the seats are empty. You know they are empty. If you are reading this, you may be one of the empty seats, and you do not need a pastor with a chart to confirm what you did with your own two feet on a Sunday morning when you decided, finally, not to go. What I want to establish here, at the start, is only this. The emptiness is not a mystery to be solved with better lighting. It is a message. It has been sent, at great cost, by people who tried very hard to stay and could not. The least the church can do, the very least, is stop treating the message as static on the line and start treating it as speech. Somebody is talking. It is time we shut up and heard it.

Chapter Two: Why They Were Right to Leave

There is a temptation, when a pastor writes about people who left, to grant the leaving in general and deny it in every particular. Yes, the church has failed, we say, in the abstract, in the passive voice, in the way you confess to being a sinner in a way that costs you nothing because everyone is one. And then when an actual person tells an actual story, the reflexes fire. Well, we do not know the whole situation. Well, there are two sides to everything. Well, hurt people can misremember. Well, no church is perfect, and if you are looking for a perfect church you will not find one, and by the way when you find it do not join it because you will ruin it. That last line is a joke pastors tell. It is a way of making a wound sound like a preference.

I am going to spend this chapter refusing that move. I want to name, plainly and without the passive voice, some of the things the church actually did, because a steelman that stays general is not a steelman. It is a dodge with good manners. If I cannot say the specific true things, I have no right to ask you to hear the specific hard things I want to say later. So I am going to say them, and I am going to say them about churches like mine, led by men like me, and where I can I am going to say them about mine and about me.

The church covered up abuse to protect its reputation. This is not an accusation from the outside. It is the finding of the church's own reckonings, when it could be forced to have them. The Southern Baptist Convention, the largest Protestant body in

America and the one closest to my own tradition, commissioned an independent investigation that reported in 2022 that its executive leadership had for two decades maintained a private list of accused abusers while telling survivors and churches that no such list could be kept, that it was legally impossible, that their hands were tied. Their hands were not tied. They had the names. They kept the names to protect themselves and let the men keep moving. When I read that report I did not feel superior. I felt sick, because I knew the instinct in it. The instinct to protect the witness of the ministry. I have felt that instinct in smaller and less catastrophic forms, the instinct to keep a thing quiet so the work is not harmed, and I know now that the instinct is a demon and it wears the face of stewardship.

The church punished questions. Not always with a trial. Usually with a temperature. A young person raises a hard question about hell, or about the Canaanites, or about why the God of love in chapter one is ordering the sword in chapter eight, and the room cools. The question is not answered. The questioner is managed. They are prayed for in that tone. They are handed a book that assumes the conclusion. They learn, quickly, that the community will love them as long as they keep the questions inside a certain fence, and that the fence is the actual object of devotion. So the honest ones leave, because they cannot pretend, and the church congratulates itself on its purity while quietly exporting its most serious people to the atheists. I have watched a church do this. I have, God forgive me, done a version of it from the front, treating a hard question as an attack that needed a counterattack, because I was afraid, and a frightened pastor is a dangerous shepherd.

The church confused its politics with its gospel, and then it could not tell the difference, and then it could not understand why

anyone who disagreed with its politics assumed they disagreed with its gospel. This one I will develop later at length, because it may be the largest single cause of the exodus in my lifetime. But name it here. A generation watched the church that taught them Jesus loves the outsider throw its full weight behind whichever party promised it power, watched it excuse in its own champions the exact sins it had spent decades denouncing in others, and drew the obvious conclusion. Not that the church was hypocritical about politics. That the church had been lying the whole time, that the moral seriousness was a costume, and that the real object of worship had been power all along. They were not entirely wrong. That is the part that should keep us up at night. They were not entirely wrong.

The church made grief a scheduling problem. When your child dies, or your marriage ends, or your body betrays you, you are not on the program. The machine is built for the healthy and the happy and the volunteering. You get a meal train for two weeks and then you get a slow, embarrassed distance, because your ongoing sorrow is a drag on the vibe, and the vibe is load-bearing. I have seen the most faithful, longest-serving members of a congregation discover, in their worst month, that the community they poured their lives into had no idea what to do with a person who was not okay. And they did the math. They realized that they had been useful, and that useful is not the same as loved, and that they had confused the two for thirty years. That realization empties more seats than any scandal, and it never makes the news, because nobody covered it up. It just quietly happened, in a thousand foyers, over lukewarm coffee.

Now I want to be careful, because there is a way of listing these sins that becomes its own kind of performance, the pastor flogging the church to prove he is one of the good ones, and that

performance is a lie too, maybe the subtlest one in the whole book. So let me say the thing that keeps this from being theater. I am not confessing these sins as a spectator who happens to wear the uniform. I am confessing them as a participant who has committed versions of most of them. I have protected reputation over people. I have cooled at a question. I have let my politics leak into my pulpit and called it courage. I have let a grieving person become, to me, a scheduling problem. When I say the church did this, the church includes the man writing the sentence. If it did not, the sentence would be worthless.

And here is the verdict I want to land before the chapter turns, because everything in the second half of this book depends on you believing I mean it. The people who left over these things were not weak. They were not faithless. Many of them were, in fact, more serious about the actual teaching of Jesus than the institution they left, which is precisely why they could not stay inside its contradiction. Some of the most Christ-haunted people I know are outside the church, and some of the most comfortable people I know are inside it, and any theology that cannot account for that arrangement is a theology that has stopped reading its own book. The leaving was often an act of integrity. I need you to hear a pastor say that without a but attached, so I will end the chapter without one. It was often an act of integrity. Full stop. We turn to the machine next.

Chapter Three: The Church as a Brand

Somewhere in the last fifty years the American church learned to think of itself as a product, and once it learned that, it could not unlearn it, and the people it lost were often the ones who noticed. I do not mean this as a slur. I mean it as a description of a machine I have operated. I have sat in the meetings. I have used the words. Reaching people. Growing the ministry. Improving the guest experience. Every one of those phrases is borrowed from a world that sells things, and I did not notice I was borrowing, because the language of the market had become the water I swam in, and a fish does not know it is wet.

Consider what it means that we call the first-time visitor a guest and build a team to manage their experience. There is real hospitality in it, and I do not want to sneer at the greeter with the lanyard who genuinely loves people. But watch what the frame does. It casts the newcomer as a consumer to be converted into a repeat customer, and it casts the church as a service provider competing for their loyalty against the other churches in town and against the very reasonable alternative of brunch. Once that frame is in place, every decision bends toward it. The music is chosen to retain. The sermon is timed to retain. The lobby is designed, the coffee is sourced, the lighting is calibrated, the parking is solved, all in service of the metric that the frame makes inevitable, which is not holiness and is not truth. It is return visits.

Eugene Peterson, the pastor who spent thirty years in one

Maryland congregation and then translated the Bible into the language people actually speak, wrote against this his whole life. He called the pastor who runs the church as a business a shopkeeper, and he meant it as an indictment. The vocation of pastor, he insisted, had been replaced by a job description lifted from the corporation, and the replacement had happened so smoothly that most pastors, himself included in his younger years, did not feel the substitution occur. The shopkeeper's concern, Peterson wrote, is to keep the customers happy, to lure them in, to entertain them, to make sure they leave feeling they got their money's worth. And the shopkeeper measures success the way any shopkeeper does. By the numbers. I read Peterson late, after I had already built a fair bit of the shop, and reading him was like getting a letter from a doctor telling you that the symptoms you had been proud of were the disease.

The brand church has a distinct theology whether or not it ever states one, and its theology is that the customer is sovereign. This is the deep inversion, and it is worth saying slowly. In the gospel, God is sovereign and the human being is summoned, confronted, remade, called out of himself into something he did not design and would not have chosen. In the brand church, the human being is sovereign and God is the product, positioned to meet a felt need the customer already knew he had. The sermon becomes a solution to a problem the audience brought in with them, rather than a word that might tell them their problem is not the one they thought. And a church organized to meet the needs its customers already feel can never tell them the one thing they most need to hear, which is that they are wrong about what they need. It has traded away the authority to do so in exchange for the loyalty it depends on.

I want to be fair to the people who built this, because I am one of

them, and because the motive was usually not cynical. It was fear, dressed as strategy. Attendance was falling. Bills were real. Staff had families. And into that anxiety came the church-growth movement of the 1980s and 1990s, with its seminars and its metrics and its promise that if you would just remove the barriers, smooth the entry, speak the language of the unchurched neighbor, the room would fill. And it worked, for a while, in that it filled rooms. It just filled them with people who had been formed to expect a product, and a person formed to expect a product will leave the moment the product down the street is better lit. We built our own churn. We taught a generation to shop, and then we were wounded when they shopped their way out our doors.

And here is the cost the market frame hides, the cost that does not show up on any dashboard. When the church becomes a product, the members become an audience, and an audience does not need each other. You do not know the person in the next seat at a concert. You do not have to. You are both there for the thing on the stage, and when it is over you file out into the parking lot and back into your separate lives, having shared a room but not a life. The brand church can fill a room with a thousand people who are each, spiritually, alone, and call it a great crowd. The people who left often left because they finally admitted the loneliness. They had been to church every week for a decade and no one would have noticed if they vanished, and one week they tested the theory, and they were right. Nobody called. The product did not miss them, because a product does not miss anyone. That is the tell. A body misses a limb. A brand just adjusts its projections.

So when I make the case, later, for the body of Christ, understand what I am not making a case for. I am not asking you

to come back to the shop. The shop deserved to lose you. If your only options were the shop or the parking lot, I would tell you to take the parking lot, because at least in the parking lot you are not lying to yourself about being fed. But I do not think those are the only two options, though the shop has worked hard to make it seem so, because the shop cannot conceive of a church that is not a shop any more than a fish can conceive of the air. There is an older thing under the brand. The brand is a parasite on it. And you cannot see the older thing while the parasite is talking, which is most of the reason this book has to spend so long clearing the parasite away before it can point at what is underneath. We clear more of it away next, because the brand was not the worst of it. The bloc was.

Chapter Four: The Bloc

If the brand hollowed the church out from the inside, politics is what finally made the hollowness visible to the whole watching world, and I do not think the church has begun to reckon with what it cost. I am going to write this chapter carefully, because the subject is a minefield and because I have my own convictions and because the moment a pastor picks a side in print half his readers stop reading and start scoring. So let me say at the outset what I am doing and what I am not. I am not going to tell you how to vote. I am going to tell you what happened to the credibility of the church when it made how you vote the test of whether you belong.

Here is the thing that broke it, and it broke on both sides, though the American church broke worst on the right because that is where its numbers were. A movement that had spent decades insisting that character counts, that private morality was inseparable from public fitness, that a leader's treatment of women and of the truth and of the vulnerable revealed the state of his soul, discovered in a single election cycle that it could set all of that down when power was on offer, and pick it back up again to use against its enemies. The watching generation, the one we had raised in our youth groups, did the arithmetic in about ten seconds. If the character standard was real, it would apply to our side. It did not apply to our side. Therefore the character standard was never real. Therefore everything else you taught me might not be real either. That is not a cynical inference. That is a valid one. We handed it to them.

I need to be even-handed here or I have no standing, so let me

name the other direction with the same instrument. There is a version of the church on the left that performed the identical trade in the opposite costume, that took the gospel of a crucified Jewish carpenter and quietly emptied it until nothing was left but the politics of the moment with a stained-glass window behind it, that treated the current consensus of its own class as self-evidently the mind of Christ and anyone who questioned it as not merely wrong but unsafe. That church lost people too, the ones who came looking for the living God and found a nonprofit with a worship band, who could get the same politics from their university with better coffee and no obligation to sing. When I say the church became a bloc, I mean the whole church, in both its tribes, each certain it was the faithful remnant and the other tribe was the compromise. The tell was the same on both sides. In both, you could predict the entire theology from the yard sign. And a faith you can predict from a yard sign is not a faith. It is a chaplaincy to a politics that was going to happen anyway.

The prophets are the ones who see this coldest, which is why the church quotes them constantly and imitates them never. Amos, in the eighth century before Christ, stood in the middle of a religious revival, a time of full sanctuaries and generous offerings and confident national feeling, and delivered the word of the Lord to it. I hate, I despise your feasts, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies. God was not impressed by the crowds. God was nauseated by them, because the crowds had married the worship to the injustice and could no longer tell the two apart, and the marriage was the sin. Walter Brueggemann, the Old Testament scholar who spent his life on these texts, argued that the prophet's job was to puncture exactly the fusion of God and nation that makes a people feel most secure, to name it as idolatry precisely when it feels like patriotism. Brueggemann called the alternative the prophetic imagination,

and its first move is always to grieve what everyone else is celebrating. The American church, in my lifetime, learned to celebrate what it should have grieved, and it lost its prophets, and it lost the people who were waiting for a prophet and got a partisan instead.

I felt the pull of the bloc in my own pulpit, and I will tell you how it works, because it does not feel like selling out. It feels like courage. There is a week when the news is hot, and your people are angry, and you know exactly what you could say from the front that would make two-thirds of them stand up and the other third finally leave and good riddance. And it would feel like boldness. It would feel like taking a stand, refusing to be one of those cowardly pastors who never says anything real. And it is the exact opposite. It is the easiest thing in the world to tell people what they already believe with more heat than they could generate themselves. That is not prophecy. That is flattery with a raised voice. The prophetic word is the one that costs you your own tribe, that makes the people who agree with you politically the most uncomfortable, and I did not preach it often enough, because I liked being liked by my own side as much as any man does.

So the bloc emptied the seats in a particular and terrible way. It did not just drive out the people who disagreed with the politics. That would be bad enough. It drove out the people who agreed with the politics but could see that the church had made an idol of it, who did not want their deepest convictions about God fused to the passing rage of a news cycle, who understood, better than their pastors, that a gospel enlisted in any party has been demoted from a King to a mascot. Some of the most serious believers I have known left over this, and they were not leaving Christ. They were refusing to watch Christ be used, and they

could not find a room where he was not being used, so they left the rooms. I do not blame them. I blame the rooms. I helped build one.

And yet. Here comes the and yet that this whole book is made of. The failure of the church to be the body of Christ in the voting booth does not prove that there is no body of Christ. It proves that this body, like every body since the first one, is capable of betraying its own head. That is not a new discovery. It is the plot of the New Testament. The men closest to Jesus abandoned him at the arrest, denied him at the fire, and one of them handed him over for money. The church was born out of its own founding betrayal and forgiven into existence anyway. So when you show me the church selling its birthright for a seat at the table of power, you are not showing me a reason the church is fake. You are showing me the oldest sin in the church's own scriptures, the one it was warned about and did anyway, the one it will need forgiving for, the one it cannot forgive itself for alone. Hold that thought. It is going to matter when we turn the corner. But we are not turning the corner yet. There is one more failure to name, and it is the one that cuts closest, because it is not about power or money. It is about the truth.

Chapter Five: The Credibility Problem

The word hypocrite is the one the dechurched reach for most, and pastors hate it, and I have come to think we hate it because it is accurate. We have a defense ready. Everyone is a hypocrite. The church is a hospital for sinners, not a museum for saints, and a hospital is full of sick people, so what did you expect. It is a good line. I have used it. And it is true as far as it goes, and it does not go nearly as far as we need it to, because it answers a charge no one is actually making. The dechurched are not surprised that Christians sin. They grew up with Christians. They know Christians sin. That is not the accusation. The accusation is subtler and it is worse.

The accusation is that the church claims a power it does not have, and then punishes the people who notice. It stands up every Sunday and announces that it has been made new, that the Spirit of the living God dwells in it, that it is being changed from one degree of glory to another, that you will know them by their love. It makes, in other words, an empirical claim. It says something visible should be different here. And then the visitor looks, and often what is visible is not different, or is worse, meaner in its gossip, colder in its cliques, harsher in its judgment than the pagan office down the street. The problem is not that the church fell short of perfection. Everyone falls short of perfection. The problem is the gap between the size of the claim and the size of the life, and the church's refusal to admit the gap even exists.

Here is the mechanism, because I have watched it run. A pastor

falls, in one of the ordinary ways pastors fall, and the church has a choice. It can tell the truth, which is costly, which means letting the reputation of the ministry take the wound, which means sitting in a mess in front of the very people it was trying to reach. Or it can manage the story. It can use words like moral failing and season of restoration, it can move the man quietly to another position or another state, it can ask the congregation to protect the witness by keeping things in-house, and it can do all of this while continuing to preach every Sunday about integrity and the fear of the Lord. And the people who saw the truth, who know what actually happened, watch the machine choose its reputation over its honesty, and they learn the real doctrine of that church, which is not printed anywhere. The real doctrine is that the institution comes first. Everything else is marketing.

Dietrich Bonhoeffer saw this coming a long time ago, from inside a church that was busy accommodating itself to something far worse than a scandal. In his little book on Christian community, written in 1939 as the German church was tearing itself apart over whether to bow to the Reich, he wrote a sentence that has cost me sleep. He said that the person who loves their dream of community more than the community itself becomes a destroyer of that community, even though their personal intentions may be ever so honest and sincere and sacrificial. Bonhoeffer was talking about idealists, the people who arrive at church with a shining vision of what it should be and then grow bitter when the real people fail to match the vision. But the sentence cuts the other way too, at the institution that loves its dream of itself, its brand, its reputation, its projected image of a healthy growing gospel-preaching church, more than it loves the actual broken body in the room. That church will lie to protect the dream. It will sacrifice the real member to preserve the imagined institution. And in doing so it destroys the very thing it

claimed to be protecting.

I have to put myself in this, and it is not comfortable. There was a season in my ministry when a man on my staff was quietly asked to leave over something I decided the congregation did not need the details of. I told myself I was protecting people. I was protecting them from information they had a right to and that would have let them make their own judgments and grieve honestly. What I was actually protecting was the smooth surface of the thing, the sense that we were a healthy church where these things did not happen, and by protecting the surface I taught a handful of people who knew the truth that our church would choose the surface every time. At least one of them is gone now. He did not leave over the man's sin. He left over mine, the cover, the smoothness, the pastor who preached truth and practiced management. I do not know where he is. He was right to go.

There is a way to have credibility, and it is not the way we have been reaching for. It is not a better reputation. It is a worse one, chosen on purpose, in the direction of the truth. A church that told the truth about its own failures would be less impressive and more believable, and it would lose the people who wanted an impressive church, and it would keep, and maybe win back, the people who had given up on ever finding an honest one. Rowan Williams, the theologian who spent a decade as Archbishop of Canterbury holding a fracturing communion together, said that the church is most itself not when it is confident and successful but when it is repenting, when it is standing in the truth about its own condition, because that is the only posture in which the gospel it preaches is actually visible in the way it lives. A confident church preaches grace and displays performance. A repenting church preaches grace and displays need, and need is the only soil grace has ever grown in.

So the credibility problem does not get solved by getting better at hiding. It has never once been solved by getting better at hiding, though we try that first every time. It gets solved, if it gets solved, by the church becoming the one institution in a person's life that does not lie about itself, that owns its failures out loud before anyone forces it to, that would rather be caught telling an ugly truth than telling a beautiful lie. That church does not exist most places. I have not fully built it where I am. But I have seen it flicker, in moments, usually in the small and unimpressive congregations that gave up on being impressive long ago, and the flicker is enough to make me think the thing is possible. We are almost to the turn. But before I can make the case for the body, I have to name the deepest wound of all, the one that does not heal with an apology, because it was done in God's name. The wound of control.

Chapter Six: The Wound That Was Done in God's Name

There is a category of church harm that is different in kind from the ones I have named so far, and it is the one I have to be most careful with, because to write about it carelessly is to wound the wounded again. It is the harm that came not from the church being weak but from the church being strong, strong in the wrong way, over the wrong people, in the name of God. Spiritual abuse is the term that has come into use, and like all such terms it is both useful and blunt. Useful because it names a real thing that people spent years unable to name. Blunt because it gets stretched until it covers any moment a church ever asked something hard of someone, which cheapens it for the people who lived the real thing. I want the real thing here, not the stretched version.

The real thing works like this. A person comes into a community that offers belonging, meaning, and access to God, three of the deepest hungers a human being has. And the community, or its leader, quietly attaches conditions to those goods that have nothing to do with God and everything to do with control. Your belonging becomes contingent on your agreement. Your access to God becomes mediated through your submission to a man. Your questions become evidence of a rebellious spirit. Your doubts become sin. And because the goods on offer are so deep, and because the person genuinely loves God and genuinely wants to be faithful, they will bend themselves into shapes that damage them, and they will call the bending obedience, and the leader will call it discipleship, and it can go on for years before

the person realizes that the God they were told they were serving would never have asked for this, that the asking was a man, using God as a lever.

I have watched the structure of it up close, and the thing that makes it so hard to escape is that it uses the person's own faith against them. If you doubt, you are told the doubt is the enemy talking. If you want to leave, you are told that leaving is rebellion against God's appointed authority, that there is safety only under the covering of the church, that outside is the wolf and the dark. Some traditions taught this explicitly, with a whole doctrine of spiritual covering that made the leader an intermediary you could not go around. Others taught it by feel, in a thousand small signals about who was in and who was cooling and what happened to people who asked too much. Either way, the person's love for God, which is the best thing about them, becomes the chain. That is the particular evil of it. It does not attack faith from outside. It weaponizes faith from inside. It turns the sheep's own trust into the instrument of the shearing.

Jesus reserved his hottest anger for exactly this. It is worth noticing, because the church that abuses tends to picture Jesus as endorsing its severity, as the enforcer behind the leader's demands. The actual Jesus of the actual Gospels aimed his fiercest words not at the sinners, whom he ate with, but at the religious authorities who tied up heavy burdens and laid them on people's shoulders while lifting not a finger to help. Woe to you, he said to the most respected religious men of his day, for you shut the kingdom of heaven in people's faces. You neither enter yourselves nor allow those who would enter to go in. That is a description of spiritual abuse, delivered by God in the flesh, against the religious establishment, in defense of the people they were crushing. The abused person who leaves the church is

often, whether they know it or not, running toward the Jesus of that passage and away from the men who claimed to speak for him. The tragedy is that they usually cannot tell the difference anymore, because the men so thoroughly wore his face.

Here is where I have to be careful not to make the cheap move, and the cheap move is very available to me right now. The cheap move is to say that was not real Christianity, those were not real shepherds, the true church would never do that, and thereby to lift the institution free of the crime by defining the criminals out of it. I will not do that, because it is a lie, and because it is the same lie the abusive church tells, just aimed in the opposite direction. Those were real churches. Those were ordained men. They preached the real Bible, or verses of it, and they baptized real converts and served real communion and were beloved by real congregations who defended them. You cannot amputate them from the church without amputating half the church, because the capacity for this is not a foreign infection. It is in the institution's own bloodstream, in the very structures of authority and submission that the church needs in order to be a church at all. Authority can shepherd and authority can devour, and it is the same authority, and that is the terrifying part.

So what do I say to the person who was hollowed out this way, who prayed the manipulated prayers and gave the coerced money and stayed in the harmful marriage or the harmful church because a man with a Bible told them God required it, and who finally got out, and who now cannot walk into a sanctuary without their chest tightening because the whole apparatus of worship is welded in their memory to the apparatus of their harm. What do I say. I say first that I believe you, which is the thing the church usually would not do, the thing that would have changed everything if someone had done it early. I say that your

body is not overreacting, that the tightening in your chest is accurate information, that it is your own faithfulness sounding an alarm it should have been allowed to sound years ago. I do not tell you to get over it. I do not tell you the timeline. I tell you that the God you were reaching for the whole time is not the man who stood between you and him, and that the desire itself, the reaching, was never the problem and was never abused out of you, because it is still there, or you would not have felt the loss.

And then, and only then, very quietly, I say one more thing, and it is not a demand and it is not a deadline. The place where the wound happened is not the only place the thing exists. This is the hardest possible case for the argument of my whole book, harder even than the political one, because here the person was hurt by the very thing I am about to commend. But I have watched people who were spiritually abused find their way, years later and slowly, into a different kind of body, a small one usually, an unimpressive one, led by someone who had no interest in being anyone's covering, who wanted nothing from them and offered them a chair and let them sit in it for a year without asking for a thing. And I have watched something in them start to breathe again, not because they got over it, but because they finally experienced the difference between a shepherd and a wolf, felt it in the body, learned that the two are not the same even though they had worn the same clothes. I am not saying you have to go looking for that. I am saying it exists, that the counterfeit does not disprove the real, that a forged bill is only worth forging because somewhere there is a currency. We have now named the worst of it. We have granted the case, all of it, as fully as I know how. Now the book has to turn, and I have to earn every inch of the turn, starting with the one claim everything else depends on. That you were never meant to do this alone.

Chapter Seven: And Yet, Not Alone

A Christianity you can practice entirely by yourself is a Christianity the New Testament would not recognize as its own.

Everything so far has been the case for the prosecution, and I meant every word of it, and I was inside the dock the whole time. Now I have to turn, and I want to mark the turn clearly so you do not feel it as a trick, because the whole first half was designed to earn the right to this second half, and if it reads as a bait and switch then I have failed at the one thing I promised in the introduction not to do. So let me be plain about what is happening. I am not going to argue that the church was not as bad as you thought. It was as bad as you thought, and in places worse. I am going to argue something else entirely. That the thing you left, however corrupt its local expression, is not optional to the faith itself, and that this is not my opinion but the plain assumption of the entire New Testament, and that a Christianity practiced alone is not a purer Christianity but a different religion wearing the name.

Start with a simple observation about the book itself. If you sit down and read the New Testament looking for the solitary Christian, the believer who has God but no church, you will not find him. He is not there. The letters that make up most of the New Testament are almost all addressed to congregations, not individuals, and even the ones addressed to individuals are addressed to pastors of congregations about how to run congregations. The commands are plural. Love one another. Bear

one another's burdens. Confess your sins to one another. Forgive one another. Encourage one another. Do not neglect to meet together. There are dozens of these one-another commands, and every single one of them requires an other, which is to say every single one of them is impossible to obey alone. You cannot bear your own burden as another. You cannot forgive yourself as another. The grammar of the New Testament Christian life is plural, and a solitary Christian has quietly edited the whole grammar into the singular and not noticed the surgery.

I know the objection, because I made it myself for a while, in the angry season after I saw clearly what the church had done. The objection is that all of this describes community, sure, but community does not have to mean the institution. I can love and forgive and bear burdens with a few friends, over dinner, without buildings and budgets and boards and the whole apparatus that did the damage. And there is something right in this, and I will honor it later when I talk about what the church should shrink back down to. But there is also something missing in it, and the missing thing is decisive. The community the New Testament describes is not a community you assemble from people you already like. It is a community you are given, made of people you did not choose, including people you would never have chosen, and the not-choosing is the point. The dinner party of friends who agree with you is a wonderful thing and it is not the body of Christ, because you built it to your own specification, and a body you built to your own specification is just an extension of yourself. The church is the people God put in the room. That is entirely different, and it is entirely harder, and the hardness is where the actual transformation lives.

Think about what the solitary or self-selected version cannot do to you, and I mean cannot do for you, because the doing is a gift

disguised as a burden. It cannot sand you down. The friends you chose reflect you back to yourself. They share your assumptions, your class usually, your politics often, your sensibilities almost always, because that is how you came to be friends. They cannot easily show you your blind spots, because they largely share your blind spots. But the old woman three pews over who votes the way you hate, the awkward man who corners you every week with the same story, the family whose kids are loud and whose theology is thin, the person you would cross the street to avoid who is nonetheless, unavoidably, your brother in this thing, these people can do something to you that your chosen friends cannot. They can teach you to love someone you did not select for lovability. That is the entire moral content of the exercise. Anyone can love the people they would have chosen. The gospel claim is that you are being remade into someone who can love the people God chose, and you cannot practice that on people you chose, by definition.

Wendell Berry, the Kentucky farmer and writer who has spent sixty years thinking about what it means to belong to a place and a people, has a word he uses instead of community, and the word is membership. He got it from Paul, though he uses it about a farming town. To be a member, in Berry's sense, is not to have signed up for an organization that serves your interests. It is to belong to a body in such a way that your good and the good of the others are not separable, that you cannot flourish while they fail, that you are stuck with each other in the deep sense, tied together by obligation and history and need whether you feel like it on a given morning or not. Berry writes that the community, if it is to survive, must be a membership of people who are willing to be members, willing to give up a certain amount of their sovereignty, their freedom to simply leave when it stops being pleasant, in exchange for the only kind of belonging that is

actually load-bearing. The market church destroyed exactly this by making the member a customer, and the customer is sovereign, and the sovereign customer can never be a member, because membership begins where sovereignty ends.

So the case is not that you need other people in a general and sentimental way. Of course you do, everyone knows that, loneliness is killing this whole culture and the church did not invent that particular ache. The case is sharper and stranger than that. It is that the specific salvation the gospel describes, the remaking of a self-enclosed person into a person who can love God and neighbor, cannot happen to a sovereign individual, because the sovereign individual is precisely the disease being cured. You cannot be saved from your isolation by an isolated practice. You cannot be delivered from making yourself the center by a spirituality you arrange around your own center. The church, the real one, the given one, the one full of people you would not have picked, is not the delivery mechanism for a salvation that could have come some other, more convenient way. It is part of the salvation itself. To be joined to Christ is to be joined to his body, and there is no joint that attaches you to the head while leaving you free of the hands and feet. Paul knew this. He built a whole image out of it. And that image is where we go next.

Chapter Eight: The Body

A hand does not get to resign from the body because it is tired of the foot.

Paul reaches for the image of a body when he is trying to solve a very practical problem in a very messy church, and it matters that the setting is messy, because he is not describing an ideal. The church at Corinth, which received the letter where this image lives, was a disaster by any measure we would use today. They were suing each other in pagan courts. They were getting drunk at the communion table while poorer members went hungry. They were split into personality cults around their favorite preachers. There was a man sleeping with his stepmother and the congregation was proud of how tolerant they were being about it. This is the church, the actual church, to which Paul writes the most exalted description of the church in all of Scripture. He does not wait for them to get their act together before he tells them they are the body of Christ. He tells the disaster that it is the body of Christ. The description is not a reward for good behavior. It is a statement of what they already are, addressed to people behaving terribly, which should tell you something about how the title works.

Now you are the body of Christ, he writes, and individually members of it. Sit with how strong that is. He does not say you are like a body, as a helpful comparison. He does not say you should try to function as a body, as an exhortation. He says you are the body of Christ, as a fact about their present condition, the way you would tell someone the color of their own eyes. And the

members, the individual Christians, are not members the way you are a member of a gym, a person who paid and can quit. They are members the way a hand is a member of an arm, an organic part of a living whole, connected by tissue and blood and nerve to every other part, unable to be removed without both the part and the whole being wounded. The English word member has decayed in our mouths until it means someone on a list. Paul meant a body part. When he says you are members of the body of Christ, he means you are its hands, its feet, its eyes, and a hand that has decided to go it alone is not an independent hand. It is a severed one, and a severed hand does not thrive in its freedom. It dies of it.

The heart of the passage is a set of things the parts of a body are not permitted to say to each other, and each of them is aimed straight at the modern dechurched heart, including mine. The foot may not say, because I am not a hand, I do not belong to the body. That is the wound of the person who never fit, who was made to feel their gifts were the wrong gifts, their questions the wrong questions, who concluded they did not belong and left. Paul says the foot's sense of not-belonging does not actually detach it. It belongs whether it feels it or not. And then the harder one, aimed at the powerful and comfortable rather than the marginal. The eye cannot say to the hand, I have no need of you, nor again the head to the feet, I have no need of you. That is the sin of the strong member, the impressive one, the leader who decided he did not need the weak and awkward and difficult parts and quietly ran the church as though it belonged to the eyes alone. Paul says the eye is lying. The eye desperately needs the hand. A body that is all eye is a monster, not a super-body. The parts that seem weaker, Paul insists, are indispensable, and the parts we think less honorable we clothe with greater honor, because that is how a body works, protecting its soft places

rather than exposing them.

I want to press on the word indispensable, because it undoes the whole logic of the market church in one stroke. The market church is built on the dispensability of every member. That is what makes it a market. If you leave, we will get another one, because you were an interchangeable unit of attendance and giving, and the machine runs the same with your unit or a different unit in the seat. Paul says no. In a body, no part is interchangeable. The eye cannot be swapped for another eye off the shelf. When you lose a part, you do not replace it, you grieve it, because the loss is real and permanent and the body is genuinely diminished by it. The forty million who left were not forty million interchangeable units of attendance leaving a market with excess supply. If Paul is right, they were forty million body parts, and the body that lost them is not the same size with a supply problem. It is maimed. It is walking around missing its hands and wondering why it cannot hold anything. The church that treated its members as replaceable proved, by its own casual arithmetic, that it had stopped believing Paul's image and started believing the market's, and the members felt the difference in their bones and left.

But the image cuts toward the one who left as hard as toward the church that failed them, and I have to say this part even though it is the part you will like least, because I promised honesty and honesty is not just honesty about the institution. If you are a member of the body in Paul's organic sense, then your leaving is not a neutral consumer choice, a simple decision to take your business elsewhere with no cost to anyone. It is an amputation, and amputations wound both sides. You are not only harmed by the body's failures. The body is harmed by your absence. The gifts you were given, and everyone is given some, were given for

the building up of the whole, and when you took them out the door the whole lost them, and some brother or sister who needed exactly your gift did not receive it, and does not know your name, and is poorer for your going and will never know why. I am not saying this to guilt you back into a harmful room. I said clearly that some rooms must be left. I am saying that leaving is never as cheap as the market told you it was. The market told you that you were a customer, and a customer owes nothing and is owed nothing and can walk away clean. Paul tells you that you were a hand, and a hand cannot walk away clean, because a hand cannot walk away at all without tearing.

So the body image gives with both hands, which is only right, because it is an image of hands. It gives the marginalized member a belonging that their feeling of not-belonging cannot cancel, which is grace. And it gives the departed member a dignity and a cost that the market denied them, telling them their presence mattered and their absence is felt, which is also grace, harder grace, the kind that comes with weight. What it will not give anyone is the modern thing, the sovereign individual with a private God and no need of the difficult others. That option is not on Paul's table. It was never on the table. The whole New Testament was written by people for whom it would have been an incoherent idea, a Christian with no church, a saved hand walking around detached and calling its detachment maturity. We inherited the incoherent idea from somewhere else, from the market and the frontier and the buffered modern self, and we imported it into the faith and did not notice it did not fit. Bonhoeffer noticed. He watched a church destroy itself and then wrote a small book about what a real one is, from a seminary that was about to be shut down by the state, and that book is where we go next.

Chapter Nine: Life Together, Among the Broken

In the autumn of 1939, in a nearly illegal seminary in a remote corner of Germany, Dietrich Bonhoeffer sat down to write a short account of the Christian life he and his students had been living, a life of shared prayer and shared meals and shared confession, and he did it in a hurry because he correctly guessed the whole enterprise was about to be crushed by the state, which it was. The book is called *Life Together*. It is barely a hundred pages. It was written by a man who would be hanged by the Nazis six years later for his part in the resistance, and it was written for a community that existed for less than three years before the Gestapo shut it down. I mention the circumstances because they matter to how you read it. This is not the theory of a comfortable man describing an ideal he never tested. It is the testimony of a man watching real Christian community get born and die under pressure, writing down what he learned before the window closed.

The first thing Bonhoeffer says is the thing that saves the whole project from sentimentality, and it is the sentence I quoted earlier and will quote again because it is that important. He who loves his dream of a Christian community more than the Christian community itself becomes a destroyer of that community. This is aimed directly at the person who left because the church did not live up to their vision of what a church should be, and Bonhoeffer, remarkably, does not tell that person their vision was too high. He tells them their vision was the problem. The idealist, he says, comes into community with a dream, a picture

of how the fellowship should feel and function, and when the real people fail to match the dream, the idealist becomes an accuser, first of the others, then of God, and finally of himself, and in the accusing he destroys the very community he thought he loved. Because he never loved the community. He loved the dream, and the real community was only ever a disappointment measured against it.

What Bonhoeffer offers instead is a stunning reversal, and it is the reversal the wounded church-leaver most needs to hear and least expects from a book about Christian community. He says that the sooner your dream of community is shattered, the better. He calls the disillusionment a grace. Because only when the ideal picture is broken can you begin to love the real people, the actual difficult tiresome disappointing people God has put in front of you, rather than loving your own beautiful idea and using the real people as props for it. The person who is grateful for small things, who receives the flawed community as a gift rather than measuring it against a fantasy and finding it wanting, is the one who can actually live in a fellowship. And the person who is always disappointed, always aware of how far the real church falls short, is loving something, but it is not the church. It is a picture in his own head, and a picture cannot be loved back.

Then Bonhoeffer says the thing that makes the whole book true, the thing that keeps this from being one more demand that you settle for less than you deserve. Christian community, he insists, is not an ideal we have to realize but a reality created by God in Christ in which we may participate. The fellowship does not depend on the members being lovable, or compatible, or even good. It depends on Christ, who has already joined them together before they lift a finger, whose reality holds the community together over the heads of its failing members. This is why

Bonhoeffer can say we enter into community not as those who make demands but as those who thankfully receive. You do not come to church to get your needs met by other people, who will fail you, because they are people. You come as one who has already been given the community by Christ, and who therefore does not need to extract it from the others by force or leave in a rage when they cannot supply it. The pressure comes off the people. They were never able to bear it anyway. The community rests on Christ, and Christ can bear it.

I have found this both bracing and difficult, because it cuts against the grain of everything the therapeutic church taught me to want, and I taught others to want, from the front. We built churches to meet needs, and we told people to come and get their needs met, and then we wondered why the community was so brittle, so quick to fracture, so full of people leaving because their needs were not being met. Of course it was. We had made the community into a needs-meeting machine, and a needs-meeting machine breaks the moment it fails to meet a need, which is constantly, because people are bottomless and other people are not God. Bonhoeffer would say we built the community on the wrong foundation, on the members and their needs, when the only foundation that holds is Christ and his prior gift. A church built on Christ can survive its members disappointing each other, because that was never what was holding it up. A church built on need-meeting cannot survive a single unmet need, and it meets a thousand of those before lunch.

There is a passage in *Life Together* about the difference between what Bonhoeffer calls spiritual community and emotional community, and it has stayed with me for years, because it names the counterfeit that the abusive churches ran on. Emotional community, in his terms, is a fellowship held together

by human attraction, by strong personalities, by the emotional dependence of members on a charismatic leader, by the warm feeling of belonging that a gifted man can generate in a room. It looks like the real thing. It feels, often, better than the real thing, because it is engineered to feel good. But it is a human construction, and it binds people to a man rather than to Christ, and it uses the members for the leader's needs while telling them their needs are being met. Bonhoeffer says the spiritual community, by contrast, is held together by Christ alone, points always away from the human leader and toward the Lord, and is therefore free, because no one in it is being used. When I read that, I understood for the first time what had been wrong with certain rooms I had been in and certain rooms I had run. They were emotionally powerful and spiritually empty. They ran on the leader. And when the leader fell, or the feeling faded, there was nothing underneath, and everyone scattered, and they called it losing their faith when what they had actually lost was a feeling that had been sold to them as faith.

So Bonhoeffer does not answer the wounded church-leaver by defending the church that wounded them. He does something better. He hands them a diagnosis of what went wrong that is sharper than the one they came in with. The church that hurt you was very likely an emotional community masquerading as a spiritual one, running on a man, meeting needs it stoked, held together by feeling rather than by Christ, and its collapse and your wounding were written into its foundation from the start. That is not a reason to give up on Christian community. It is a reason to find or build the other kind, the kind held together by Christ alone, where the leader points away from himself, where no one is being used, where the disappointment of your dream is welcomed as the doorway to loving the real. That kind is quieter. It will never fill a stadium. It is also the only kind that can hold a

broken person without breaking them further, and it is the kind the New Testament was describing the whole time. But you cannot get to it while you are still holding the dream. The dream has to die first. Bonhoeffer said the death of the dream is a grace. I did not believe him for years. I believe him now.

Chapter Ten: The Things You Cannot Do Alone

There is a category of Christian practice that simply cannot be done by a solitary person, and the modern church-leaver, formed to think of faith as a private matter between the soul and God, often does not notice these practices going missing until years later, when they realize something in them has quietly starved. I am talking about what the old traditions called the means of grace, and specifically about the ones that require a body. Word, water, table. Preaching, baptism, the Lord's Supper. These are not enrichments added to a faith that would be complete without them. In the historic understanding of nearly every branch of the church, Catholic and Orthodox and Protestant alike, they are ordinary channels through which God actually gives himself to his people, and here is the thing the private spirituality cannot get around. Two of the three cannot be done alone, and the third was never meant to be.

Start with the table, because it is the sharpest case. The Lord's Supper is not a private devotional. You cannot celebrate communion by yourself in your kitchen, not because there is a rule against it exactly, but because the thing makes no sense as a solo act. It is a meal, and a meal alone is not a meal, it is eating. Paul, in that same messy letter to the Corinthians, ties the bread directly to the body of the church. Because there is one bread, he writes, we who are many are one body, for we all partake of the one bread. The horizontal and the vertical are welded together in the sacrament. In receiving Christ, you receive the people receiving Christ beside you. That is why Paul is so furious that

the Corinthians were dividing at the table, the rich eating first and getting drunk while the poor got nothing, because the division at the table was a denial of the very thing the table was. To eat the bread while despising the body, he says, is to eat judgment on yourself. The meal is not a private transaction between you and God with other people incidentally in the room. The other people in the room are part of what you are receiving. Take them away and you have not simplified the sacrament. You have abolished it.

Baptism is even clearer, because you cannot baptize yourself. It is grammatically and physically a thing done to you by another, in the presence of a community, into a body. You do not baptize yourself into Christ any more than you birth yourself into a family. You are received. Someone else says the words, someone else lowers you into the water and raises you, someone else stands as witness that this happened and that you now belong. The early church understood baptism as the doorway into the church, not a private symbol of a private decision, and the two are not the same thing. The private-decision version, which I was taught and which much of American evangelicalism runs on, quietly relocated the meaning of baptism from being joined to a body to expressing an individual choice, and once you have made that move, of course the body becomes optional, because the sacrament was already redefined to leave it out. But that is not what baptism was for most of Christian history. It was the moment you stopped being a solitary seeker and became a member, and you cannot become a member of yourself.

The preaching of the word is the one case where a solitary person can seem to manage, because you can read the Bible alone, and you should, and no one is stopping you. But notice what the private reading cannot do. It cannot confront you with a

word you did not choose. When you read alone, you select the passages, you set the pace, you skip the parts that unsettle you, and above all you interpret through your own lens with no one present to say, that is not what it means, or, you have made this verse serve you rather than judge you. The preached word, delivered by another to a gathered body, has the capacity to say the thing you would never have said to yourself, to land on the exact sin you were managing to avoid, to be, as the letter to the Hebrews puts it, living and active, sharper than any two-edged sword, piercing to the division of soul and spirit. A word you administer to yourself will always, in the end, tell you what you were prepared to hear. That is its limit and it is a fatal one. The word preached into a body can ambush you, and the ambush is the grace, and the solitary reader has arranged a faith with no possibility of ambush.

I want to be honest about the objection here, because it is a strong one and I have felt its full force. The objection is that these means of grace were exactly what the corrupt church weaponized. The table was used to include and exclude, to enforce conformity, to punish. Baptism was made into a loyalty test. The preached word was the very instrument of the spiritual abuse, the sword turned against the sheep. So to tell a wounded person that they cannot get these things alone is to tell them they must return to the scene of the crime to receive what they need, which sounds less like good news and more like a hostage situation. I take the objection seriously. It is the reason this book has been so slow and so careful. But notice what the objection actually concedes. It concedes that these things are real goods, powerful enough that their corruption did real damage. You cannot weaponize nothing. The very fact that the misused table could wound so deeply is evidence of how much the rightly used table gives. The abuse is a testimony to the value, the way

counterfeit money testifies to the existence of the real currency, the way a poisoned well testifies that there was water in it worth poisoning.

So the honest answer to the objection is not to deny that the means of grace can be weaponized. They can, and they were, against people I love, and against some of you. The honest answer is that a good weaponized is still, underneath the weaponizing, a good, and that the solution to a poisoned well is not to swear off water forever but to find, eventually, when you can, a well that has not been poisoned. There are tables that are not policed. There are congregations where the word is preached to comfort the afflicted and afflict the comfortable rather than to control. There are baptisms performed as welcomes rather than as tests. They are quieter and rarer than they should be, and I will not pretend they are on every corner. But they exist, and the thing they give exists, and it is a thing you genuinely cannot manufacture alone in your living room with a podcast and a Bible app, however sincere your faith. You were made to be fed at a table you did not set, washed in water you did not draw, cut by a word you did not choose. The private version keeps you comfortable. It also keeps you hungry, and the hunger is the body telling you the truth, and there is one more thing the private version cannot give you, and it is the largest of all. It cannot give you the company of the dead.

Chapter Eleven: You Are Not the First

The faith did not begin the day you found it, and it will not end the day you doubt it.

One of the strangest and most freeing doctrines in the whole Christian tradition is buried in a line of the ancient creed that most churches recite without thinking, the line about the communion of saints. It is easy to skate over. It sounds like churchy filler between the forgiveness of sins and the resurrection of the body. But it is making a claim so large that if you took it seriously it would rearrange your whole sense of what the church is and how alone you are inside it, which is to say, not alone at all, not remotely, not even close. The communion of saints means that the church is not only the people currently breathing. It is every believer who has ever lived, the whole company of the faithful across two thousand years and every continent, all of them somehow joined in the one body of Christ that death does not sever. When you belong to the church, you belong to them. You are the newest arrival in a house that has been full for a very long time.

This matters enormously to the person who left, and here is why. The modern church-leaver has usually been formed inside a very thin slice of Christianity, a few decades of a single tradition in a single country, and often it is a bad slice, a shallow or corrupt or politicized or abusive expression, and they have quietly, understandably, taken that slice to be the thing itself. When they

reject it, they think they are rejecting Christianity, when in fact they are rejecting a tiny and unrepresentative sample of it, a sample that would have horrified most Christians in most centuries. The communion of saints is the antidote to that mistake. It says the faith you are tempted to leave is two thousand years old and unimaginably various, that it survived the fall of Rome and the plagues of the Middle Ages and the corruptions of the Renaissance church and produced, in every one of those disasters, people of staggering wisdom and courage and love, and that whatever the megachurch down the street did to you, it does not get to be the final word on what this thing is. There is a much older, much deeper, much stranger river, and the puddle you left is not the river.

Let me make it concrete, because the doctrine stays abstract until it has faces. When you doubt, you are not the first. Sit with the actual history. Augustine, in the fourth century, spent years unable to believe, chasing every philosophy on offer, sleeping around and lying to himself, before he was undone in a garden in Milan. The author of many of the Psalms cried out how long, O Lord, will you forget me forever, which is not the prayer of a confident man. Mother Teresa, we now know from her letters, spent decades in a spiritual darkness so total she could not feel God at all, and served the dying of Calcutta anyway, in the dark, for fifty years. The faith has always contained its doubters, its wrestlers, its dark-night saints, and it did not expel them. It canonized some of them. When the shallow church told you that your doubt made you a bad Christian or no Christian, the shallow church was betraying two thousand years of its own family history, in which doubt was often the mark of the most serious believers, the ones who cared too much to pretend. You were made to feel like a defective unit. You were, in fact, in the oldest and most honorable company the faith has.

The same is true of your grievances against the institution, and this is the part that surprises people. You think your critique of the corrupt church is a modern discovery, a product of your enlightenment finally seeing through the whole thing. It is not. It is ancient, and it comes from inside the church, from her own saints, stated more fiercely than you have stated it. Bernard of Clairvaux, in the twelfth century, wrote to a pope, an actual sitting pope, and told him the church had become a marketplace and the clergy were wolves. Catherine of Siena, a laywoman in the fourteenth century, wrote to the popes of her day and called them to account for the corruption of the church in language that would get you thrown out of most congregations today for disrespect. The prophets, as I keep saying, said harder things than any of us. The church has always contained a tradition of blistering internal critique, carried out by its holiest members, precisely because they loved the thing enough to be furious at what it had become. Your anger at the corrupt church, if it is love turned to grief, is not outside the tradition. It is one of the most traditional things about you. You just did not know you had ancestors.

There is a particular loneliness in the modern deconstruction, and the communion of saints speaks directly to it. The loneliness is the feeling that you are out on the edge, that you have seen something the naive believers around you cannot see, that you are alone in your clear-eyed disillusionment, and that there is no way back that would not be a betrayal of what you now know. That loneliness is real and it is also, in a strange way, a kind of pride, the pride of thinking you are the first to see through it, and the communion of saints humbles that pride in the gentlest possible way. It says you are not the first. Thousands have stood exactly where you stand, seen exactly what you see, felt exactly the disillusionment you feel, and a great many of them found a

way through it that was neither naive return nor final departure, a way through into an older and tougher and more clear-eyed faith on the far side of the disillusionment. They left you maps. The maps are in the books nobody made you read. You were handed a faith with no ancestors and told it was two thousand years old, and the contradiction was never yours to resolve, because it was a lie you inherited, not a truth you discovered.

So the communion of saints reframes the whole crisis. You are not a lone individual deciding whether to accept or reject a proposition called Christianity. You are a late arrival in an ancient people, being invited to take your place in a company that includes the doubters and the critics and the wounded and the furious, all of whom belonged, none of whom had it figured out, most of whom would recognize your struggle as their own. Chesterton called tradition the democracy of the dead, the refusal to let the small aristocracy of those who happen to be walking around have the only vote. The dead get a vote in the church. And the dead, the great cloud of witnesses the letter to the Hebrews says surrounds us, are voting, overwhelmingly, that the thing is real, that they found it worth their lives, that they stayed with it through worse than you have seen, and that the corruption you fled, which they also saw and fought, is not the final truth about the body of Christ. You wanted to leave a shallow thing. You have every right to. But do not mistake the shallow thing for the deep one. The deep one has been waiting two thousand years, and it has room for you, and it is not surprised by anything you have to say, because its saints said it first, and louder. Now, to make this real, we have to descend from the whole company of the dead to the hardest possible test, the one that happens between two living people in a room. Confession. Forgiveness. The place the theory either becomes flesh or stays a pretty idea.

Chapter Twelve: Confession Among People Who Know Your Name

Bonhoeffer has a chapter near the end of *Life Together* that most readers skip, because it is uncomfortable, and it is the chapter I have come to think is the whole point of the book. It is about confession, and not confession to God in the privacy of your own heart, which everyone approves of because it costs nothing and no one ever finds out. It is about confession to another Christian, out loud, of your actual sins, the specific ones, to a person who will see your face while you say them. Bonhoeffer argues that a Christian community that has not learned to do this is not yet a real community, that it is still living in what he calls the pious fellowship of the devout, where everyone maintains the performance of being basically fine, and that this performance is precisely what keeps the community shallow and eventually kills it.

Here is his logic, and it is devastating. In a community without confession, he says, we are alone with our sin, and being alone with our sin is exactly where sin wants us. Sin demands to be alone, he writes. It withdraws from the community. The more isolated a person is, the more destructive the power of sin over them, and the more deeply they become caught in it, the more devastating is their isolation. Sin wants to remain unknown. It shuns the light. So the community where everyone pretends to be fine is not a safe community. It is a community where every member is being slowly destroyed in private by the very things they cannot say out loud, and the pretending, the mutual performance of holiness, is the mechanism of the destruction.

The bright shiny church where no one struggles openly is not a healthy church. It is a hospital where everyone has agreed to pretend they are not sick, and people die of that agreement all the time.

Now watch how this connects to why people left. A great many of the wounded left churches that were exactly the pious fellowship of the devout, communities that ran on the performance of being fine, where you learned early that your real struggles were not welcome, that the sin you were actually fighting could not be named, that the doubt you were actually having would be met with alarm rather than embrace. So you performed. Everyone performed. And under the performance you were alone, more alone than you would have been outside the church, because at least outside no one demanded you pretend. And eventually the loneliness under the performance became unbearable, and you left, and you told yourself, correctly, that the church was fake, that it was all a show. What you may not have known is that Bonhoeffer diagnosed your exact experience in 1939 and named it as a betrayal of what the church is supposed to be. The fakeness you fled was real. It was also not the church. It was the church's disease, the specific disease that confession is the cure for, the cure your church refused to administer because administering it would have punctured the performance everyone was invested in.

Because here is the astonishing flip side. Bonhoeffer says that in confession, the breakthrough to community happens. When you finally speak your real sin out loud to another person, the isolation shatters. The thing you were sure would end your belonging, that would make them recoil, that would prove you did not really belong among these good people, turns out to be the thing that finally lets you belong, because now they know the

real you and not the performance, and they have not fled, and their staying is a word of grace deeper than any sermon. Bonhoeffer says the confessing Christian receives back their own self through the other, that in the presence of a brother or sister who hears their sin and does not condemn them, they experience the presence of God in a way the solitary confession to an invisible God can never quite deliver. It is one thing to believe in the abstract that God forgives. It is another thing entirely to say the worst true thing about yourself to a human face and watch that face not turn away. That is the gospel made flesh, and you cannot get it alone, because it requires an other, a body, a person in the room who knows your name.

I have both received and refused this in my own life, and the refusing is the more instructive story, so I will tell that one. For a long stretch of my ministry I confessed my sins to God alone, in private, sincerely, and I would not have dreamed of naming them to another person, and I told myself this was because they were between me and God. That was a lie, and the truth underneath it was simpler and uglier. I was a pastor, and I had built a reputation as a man of some spiritual seriousness, and I was terrified of what it would cost that reputation for anyone to know what I actually struggled with. So I kept my confession vertical and invisible, and I stayed, in Bonhoeffer's exact phrase, alone with my sin, and it had more power over me than it should have because I gave it the isolation it demanded. It was only when I finally told the truth to one other man, an older pastor who had no stake in my reputation, that I felt the thing break. Nothing about the sin changed. Everything about its power changed, because it was no longer secret, no longer feeding on the dark. I had preached grace for years. I experienced it, in that full and shattering way, only when I was finally willing to be known by another human being who could see my face.

There is a danger here that I have to name, because confession was one of the tools the abusive churches turned into a weapon, and I would be reckless to commend it without the warning. Confession requires safety, and safety requires that the person you confess to has no power to use it against you, is not your spiritual dictator, will not store your sin as ammunition or a lever of control. The forced confession, the confession extracted by a leader who then holds it over you, the confession that becomes public humiliation or a tool of dominance, that is not what Bonhoeffer means and it is a grotesque perversion of it. Real confession is voluntary, is offered to a fellow sinner and not to a superior, and is met with the confessor's own confession in return, so that no one stands above and no one stands below, and both stand together as forgiven beggars at the foot of the cross. If a church made confession into a technology of control, it corrupted the very thing that was supposed to set you free, and your recoil from it is holy. But the corruption of the practice does not abolish the practice. Somewhere there are people you could tell the truth to who would not weaponize it, and the freedom Bonhoeffer describes is real, and it is on the other side of a wall of fear that the abusive church built inside you, and getting over that wall, with the right person, in your own time, is some of the most healing work a wounded believer ever does.

So confession is the place where the whole argument of this book stops being a theory and becomes a room with two people in it. Everything I have said about the body, about not being alone, about the means of grace, about the communion of saints, all of it comes down finally to whether you can say a true thing to another human face and be received. That is the church at its irreducible core, smaller than any building, older than any denomination, impossible to do alone, and it is the exact thing the corrupt church made impossible and the exact thing the real

church exists to make possible. Two sinners, telling each other the truth, forgiving each other in Christ's name, and thereby becoming, in that moment, in that room, the body of Christ, which is what they were the whole time. If you have never had that, you have not yet had the church, whatever you attended. And if you have had it, even once, you know it is real, and you know it is worth the wall you had to climb to reach it. Now we turn from what the church is to what it could be, from diagnosis and defense to a description of the thing worth returning to, if such a thing could be built.

Chapter Thirteen: What a Church Worth Returning To Looks Like

It is not enough to defend the church in the abstract while leaving the actual churches as bad as they are. That would be a cheat, and you would smell it. If the body is real and not optional, then the failures of the visible churches are not excused by the reality of the invisible body, they are indicted by it, and the pastor who has spent twelve chapters granting the case against the church owes you a picture of what a church that deserved you would actually look like. Not a perfect church. There is no perfect church, and the search for one is the idealism Bonhoeffer warned would make you a destroyer. But a church worth the risk of returning to, a church that would not do to you what the last one did. Let me try to describe it, knowing I have not fully built it, knowing this is as much confession of failure as it is vision.

A church worth returning to tells the truth about itself. This is first because it is the one that everything else depends on. It does not perform health it does not have. When its leaders fail, it says so, in plain words, and lets its reputation take the wound rather than protecting the institution at the cost of the truth. It does not use phrases like moral failing to fog what happened, does not move its predators quietly down the road, does not ask the wounded to protect the witness by staying silent. It would rather be known as the church where hard things get named than the church where everything looks fine, because it has learned that looking fine is the enemy, that the performance of health is the disease, and that a community which cannot tell the truth about

its own sin cannot offer anyone the grace it preaches. This church will look worse than the shiny ones. That is how you will know it is better.

A church worth returning to has a leader who points away from himself. This is Bonhoeffer's spiritual community against his emotional community, made concrete. The leader is not the point. His personality is not the draw. His giftedness, if he has any, is deployed to make himself less necessary rather than more, to build a body that could survive his departure, to hand the ministry outward rather than gathering it inward around his own charisma. You can tell the difference quickly if you know what to look for. In the emotional community, everything runs on the man, and the highest value is loyalty to him, and questioning him is treated as questioning God. In the spiritual community, the man keeps stepping out of the center and pushing you toward Christ and toward the other members, and he seems almost relieved when he is not needed, and he does not confuse criticism of himself with rebellion against the Lord. The abusive churches were all emotional communities with a man at the center. The church worth returning to has a man who keeps getting out of the way.

A church worth returning to is small enough to know you, or is organized so that some smaller part of it can. I do not think size is a sin in itself, and I will not pretend the little church is automatically holy, because I have seen little churches that were vicious in ways a big anonymous one could never manage. But I do think that the body Paul describes, the one where the parts know and need and suffer with one another, requires that somewhere in the structure there is a room small enough for you to be known, to be missed when you are gone, to have someone notice the change in your face. A church of thousands where you

could vanish and no one would call has not sinned by being large, but it has failed to be a body wherever it left you unknown, and the church worth returning to has solved this somehow, has made sure that under the crowd there is a place where you are not a unit of attendance but a person with a name.

A church worth returning to holds its convictions without making them the price of belonging. This is the hardest one to describe without being misunderstood, so let me be careful. I am not describing a church with no convictions, a church that believes nothing firmly enough to be worth joining, because that church is just the culture with a cross on it and it will not hold your weight in a crisis. The church worth returning to believes the old creedal things with its whole heart, confesses them, will not water them down to keep you comfortable. But it distinguishes, the way the tradition always distinguished, between the things that are the faith and the things that are opinions about the faith, and it does not make its politics or its secondary doctrines or its cultural preferences into tests of whether you belong. You can disagree with it about a great many things and still be fully a member, fully loved, fully at the table, because it has learned the difference between the creed and the tribe, and it refuses to let the tribe masquerade as the creed. The church that made a yard sign the price of belonging had lost this. The church worth returning to has found it again.

A church worth returning to is a place where you are allowed to not be okay. It has repented of the machine built only for the healthy and the happy and the volunteering. It knows how to sit with grief that does not resolve on schedule, how to stay present to a marriage that is failing without rushing to fix it or judge it, how to receive the doubter and the depressed and the barely-hanging-on not as problems to be processed but as members of

the body whose suffering is the body's own suffering. It has a table long enough for the people who are not fine, and it does not quietly edge them toward the exit when their ongoing pain becomes inconvenient to the mood. This is rare. I will be honest that it is rare, because it costs the community its comfort, and most communities will choose their comfort every time. But where it exists, it is unmistakable, and it is the thing the wounded are actually looking for when they go looking, whether they could name it or not. A place where they do not have to perform. A place where the truth of their condition is welcome. A place where not being okay does not cost them their belonging.

I have described five things, and I could describe more, but I want to end this chapter by admitting the obvious. The church I have described mostly does not exist, or exists in fragments, a piece here and a piece there, never all assembled in one building down your street. I have not built it where I am. I have built pieces of it and failed at pieces of it and I am still failing at some of them as I write this sentence. So I am not pointing you toward a church that exists and telling you to go there. I am doing something harder and less satisfying. I am describing the thing so that you can recognize it if you ever see even a flicker of it, so that you will not settle for the counterfeit, and so that, if you are one of the people who is going to help build the church your children inherit, you will know what you are building toward. The church worth returning to is not mostly out there waiting for you. It is mostly still to be built, by the very people who were wounded enough to know what it must never do again. That is a strange kind of hope. It is the only honest kind I have. And it raises the question the next chapter has to face, which is what you do when the church you actually have, the real one down the street, is not the one I just described, and staying means staying disappointed.

Chapter Fourteen: Staying Without Pretending

Most of the people reading this who are still in a church are not in the church I described in the last chapter. They are in an ordinary church, which is to say a disappointing one, a mixed and mediocre and sometimes maddening one, a church with a decent enough pastor who preaches forgettable sermons, a music program that makes them wince, a board that moves at the speed of continental drift, and a handful of people they genuinely love scattered among a larger number they merely tolerate. And the question for these people is not whether to return, because they never left, but whether to keep staying, and more precisely how to stay without either pretending the church is better than it is or curdling into the bitter critic who poisons everyone around him. This is its own spiritual discipline, and almost no one teaches it, and it may be the most needed skill in the whole Christian life right now.

The pretending is the first temptation and it is the one the church actively encourages, so it is the harder to resist. There is enormous social pressure inside a congregation to speak well of it, to be positive, to not be divisive, to protect the unity by never naming the problems, and this pressure gets dressed up in spiritual language about not gossiping and not being critical and not causing division. Some of that is real. Gossip is a genuine sin and I am not licensing it. But a great deal of what passes for protecting unity is just the performance of health that Bonhoeffer said was killing us, the mutual agreement to pretend everyone is fine, and it produces a church full of people privately

disillusioned and publicly enthusiastic, which is to say a church full of people who are lying, and the lying corrodes them. You cannot have a healthy relationship with an institution you are required to pretend is better than it is. That pretending is exactly what broke the people who left. If staying requires it of you, staying will break you too, just more slowly.

So the first move of faithful staying is to stop pretending, to let yourself see the church clearly, disappointments and mediocrities and failures fully in view, and to love it anyway, not the imagined version but the real one. This is Bonhoeffer's shattered dream received as grace, and it is the opposite of both the enthusiast and the cynic. The enthusiast loves an imagined church and cannot see the real one. The cynic sees the real one and cannot love it. The mature member sees the real one clearly, more clearly than the enthusiast, and loves it more truly than the cynic ever could, because he is loving what is actually there rather than a fantasy or a grievance. This is how you love anything real, by the way, a spouse, a child, a country, a self. You see it as it is and you do not withdraw your love, and the seeing and the loving together are what maturity means. The church is just the hardest case, because the gap between what it claims and what it is runs wider than almost anything else you will ever love.

There is a difference, and you have to learn to feel it, between staying disappointed and staying resentful, and the difference is roughly the difference between grief and contempt. Disappointment grieves the gap between what the church is and what it should be, and grief is a form of love, because you only grieve what you value. Resentment has stopped valuing. It has crossed over into contempt, into a settled superiority that watches the church fail and feels vindicated rather than sad, that has secretly given up on the thing while continuing to attend it,

that uses its clear sight of the church's flaws as a way of standing above the other members rather than suffering alongside them. The resentful member is more destructive than the one who left, because he stays and spreads the contagion, and he mistakes his contempt for discernment. The test you have to keep applying to your own heart is whether you still grieve the church's failures or whether you have started to enjoy them, whether they still hurt you or whether they have started to feel good, and the day they start to feel good is the day you have become a danger to the body you are still technically part of.

Wendell Berry has a line about marriage that I have stolen and applied to the church more times than I can count, because the two are more alike than we admit. He writes that you do not marry the person you think you are marrying, that you marry a stranger, and that the marriage is the long slow work of coming to know and love the actual person you find yourself bound to rather than the imagined one you thought you were choosing. The same is true of a church. You do not join the church you think you are joining. Within a year the illusions burn off and you find yourself bound to the actual congregation, the real difficult people, the real disappointing leadership, and the membership Berry describes, the willingness to stay bound and to keep working at the love, is the whole thing. The people who leave the moment the illusion burns off are like the people who leave a marriage the moment the honeymoon ends. Sometimes they are fleeing a genuine abuse and they are right to go, and I will say more about that next. But often they are just fleeing the ordinary disappointment that is the price of any real bond, and they will flee the next church too, and the next, because the thing they cannot tolerate is not any particular church, it is reality, the reality that everything real disappoints you and asks to be loved anyway.

Faithful staying also means finding your specific place to serve rather than remaining a spectator with opinions, and this is more practical than spiritual but it is where the spiritual becomes real. The disappointed spectator has a lot of time to be disappointed, because he is doing nothing, and the doing of nothing is half of what feeds the disappointment. The member who has found a place, who teaches the kids or visits the sick or sets up the chairs or sits with the grieving, is too involved in the actual life of the actual body to sustain the spectator's contempt, because he has skin in it now, he is one of the failing parts himself, and it is very hard to feel superior to a body you are visibly failing to perfect from the inside. Berry's membership is not a feeling. It is a set of obligations shouldered, a place taken, a load carried, and it turns out that the load-carrying is the cure for a great deal of the disappointment, not because the church gets better but because you stop watching it from the outside and start being it from the inside, and the inside view is different, gentler, more forgiving, because from the inside you can see how hard the failing people are actually trying.

I want to be clear that faithful staying is not the same as staying no matter what, and I would be doing real harm if I let this chapter be heard that way, so let me set up the next one by drawing the line hard. Everything I have said about staying assumes a church that is ordinary-bad, disappointing and mediocre and mixed, the normal condition of every real church since Corinth. It does not apply to a church that is dangerous. There is a difference between a church that disappoints you and a church that harms you, between a community that fails to be all it should be and a community that is actively destroying its members, and the discipline of faithful staying is for the first kind, not the second. To tell a person in a genuinely abusive church that leaving would be a failure of faithfulness is to

become one more voice in the apparatus of their abuse, and I will not do it. So the next chapter is about the other line, the one where leaving a particular church is not a failure of faith but an act of it, and about how to tell, in your own case, which line you are actually standing on, because getting that wrong in either direction does real damage, and the church has gotten it catastrophically wrong in one direction for a very long time.

Chapter Fifteen: When Leaving Is Faithful

I have spent a great deal of this book making the case that the church is not optional and that leaving is costly and that faithful staying is a discipline worth learning, and if I stopped there I would have written a dangerous book, the kind of book that gets handed to a woman by an elder who wants her to stay under a roof that is crushing her. So I have to be as clear about the exception as I have been about the rule, and I have to give the exception its full weight and not treat it as a grudging footnote, because for some of my readers the exception is the whole ballgame, the difference between a book that helps them and a book that hurts them. There are churches you should leave. Leaving them is not a failure of faithfulness to the body of Christ. It is faithfulness to the body of Christ, precisely because a church that is destroying its members has stopped being the body of Christ in that place and started being something else that is using the body's name.

Let me draw the distinction as sharply as I can. A church you should stay in disappoints you. A church you should leave endangers you. The disappointing church fails to be all it should be, is mediocre and mixed and frustrating, wounds you through neglect and ordinary human failure and the general disappointing quality of institutions run by sinners. The dangerous church actively harms you, deploys its authority to control and diminish and trap you, treats your questions as rebellion and your conscience as the enemy, uses God as a lever against your own good, and closes the exits by teaching you that leaving is leaving

God. The first church is the normal church, the one every real Christian is called to stay in and love and suffer with and slowly help improve. The second church is not a harder version of the first. It is a different thing wearing the same clothes, and the discipline of faithful staying does not apply to it, any more than the discipline of faithful marriage applies to a hostage situation.

How do you tell which one you are in, when you are inside it and cannot see clearly and have been taught by the church itself to distrust your own perception? That last clause is the whole difficulty, because the dangerous church specifically disables the instrument you would use to detect it, teaching you that your unease is the flesh, that your desire to leave is rebellion, that your conscience is deceived and only the leadership can be trusted to interpret God's will for you. So I will offer a few tests that try to get underneath that disabling, and I offer them knowing that no list is foolproof and that you may need people outside the church to help you see, which is itself a tell, because a healthy church is not afraid of your outside relationships and a dangerous one works to sever them. Watch for whether questioning the leader is treated as questioning God. Watch for whether leaving is described as spiritual disaster, as coming out from under a covering, as putting yourself in danger. Watch for whether the church works to isolate you from anyone who might give you a different perspective. Watch for whether your worth in the community depends on your usefulness and your compliance. Watch, above all, for fear. A church held together by fear of what leaving would cost you is a church you should leave, and the fear itself is the evidence.

Jesus gives us the deepest test, and it is not a rule but a fruit, and I keep coming back to it because it cuts through every clever justification an abusive leader can offer. You will know them by

their fruits, he said. Not by their doctrine, which can be impeccable while the fruit is poison. Not by their size or their energy or their apparent spiritual power, all of which the dangerous church often has in abundance. By their fruits. So look at the fruit in the actual lives of the people who have been under this leadership for years. Are they becoming more free or more fearful, more loving or more anxious, more able to love the people outside the group or more suspicious of them, more themselves or more like carbon copies of the leader. Is the fruit of this church, in the people it has shaped, the fruit of the Spirit, which is love and joy and peace and patience and kindness, or is it a different spirit's fruit, which is fear and control and anxiety and the slow erasure of the self. The tree is known by what it produces in the people who eat from it, and if the people around you are being diminished rather than grown, you have your answer, whatever the doctrine on the sign out front.

But I have to guard the other side of this line too, because the danger runs in both directions, and I have watched people misuse the exception as thoroughly as the church misused the rule. There is a way of leaving that dresses up ordinary disappointment as abuse, that takes the normal friction of belonging to a real community and reframes it as harm in order to justify a departure that is really about not wanting to be bound to anyone, not wanting to be told anything hard, not wanting to submit to the ordinary discomforts of membership. The culture we live in is very good at teaching us to call every discomfort a wound and every authority an abuser and every obligation a form of oppression, and a person formed by that culture can experience the mildest accountability as violence and leave a perfectly ordinary church convinced they have escaped something terrible when they have really just fled the ordinary cost of belonging to anything. I say this carefully, because it is

the exact move the abusive church uses to keep its victims, telling them their real harm is just their flesh resisting accountability, and I do not want to hand that weapon back to the abusers. But the misuse is real, and pretending it is not real would be its own dishonesty.

So how do you tell your own ordinary disappointment from genuine danger, when both feel bad and both make you want to leave? I think the test is finally about what you are fleeing toward and what the fleeing does to your soul. The person leaving genuine danger is fleeing toward freedom, toward the possibility of loving God without a man standing between them, and though the leaving is terrifying and costly, on the far side of it something in them can breathe that could not breathe before. The person fleeing ordinary belonging is usually fleeing toward a sovereignty that will slowly starve them, toward the freedom of the severed hand, and though the leaving feels like liberation it tends to produce, over years, not a freer soul but a smaller and lonelier and more self-enclosed one, because they did not escape a prison, they escaped a body, and the body was the thing keeping them alive. You will not always be able to tell which you are doing in the moment. But you can watch the fruit of your own leaving over time, honestly, and the fruit will tell you, if you are willing to look, whether you fled a wolf or fled the flock.

And if it turns out you fled a wolf, hear this clearly before the chapter ends, because you have probably been told the opposite by people who should have protected you. You did not leave the body of Christ. You left a place that had stopped being the body of Christ and started devouring it. The guilt you carry, the fear that your leaving was rebellion, the voice that tells you that you have put yourself outside God's protection, is not the voice of God. It is the residue of the control, still running in you after you

got out, the way a prisoner's body keeps flinching after the guard is gone. The God you were reaching for the whole time was on the side of your escape, was in fact grieved by what was done to you in his name, was there in the parking lot when you finally walked out to your car shaking. Leaving that was not the end of your faith. It may have been the truest act of faith you had performed in years, the moment you refused to keep calling a wolf a shepherd. The body of Christ is still yours. It is just somewhere else, in some room you have not found yet, waiting, and it is not what hurt you, and it never was. Which brings us to the hardest question of all, harder than whether to leave, which is whether, after all of it, a person who was burned that badly could ever go back to any church at all, and what it would cost, and whether it would be worth it.

Chapter Sixteen: Coming Back After Being Burned

The scar tissue is not a lack of faith. It is the record of a real wound, and it deserves to be honored, not scolded.

There is a particular kind of person I have in mind for this chapter, and if it is you, you will know within a sentence or two. You are not casually dechurched. You did not drift out over a busy season and a change of address. You were burned, badly, in a way that left a mark, and the mark is still there, and it does something to your body when you walk past a church building or hear a certain kind of worship music or catch the particular cadence of a certain kind of preacher. Your nervous system learned something in that church, and what it learned was that these rooms are not safe, and no amount of theological argument reaches the place where that lesson lives, because it is not stored as an argument. It is stored as a flinch. And every book that tells you to just get back in a pew is speaking to your mind while ignoring your body, and your body is the one that left.

I am not going to tell you to get back in a pew. I want to say that plainly, at the top, because you have been braced for the ask since you picked up a book by a pastor, and I do not want you reading the rest of this chapter with your guard up waiting for the pivot. There is no pivot. If you never walk into a church building again, that is between you and God, and I am the last person who should be adding to the pile of religious authorities telling you what you owe. What I want to do instead is

something smaller and, I hope, more useful. I want to talk honestly about what coming back would actually involve, for someone in your specific condition, so that if you ever do want to try it, you go in with realistic expectations instead of the fantasy that either sets people up to fail or scares them off entirely. Coming back after being burned is a real thing that real people do, and it is nothing like the coming back that the unburned imagine.

The first thing to know is that the flinch is not going to disappear before you go, and waiting for it to disappear is a trap. People think they have to heal first and return second, that they need to arrive at a church already fine, and so they wait to stop flinching, and the flinch does not stop, because the flinch is a response to a real thing that really happened and it does not resolve in the abstract. The body learns safety by having safe experiences, not by thinking about them, which means, uncomfortably, that some of the healing can only happen on the other side of a door you are afraid to walk through, in small doses, with an exit always available. This is why coming back, for the burned, has to be done differently than for anyone else. Not a full plunge. Not a commitment. A single visit, sitting near the back, near the door, with permission you have given yourself in advance to walk out the moment your body says leave, and no shame attached to the walking out. You are not testing your faith. You are testing whether this particular room, these particular people, are safe, and your body gets a vote, and you are going to honor its vote, because last time no one did and that was part of the harm.

The second thing to know is that you are allowed to go slowly, invisibly, and without giving anything, and this will feel wrong because the church trained you to believe that belonging requires immediate output. In the church that burned you, your worth was

tied to your usefulness, and you were pulled into service and leadership and giving fast, before you were known, because the machine needed your labor. So the idea of going to a church and just sitting there, for months, giving nothing, joining nothing, letting no one assign you anything, will feel like freeloading, like you are doing church wrong. You are not. You are doing exactly the thing your damaged trust requires, which is to watch, from a safe distance, over a long enough time to see whether the fruit is good, whether the leader points away from himself, whether the not-okay people are welcome, whether anyone tries to rush you or use you or fold you into a machine. A healthy church will let you do this. It will let you sit at the back for a year, giving nothing, and it will not pressure you, because it is not running on your labor. The moment a church cannot tolerate you being a slow, watchful, non-producing observer, it has told you something important, and you can leave, and you have lost nothing.

The third thing, and this is the hardest, is that you will probably have to grieve before you can return, and the grief is for something bigger than the specific church. You are grieving the faith you had before you knew, the uncomplicated belonging, the trust you will never quite have again in exactly that form. Even in the best case, even if you find a genuinely good church and it genuinely heals you over years, you are not going back to who you were before the wound. That person is gone. The new person is warier, harder to fool, slower to trust, and, if the grief is allowed to finish its work, also deeper, more compassionate toward other wounded people, less naive, more like the doubters and the wrestlers among the saints than like the enthusiasts. The wound does not un-happen. But it can become, over time, not just damage but knowledge, the knowledge of what the church must never do, carried by someone who is now positioned to

make sure it does not do it again to someone else. The scar does not have to be only a scar. It can become a kind of authority, the authority of someone who has been to the bottom of it and come back and knows the terrain.

I have walked with people through this, and I want to tell you what it usually looks like when it goes well, because the successful version is quiet and slow and unspectacular and nothing like a testimony video. It does not look like a dramatic return, arms raised, tears flowing, all better. It looks like a person who visited a small church eight times over four months, sitting near the door, ready to bolt, and gradually noticed that their body was not flinching as hard, that the pastor kept getting out of the way, that an old woman had learned their name without demanding anything for it, that when they mentioned in passing the church that had hurt them, no one got defensive or explained it away, someone just said, that sounds like it was really bad, I am so sorry. It looks like, a year in, being surprised to find that they had somehow become one of the people who was there, not through a decision but through an accumulation of small safe experiences that slowly rebuilt something the flinch had torn down. It is not a comeback. It is a reconstruction, brick by careful brick, and the person doing it has every right to stop at any point and every right to take as long as it takes.

And if you never do it, I meant what I said. There is grace for the person who cannot go back, who tried and could not, whose wound was deep enough that the door stays closed for this life. I do not believe God stands at that closed door with his arms crossed, keeping score. I believe he is more likely to be found on your side of it, sitting with you in the parking lot, grieving with you what was done in his name, patient with a patience that outlasts your fear. The God who is the head of the body is not the

God who burned you, and if it takes you the rest of your life to feel the difference in your body rather than just know it in your mind, he has the rest of your life, and more. But I will say this one true thing and then let it go, no pressure attached, offered and not demanded. The body is still real. It is still out there, in some small quiet room you have not found, full of people who would receive you slowly and ask nothing and let you sit near the door for as long as you needed. It is not the thing that hurt you. It never was. And if you ever want it, it has been waiting, and it is not surprised by your fear, and it is not keeping score. Which raises the last great question this book has to face, the one underneath all the others. Given everything the church has done, why should we believe it will outlast its own failures at all. Why should we believe the body survives.

Chapter Seventeen: The Church That Buries Its Undertakers

The church has been dying for two thousand years, and it has buried every one of its undertakers, and this is not a triumphant fact but a strange and sobering one that I want to hold carefully, because it is easy to turn into cheap reassurance and it is not cheap. Every generation has produced confident men who announced the imminent end of Christianity, who read the signs of their moment and concluded that the faith was finished, that this was the crisis it would not survive, and every one of them died and was buried and the church walked away from the graveside and kept going. This is a historical fact, not a spiritual boast, and I offer it first as data, the way I offered the numbers of the leaving as data, because a person who has left the church deserves to have the full data set, not just the part that indicts and not just the part that consoles.

Voltaire, in the eighteenth century, is supposed to have predicted that Christianity would be gone within a hundred years, and the story, probably apocryphal but too good to lose, is that the house he wrote it in later became a depot for a Bible society. The specific tale may be legend, but the pattern it captures is not. The philosophers of the Enlightenment were confident that reason had retired religion, that the faith was a relic that would not survive contact with the modern mind, and the modern mind arrived, and the faith did not evaporate, it changed and contended and in places grew. The scientific triumphalists of the nineteenth century, the confident secular prophets who read Darwin and declared the God hypothesis dead, were sure they were watching

the last of it, and the twentieth century, which they thought would be godless, turned out to be one of the great centuries of Christian expansion in the history of the world, just not in the places they were looking. The undertakers keep being buried. The church keeps not staying dead. Something is going on here that the confident secular story cannot account for, and honesty requires the skeptic to sit with it rather than wave it away.

Here is the thing the death-of-the-church story keeps getting wrong, and it is a geographical mistake as much as a spiritual one. It reads the decline of the church in one time and place, its own, the modern West, and mistakes it for the condition of the church everywhere. But while the church has been shrinking in Europe and struggling in North America, it has been exploding across the global South, in Africa and Asia and Latin America, on a scale that has made the twenty-first century church younger, browner, poorer, and more Pentecostal than at any point in its history. The scholar Philip Jenkins documented this shift, the movement of Christianity's center of gravity out of the North Atlantic world it had occupied for centuries and into the global South, and the numbers are staggering. There are more Christians in church on a given Sunday in China than in all of Western Europe. The typical Christian in the world today is not a comfortable Westerner losing their faith. She is a young African or Asian woman, and there are more like her every year. The story that the church is dying is a story told by a small, aging, wealthy slice of the church that has confused its own decline with the fate of the whole, which is exactly the parochial mistake the communion of saints was supposed to cure.

I do not say this to gloat, because the numbers are not the point and never were, and a church that measures itself by its growth in the global South has learned nothing from what its growth in

the American suburbs cost it. I say it for one reason only, to break the spell of inevitability that hangs over the Western church-leaver, the sense that they are riding the obvious tide of history, that belief is simply over and they got out ahead of the curve, that the intelligent and the informed are all leaving and only the naive remain. That story feels true if you only look at your own zip code. It is false at the scale of the world and false at the scale of history. The faith is not a spent force being left behind by the enlightened. It is the largest and most diverse movement of human beings on the planet, growing fastest among exactly the poor and the marginalized and the suffering that its founder said it was for, and its retreat in one wealthy corner of the world is a local weather event, not the climate.

But I want to reach for something deeper than sociology, because the sociology could turn tomorrow and I do not want to rest the hope on a trend line. The reason the church buries its undertakers is not fundamentally demographic. It is theological, and it goes back to a promise. Jesus said, in the passage where he first names the church, that he would build it, and that the gates of hell would not prevail against it. Notice the structure of that promise, because it is more honest than we usually let it be. He does not promise that the church will be faithful. He does not promise it will avoid corruption, or resist the seduction of power, or protect the vulnerable as it should, or refrain from becoming, in a thousand times and places, a scandal and a wound. The history says plainly it did all of those bad things. What he promises is that it will not, finally, be destroyed, that the powers of death themselves will not manage to end it, that despite everything it does to discredit itself, the body will still be here. That is a much stranger and much darker and much more believable promise than the triumphalist version. It does not promise a church you can be proud of. It promises a church that

will not die, and the two are very different, and the second is the one the actual history delivers.

So the resilience of the church is not evidence of the church's goodness. I want to be very careful here, because this is exactly the place where the argument could go rotten, where a pastor could say, see, the church survives everything, therefore its survival proves God is with it, therefore stop complaining about its failures. That is a corrupt inference and I refuse it. The church's survival does not vindicate its failures. It does not mean the abuse did not matter or that the corruption was part of some plan. What the survival means is only this, that the failures, real and damning as they are, do not get the last word, that the body is held up by something other than the competence or virtue of its members, that it rests, as Bonhoeffer said, on Christ and not on us, which is the only reason it has not long since collapsed under the weight of what we have done to it. The church survives despite itself, not because of itself, and that despite is the whole gospel, the same despite by which any of us is saved, sinners held up by a grace we did not earn and constantly betray.

There is a comfort in this for the wounded, and it is a severe comfort, not a soft one, so let me end the chapter with it exactly as severe as it is. The church that hurt you will not have the last word, and neither will its failures, and neither, for that matter, will yours. The thing is bigger than any of its corruptions, older than any of its betrayals, and more durable than the very worst that has been done in its name, including the worst that was done to you. This does not make the wound acceptable. It makes the wound survivable. It means that the church you left, in its specific corruption, is a passing thing, a local and temporary disfigurement of a body that will outlast it, and that the body itself, the real one, the one held up by Christ, is going to be here

long after the men who wounded you are dust and their institutions are forgotten. You do not have to save it. That was never your job, and the burden of thinking you had to save it is part of what broke you. You only have to decide, someday, if you want to, whether you want to be part of the thing that is going to survive anyway, or watch it survive from the parking lot. Either way it survives. That is the strange and difficult and unearned promise, and it is the only ground I know solid enough to build a conclusion on. So let me try, in the last two chapters, to say what all of this finally comes to, and to leave you with the truth rather than the pitch.

Chapter Eighteen: The Membership of the Wounded

I have been building toward a single idea for this whole book without quite naming it, and it is time to name it, because it is the thing I actually believe and everything else has been clearing the ground for it. The church that will matter in the coming decades, the one worth returning to and worth building, is going to be built disproportionately by the wounded, by the very people the last version drove out, and this is not a tragedy to be managed but the oldest pattern in the whole story, the pattern by which God has always built his people, out of the broken and the burned and the ones who were sure they were finished. I want to spend this next-to-last chapter on that idea, because it changes what the wound means, and it changes what your leaving might yet become, and it is, I think, the most hopeful thing in the book, though it is a hard hope and not a soft one.

Start with who God actually builds with, in the Scriptures, because it is not who you would expect if you thought God recruited the way institutions recruit. He builds his people out of a stuttering murderer on the run from Egypt, out of a shepherd boy who becomes an adulterer and a murderer himself, out of a persecutor of the church who held the coats while they stoned the first martyr, out of fishermen who abandoned their master at the first sign of danger and a disciple who denied him three times before the rooster crowed. The pattern is so consistent it cannot be an accident. God does not build with the impressive and the unwounded. He builds with people who have been to the bottom of their own failure and God's apparent absence and come back

changed, because those are the only people who have anything real to offer, the only ones whose faith is not naive because it has been tested to destruction and survived. The unwounded believer has an untested faith and a shallow compassion. The one who has been through the fire has a faith that knows what it is worth and a compassion that has been paid for. God has always preferred the second kind, and the church that forgot this, that recruited the shiny and the successful and the useful, forgot the deepest thing about its own God.

Now apply that to the dechurched, to the burned, to the forty million. What if they are not the church's failure but its raw material. What if the very people who were wounded badly enough to leave are the people who know, better than anyone still comfortably inside, exactly what the church must never do again, who carry in their scars a precise knowledge of every way the thing goes wrong. A church rebuilt by people who were spiritually abused would guard against spiritual abuse with a vigilance no unwounded committee could ever manage, because they would recognize the early signs in their own bodies before any policy could catch them. A church rebuilt by people who were driven out by politics would smell the fusion of gospel and party from a mile off. A church rebuilt by people whose grief was treated as a scheduling problem would build a community that knew how to stay with suffering, because they would remember, in their own flesh, what it was to be edged toward the exit when they were not okay. The wound is not just damage. It is expertise. It is the exact knowledge the next church needs most, held by the exact people the last church threw away.

This is not a sentimental idea and I do not want it heard as one, so let me put the cost on it. Being rebuilt from your wound is not the same as being healed of it, and it is much harder, and it

happens later, and it can only happen after the grief has done its slow work. A person still bleeding from a church wound cannot yet build anything, and should not be asked to, and any pastor who rushes a wounded person into rebuilding is committing a fresh version of the original sin, using them again, extracting their labor before they are whole. The membership of the wounded is a thing that becomes possible on the far side of grief, not instead of it. It is what the scar can become, in time, if it is given time, not what the open wound is asked to do while it is still open. So I am not telling the freshly burned to go build a church. I am telling them what their pain might yet become, someday, if they want it to, so that they do not have to believe the pain is only loss, only damage, only the end of something. It might be, in time, the beginning of something, and the something might be the very thing they wish had existed when they needed it.

There is a doctrine buried in the early church that speaks to this, though it has to be handled with great care because it has been misused as a bludgeon, and I have avoided it until now for exactly that reason. Cyprian of Carthage, in the third century, wrote that there is no salvation outside the church, and the sentence has been swung like a weapon ever since, used to frighten the doubting and trap the departing and tell the wounded that leaving the institution meant leaving God. That is a corruption of what he meant, and I will not use it that way. Cyprian was not talking about a membership roll or a building or an institution you could be threatened with. He was writing during a brutal persecution, watching the question of what held Christians together when the whole world was trying to tear them apart, and his point was that the Christian life is not a solo heroism, that you cannot be a Christian by yourself against the world, that salvation comes to you inside a people or it does not

come as the New Testament describes it at all. Read that way, against its later abuse, Cyprian is saying exactly what this whole book has been saying. Not that the institution has a monopoly on God. That the faith is a shared life, and a Christianity practiced in total isolation from the body has quietly become a different thing, and you cannot have the head while permanently refusing every hand and foot.

So the wounded are not outside salvation for having left a corrupt church, and anyone who tells them so is wielding Cyprian as a weapon exactly as Cyprian would have hated. But the wounded are being called, gently and without threat, back into some form of the shared life, not necessarily the one that hurt them, not on any timeline but their own, but back into the membership, the body, the company of others, because that is where the life the gospel describes actually happens and there is no private version that is the same thing. And the astonishing possibility, the one I want to leave standing at the end of this chapter, is that when they come back, if they come back, they will not come back as patients to be healed by a healthy church. They will come back as the ones who know, the veterans, the scarred experts, the people uniquely equipped to build the church that will not repeat the sins that broke them. The last will be first. The rejected stone will be the cornerstone. The membership of the wounded is not the church's consolation prize. It may be the church's future, and it may be the truest thing the body of Christ has ever been, a body visibly made of broken and mended parts, which is, after all, exactly what its risen Lord still is, a body that kept its scars. Which is where I want to end. Not with a strategy. With the scars, and what they mean, and the weight I promised from the beginning I would leave you carrying rather than lift.

Chapter Nineteen: The Loneliness the Church Was Supposed to Cure

Before I write the conclusion, I have to go back and pick up a thread I dropped early, because it runs underneath everything and I have not given it its due. The thread is loneliness, the specific epidemic loneliness of the world we now live in, and the way the church was supposed to be the one institution standing against it and instead became, for many people, one more machine that left them alone in a crowd. I dropped the thread on purpose in the early chapters, because I did not want to reach for it too soon, did not want to seem to be selling the church as a cure for loneliness the way the market church sells everything, as a product that meets a felt need. But the thread has to be picked up now, honestly, because the loneliness is real and it is killing people and the church's failure to address it is one of the deepest reasons the leaving cost so much.

Consider the shape of the world a person walks out into when they leave the church, because it is not the world of a generation ago, and the difference matters enormously. The sociologist Robert Putnam, in his study of American civic life published in 2000, documented the collapse of the associations that used to hold people together, the clubs and lodges and leagues and unions and, yes, the churches, the whole dense web of belonging that a person used to be born into and live inside. He called the book *Bowling Alone*, after the fact that Americans were still bowling but had stopped bowling in leagues, were doing alone the things they used to do together. The church was one of the last and largest of these associations, one of the last places where

a person was known across the length of their life, where the same people saw them married and buried, where belonging did not have to be earned or curated or maintained but simply came with showing up. And when a person leaves the church now, they very often are not leaving one association among many. They are leaving the last one they had.

This is the piece the confident church-leaver sometimes does not see coming, and I say it not as a threat but as a warning offered in good faith, the way you would warn a friend. You can leave a bad church for excellent reasons and walk out into a life that has no other place in it where you are known, where anyone would notice your absence, where you belong without having to perform belonging. The wider culture has no replacement to offer. It has the gym, which knows your credit card. It has social media, which knows your data and sells your attention and leaves you lonelier than before. It has the workplace, which will replace you within a month of your death. It has, increasingly, nothing, a great scattered aloneness dressed up as freedom, and the person who leaves the church over its real failures can find themselves, five years on, aching for a kind of belonging that no longer exists anywhere they can reach, because the church was the last institution that even attempted it and they left it and did not notice they were leaving the only game in town.

I want to be careful, because this can sound like a threat, come back or be lonely forever, and that is exactly the manipulation I promised not to commit. So let me be precise about what I am and am not saying. I am not saying you should return to a harmful church to escape loneliness, because that trades one kind of death for another and I would never counsel it. I am not saying the church is the only possible source of human belonging, because that is false and it is the kind of overclaim

that got us into trouble. What I am saying is more modest and more true. The church, at its best, offered a specific and increasingly rare kind of belonging, the belonging of being known over time by people you did not choose and would not have chosen, and this specific kind of belonging is the one the modern world is worst at replacing, and a person who leaves it should at least count the cost clearly, should know what they are walking away from, so that if they walk away anyway they do it with open eyes and not with the fantasy that the culture has something equivalent waiting.

Here is what the church has that the substitutes do not, and it is the thing Wendell Berry kept pointing at, the thing that makes the difference between a network and a membership. A network is made of weak ties you maintain for what they give you, and when they stop giving you something you let them lapse, and that is fine, that is what networks are for. A membership is made of strong ties you cannot let lapse, ties of obligation and history and mutual need, ties that hold you when you have nothing to offer and would have been dropped from any network. The church, at its best, is a membership in Berry's sense, a body that is stuck with you, that carries you when you are useless, that shows up at the hospital and the graveside and the divorce not because you are giving them anything but because you are one of them and that is what members do. This is precisely what the market church destroyed by turning members into customers, and it is precisely what the wider culture cannot offer at all, and it is precisely what the lonely modern person is starving for without having a name for it. The name is membership. The place it was supposed to live is the church. And the church mostly stopped offering it, which is a large part of why the leaving hurt so much and the aftermath hurts even more.

I have watched the loneliness on both sides of the church door, and I want to testify to what I have seen, because it complicates the easy story in both directions. I have seen people trapped in churches, lonely in the pew, surrounded by hundreds and known by no one, performing belonging every Sunday and driving home in silence, and their loneliness inside the church was as real as any loneliness outside it, and I will not pretend the church cured a loneliness it was actively causing. And I have seen people who left, who were right to leave, slowly discover a loneliness on the outside that they had not anticipated, a quiet erosion of belonging that no amount of freedom made up for, and I have watched some of them ache for years for a body they could not bring themselves to trust again. Both are true. The church can be the loneliest place in a person's life, and the absence of the church can be lonelier still, and the answer is not a slogan in either direction. The answer, if there is one, is the slow rebuilding of the kind of church that actually cures loneliness instead of causing it, the membership of the wounded I described, a body small enough and honest enough and unhurried enough to know your name and carry your weight, and that church has to be built, because it mostly does not exist, and the people best equipped to build it are the very ones who know most precisely how the loneliness feels.

So the loneliness is not an argument, exactly, and I do not want to use it as one. It is a fact, a heavy one, and I am laying it on the table next to all the other facts, the abuse and the hypocrisy and the politics and the shallowness, so that the whole picture is in front of you and not just the part that condemns the church. The church failed at the one thing it was best positioned to do, which was to be the place where no one had to be alone, and its failure is real and it drove people out. And the world those people walked into is a world with a hole in it exactly the shape of the

thing the church stopped providing, and the hole is not filling on its own, and the substitutes are not working, and a great many people on both sides of the church door are lonely in a way human beings are not built to survive. That is the true state of things. The church caused some of it and the church could heal some of it and the church mostly is not, and into that gap I can only put the vision of what a real body would be, and the promise that it is worth building, and the weight of knowing how much it costs that we have not built it. That weight is where I want to end. Let me try, finally, to gather all of it into a conclusion.

Chapter Twenty: The Table in the Ruins

I promised at the start that I would not end with an altar call, and I am not going to break that promise in the last chapter before the conclusion, but I do owe you a picture, something concrete to set against all the abstraction, because I have spent a whole book making arguments and you deserve to see the thing the arguments are pointing at, in the flesh, in a room. So let me tell you about a table, an ordinary one, in an ordinary and unimpressive church, because it is the truest image I have of what I have been trying to say, and it is the image I want you to carry out of this book instead of a proposition.

The church is small, the kind of church that would never make the news for anything good or bad, eighty people in a building built for four hundred, exactly the kind of church I described counting the empty seats at the start. The pastor is not impressive. He is not a bad preacher and he is not a good one, he is a working man doing a job he loves and is not especially gifted for, and the church runs not on his charisma, of which he has little, but on the accumulated weight of years of people carrying each other. On the first Sunday of the month they take communion, and they do it the old slow way, coming forward, and I have stood and watched the line, and the line is the whole gospel, if you have eyes to see it, which most of us do not because it is too ordinary to look holy.

Here is who is in the line. There is a woman near the front whose husband left her twenty years ago and who has been carried by

this church through every one of those twenty years, and there is, three people back, the couple who took her in for a season when she could not pay her rent. There is a man who was, everyone knows, a drunk for most of his life, and who has been sober for eleven years, and the men on either side of him in the line are the ones who sat up with him through the worst of it. There is a teenager who does not want to be there, dragged by parents, and there is behind him an old man who was dragged there himself sixty years ago and did not want to be there either, and who now cannot imagine his life without it. There is a family whose child died, and there is, in that same line, every person who brought them a meal and sat in their silence and did not try to fix it and did not edge them toward the exit when their grief ran past its socially acceptable length. They are all in one line, moving slowly toward one table, to receive one bread, and Paul's sentence is not a metaphor in that room, it is a description. Because there is one bread, we who are many are one body.

Now here is the thing I want you to see, the thing that took me years to see because I was looking for an impressive church and kept missing the real one. That line contains every failure I have named in this book. Someone in that line was wounded by a church and barely made it back. Someone in that line holds political convictions that would horrify the person in front of them, and they are taking the same bread anyway, from the same hands. Someone in that line has been gossiped about by someone else in that line, and they have forgiven each other, badly and incompletely and more than once, and they are still both in the line. The church in that room is not pure. It is not the church worth returning to that I sketched in the abstract, it is the ordinary disappointing mixed real church, full of exactly the sins that drove people out of churches everywhere. And yet it is a body. The bread makes it a body. Not the purity, which it does

not have, but the shared table, the one loaf, the coming forward together with empty hands. It is a body of the wounded, feeding on the wounds of Christ, becoming what they eat.

I have come to think that this is what the church actually is, underneath all the buildings and brands and blocs and all the machinery that failed you, and that the reason we cannot see it is that we keep looking for it in the impressive places where it is not, in the successful churches and the powerful movements and the men with the platforms, when it has been all along in the slow line of broken people coming forward to a table in a half-empty room. The powerful church, the growing church, the influential church, was mostly a distraction and often a corruption, and it is dying now, and good. What is not dying, what has never once died in two thousand years of undertakers, is the table in the ruins, the small stubborn gathering of the wounded around the bread, which is where the body actually lives and always has, which the powers of death have never managed to end because it was never resting on anything the powers of death could reach. It rests on Christ. It rests on the one loaf. It rests on a promise older than any church that failed you.

So I am not going to ask you to come back. I am going to do something else. I am going to tell you that the table is still there, in some small half-empty room near you, with a slow line of broken people moving toward it, and that the line has a gap in it exactly your size, and that no one is going to drag you into it or threaten you if you stay away, and that the bread will be there whether you come or not, because it does not depend on you, it depends on Christ, and Christ has been setting that table in the ruins of failed churches for two thousand years and he is not going to stop now. You left a building. You left a brand. You left a bloc and a machine and, some of you, a wolf. You were right to

leave all of it. But the table you cannot leave, because the table is not the thing that hurt you, the table is the thing the thing that hurt you was pretending to be, and it is still there, in the ruins, waiting, patient, unhurried, with your gap in the line. That is not a demand. It is just the truth, and I have spent a whole book earning the right to say it plainly, and now I have said it, and the rest is between you and the one who set the table. Let me close.

Chapter Twenty-One: The Shallowness That Starved You

I have named the dramatic failures, the abuse and the politics and the cover-ups, because they are the ones that make the news and break the bones, and I do not want to minimize them. But there is a quieter failure that emptied more seats than any scandal, and it almost never gets named because there is no villain in it, no predator to expose, no headline to write. It is the failure of shallowness, the slow starvation of people who came to the church genuinely hungry for God and were fed, week after week, a thin gruel of tips and encouragement and mild uplift, and who left not because they were wounded but because they were bored, and who felt guilty about leaving because boredom seems like such a small and shameful reason next to abuse, and who could not shake the sense that their boredom was actually a form of hunger the church had failed to feed.

Let me describe the gruel precisely, because if I am vague you will not recognize it, and it is important that you recognize it, because you may have been starved by it without knowing that was what happened. The gruel is the sermon that takes a passage of the deepest and strangest book in human history and reduces it to three practical steps for a better week. It is the worship that generates a reliable emotional swell through musical technique and calls the swell the presence of God. It is the small group that never gets past the surface because no one has been given permission or language or courage to go deeper. It is the entire apparatus of a Christianity engineered to be accessible, relevant, and easy, stripped of everything difficult and strange and

demanding, until what remains is a mild therapeutic religion that asks nothing, costs nothing, and, it turns out, gives nothing, because a faith that asks nothing cannot give anything, the two being the same transaction viewed from opposite ends.

The sociologist Christian Smith gave this folk religion a name after studying what American teenagers actually believed, as opposed to what their churches thought they were teaching. He called it moralistic therapeutic deism, and the name is worth sitting with because it is exact. Moralistic, because its core teaching is that you should be a good and nice person. Therapeutic, because the point of religion is to feel good about yourself and be happy. Deism, because God is a distant manager who wants you to be happy and stays out of the way except when you need him to solve a problem. This, Smith found, was the actual operative faith of most American young people raised in the church, and here is the devastating part. They did not learn it from the world. They learned it in the church. It was the residue of what they had actually been taught, the gruel distilled to its essence, and it is a faith so thin that it cannot survive a single real crisis, cannot bear the weight of a Tuesday afternoon let alone a funeral, and the young people formed by it left in droves, and who could blame them, because they were leaving something that was not worth staying for, a religion of niceness with a distant God, and they were right that it was not worth their lives.

The tragedy, the specific and bitter tragedy, is that the church has, sitting right there in its own tradition, unopened, the deepest and richest treasure of thought and beauty and difficulty that human beings have ever assembled, and it fed people gruel while the feast sat in the next room. Two thousand years of the most serious minds who ever lived wrestling with the ultimate

questions. Augustine on time and memory and the restless heart. Aquinas building a cathedral of thought so vast it takes a lifetime to walk through. The mystics who went into the dark and came back with maps. The whole tradition of contemplation and lament and wrestling and awe. It was all there, all available, all belonging to the very people who were being handed three steps to a better marriage, and the church did not open the treasure because the treasure was hard and the market wanted easy, and so people who were starving for depth in a room that contained infinite depth were fed the thinnest thing on offer and concluded, understandably, that the room was empty. It was not empty. It was full. But the fullness was locked away behind an accessibility that had been mistaken for a virtue, and the hungry left, and the treasure stayed locked, and this may be the saddest failure of all because it is the one that was most needless.

I bear this failure personally and I want to name my part in it, because the temptation to preach the gruel is immense and I have not always resisted it. There is enormous pressure on a pastor to be accessible, to meet people where they are, to not go over their heads, to keep it practical, and this pressure comes dressed as love, as concern for the ordinary person who does not have a seminary degree. And there is a real love in it, I do not want to sneer at the impulse to be understood. But it curdles, and it curdled in me for a while, into a habit of underestimating my people, of assuming they could not handle the depth, of feeding them what was easy because it was easier for me too, easier to prepare and easier to deliver and easier to be liked for. And the whole time there were people in my pews starving, people capable of far more than I was giving them, people who wanted to be taken seriously as thinkers and strugglers and were instead being handed a devotional pat on the head. Some of them left. They were hungry, and I fed them gruel, and they went looking

for a meal, and I told myself they had lost interest in the things of God when in fact they had lost interest in the thin thing I had substituted for the things of God, and the difference is everything.

So if you left because you were bored, because it all seemed shallow, because you could not shake the feeling that there had to be more to this than the mild uplift you were being served, I want to tell you something that may reframe your whole leaving. Your boredom was not a spiritual failure. It was spiritual health. It was your soul, made for the deep things, refusing to pretend the shallow things were enough. The hunger you felt was the truest thing about you, and the church that could not feed it failed you, and the God you were actually hungry for is not the distant manager of the therapeutic gruel but the consuming fire of the actual tradition, the God who is not safe but is good, the God who calls you not to a better week but to your own death and resurrection. That God is in the treasure the church kept locked. He was never in the gruel, which is why the gruel could not satisfy you, which is why you left. You were right to leave the gruel. Do not make the mistake of thinking the gruel was the meal. The meal is still there, in the locked room, and it is worth breaking the lock for, and no one is standing at the door of the tradition checking your credentials, and the deepest things the church has to offer have been waiting for a hungry person like you the whole time.

There is a reconstruction available here that is different from the one the abused need, and I want to name it for the starved specifically, because it is often overlooked. The starved do not need, first, to heal from harm. They need, first, to be handed the depth that was withheld, the real theology, the hard books, the serious tradition, the difficult and beautiful thing itself. Many of them, when they finally encounter the depth, are astonished and

a little angry, because they realize it was theirs all along and was kept from them, and the anger is legitimate, and it can turn into a hunger that drives them deeper than the comfortable ever go. Some of the most serious Christians I know now are former bored church-leavers who went looking for the meal after they gave up on the gruel and found, to their shock, that the meal existed, that Christianity was not the thin thing they had left but an ocean they had been shown a puddle of. The reconstruction for the starved is not therapy. It is depth, finally offered, the feast unlocked, and it is one of the great joys of ministry to watch a starved person taste the real thing for the first time and understand that they were never leaving God, they were leaving a starvation ration served in God's name.

Chapter Twenty-Two: The God Who Has a Body

I have made a great many arguments in this book about why the church matters, and most of them have been, in a sense, arguments from below, from what human beings need and what the New Testament assumes and what the tradition teaches. But there is a deeper argument, an argument from above, that I have been circling without landing on, and it is time to land on it, because it is the ground the whole thing finally rests on. The reason the church is not optional is not primarily that human beings need community, true as that is. The reason is that God has a body, that the God of Christianity is a God who took on flesh and refuses to be met apart from flesh, and that the church is the form that flesh now takes in the world. To want a churchless Christianity is, at the deepest level, to want a disembodied God, and the God of Christianity is precisely the God who will not be disembodied, who insisted on a body at Bethlehem and insists on one still.

Start with the scandal at the center of the faith, the one that the church-leaver and the church-attender alike tend to skate over because it is so familiar it has stopped being strange. The Christian claim is not that God sent a message, or a teaching, or a set of principles, or a spiritual experience available to the private soul. The Christian claim is that God became a human being, took on a specific body in a specific place at a specific time, was born of a woman, ate and drank and wept and bled and died, and this is the most anti-spiritual religious claim ever made, in the sense that it refuses to let God be a purely spiritual reality

accessible apart from the material world. The other religions and philosophies mostly move upward, away from the body, toward the pure spirit, the escape from matter, the soul's ascent to the immaterial. Christianity moves the opposite direction. God comes down, into matter, into a body, and stays there, and is raised bodily, and ascends bodily, and will return bodily, and the whole thing is stubbornly, scandalously, offensively physical from beginning to end.

And this matters enormously for the question of the church, because the church is not an afterthought to the incarnation, a human organization that formed around the memory of Jesus after he left. The church is, in Paul's astonishing claim, the continuation of the incarnation, the body of Christ, the way the incarnate God continues to have a physical presence in the world after the ascension. When Paul persecuted the church and was struck down on the road to Damascus, the voice did not say why are you persecuting my followers, or my organization, or my teaching. It said why are you persecuting me. Saul was attacking the church, and the risen Christ experienced the attack on the church as an attack on his own body, because that is what the church is to him, his body, the physical form his presence takes now, so that to touch the church is to touch him. This is either a wild overstatement or it is the deepest truth about what the church is, and the whole New Testament treats it as the second, and if it is the second then a Christianity that discards the church is trying to have Christ without his body, which is trying to have a ghost.

I said early in this book that the New Testament does not know what to do with a solitary Christian, and I gave the grammatical reason, the plural commands, the one-another instructions. But the incarnational reason is deeper than the grammatical one. The

reason you cannot have Christ without his body is not merely that the commands require others. It is that Christ himself now has a body, and it is the church, and you meet him in it the way you meet any embodied person, in the flesh, in the particular, in the awkward physical reality of other people, and not in the pure spiritual abstraction the modern soul would prefer. The modern person wants a spiritual relationship with a spiritual Christ, private, internal, unmediated by the messy bodies of other believers, and Christianity keeps refusing to grant it, keeps insisting that the way to the head is through the body, that you cannot love the Christ you cannot see while refusing the brother you can see, that the whole thing is embarrassingly, insistently physical, a matter of bread and wine and water and the laying on of hands and the actual bodies of actual people in an actual room.

There is a reason this offends us, and it is worth naming, because the offense is the same offense the incarnation has always caused. We would prefer a God we could meet in private, on our own terms, in the clean space of our own interiority, uncontaminated by the compromises and failures and sheer bother of other people. That God would be so much more manageable. That God would never embarrass us, never disappoint us, never require us to sit next to someone we cannot stand and call them brother. And Christianity keeps taking that clean private God away from us and handing us instead this God with a body, this God who comes to us in the least manageable possible form, in the church, in the difficult others, in the very bodies we would rather be free of. The incarnation is God's permanent refusal to be spiritual in the way we want him to be spiritual, and the church is the ongoing form of that refusal, and the church-leaver who wants Christ without the church is, underneath all the legitimate grievances, wanting the one thing the incarnate God will not give, a way to him that does not pass

through the bodies of his people.

I want to be careful here, because this argument could be used cruelly, could be turned into a bludgeon against the wounded, you must return to the body or you cannot have Christ, and I have spent too much of this book guarding against exactly that to abandon the guard now. So let me say clearly what this does and does not mean. It does not mean the wounded must return to the specific body that harmed them. The body of Christ is larger than any congregation, and to flee a wolf is not to flee the body. It does not mean that Christ abandons the isolated believer, because Christ is more faithful than that and meets people in deserts and prisons and hospital beds where no church can reach. What it does mean is that the isolated condition is not the goal, not the mature form of faith, not a purer spirituality than the embodied kind, but a wound, a severance, a hand cut off from the body it belongs to, and that the healing of the wound is reattachment, in time, to some body, somewhere, when it becomes possible. The incarnation sets the direction of travel. It says that the fullness of Christ is found in his body, and that a faith moving toward that fullness is moving toward the body, not away from it, however long the road and however wounded the traveler.

So the deepest answer to why the church matters is not sociological and not even ethical. It is that God has a body, and the church is it, and you cannot have the head without the body because the head has joined himself to the body so completely that he experiences its wounds as his own. The church that hurt you hurt him too, in his own body, and he felt it, which is a stranger and more comforting thought than we usually let it be. And the church that will heal you, if you let it, will be his body too, and to be received back into it will be to be received back into him, in the flesh, in the particular, at the table, among the

difficult others, which is the only place the incarnate God has ever finally been found. Not in the clean private interior. In the body. In the ruins where the body gathers. In the bread. That is where he is, because that is where he chose to be, and he has not changed his mind, and he is not going to.

Chapter Twenty-Three: What I Owe the People I Drove Out

I have confessed, in pieces, throughout this book, and I have tried to keep the confession specific rather than performing a general pastoral humility that costs nothing. But I have not yet done the thing that honesty finally requires, which is to gather the confession into one place and let it stand undefended, and I owe that to you before I close, because a book that spends its length telling the church to tell the truth about itself has no standing if its author will not do the same about himself. So this chapter is that. Not a device. An account. The people I drove out, named as clearly as I can name them without violating their privacy, and what I owe them, and what I have learned to do with a debt I can never fully repay.

There was the woman I told you about early, in the chapter on the empty seats, the one whose cruel husband I sent her back to with a sermon about covenant. I have thought about her for years. I know now that what I did was not pastoral care, it was theological malpractice, that I took a real and living person in real danger and sacrificed her to the beauty of an abstraction I was proud of, and that my pride in my tight theology of marriage was the exact thing that made me useless to her, because a theology you are proud of is a theology you will defend at the cost of the person in front of you. I do not know where she is. I have prayed that she found safety, that she found people who saw her, that she found, somewhere, a church that did not do to her what I did. And I have had to make peace with the fact that I will probably never be able to tell her I was wrong, that the

repair I owe her is a repair I may never get to make, and that the only thing I can do with that debt is let it change how I treat the next woman who comes to me in that danger, which I have, which is not nearly enough, but is the only currency I have to pay a debt to someone I cannot find.

There was the man I asked to leave quietly, whose story I decided the congregation did not need, and the members who knew the truth and watched me choose the smooth surface over the honest mess. I told you about them in the chapter on credibility. What I owe them is an admission I have made to some of them and not to others, that I protected the institution and called it protecting people, that I taught them by my choice that our church would choose its reputation every time, and that at least one of them left over my cover rather than the original sin, and was right to. I have gone back to the ones I could find. I have said the words. I have not gotten all of them back, and I do not think getting them back is the point, and I have had to learn that a confession offered to get someone back is not a confession, it is a transaction, and they can smell it, and the only confession worth anything is the one you offer with no expectation of return, because it is simply true and they are simply owed it.

And there are the ones I cannot name because I do not know I harmed them, the people who sat in my pews starving on the gruel I preached, who left bored and guilty and never told me why, who I wrote off as having drifted or lost interest when in fact I had failed to feed them. These are the hardest, because there is no specific face to repent toward, only a general and probably large category of people I underestimated and underfed and lost without ever knowing I was losing them or why. What I owe them I cannot pay to them, because I do not know who they

are. I can only pay it forward, by refusing, now, to underestimate the people still in front of me, by taking them seriously as thinkers and strugglers, by unlocking the treasure I once kept locked, by trusting that they can handle the depth and being willing to be less liked for offering it. That is the only repayment available for a debt owed to people whose names I never learned, and it is insufficient, and it is what I have.

I want to say something about what this kind of accounting does to a person, because I think it matters for anyone, pastor or not, who is trying to reckon honestly with harm they have done. It would be easier not to do it. It would be easier to keep the confession general, to say I am a sinner like everyone, to let the specifics blur into a comfortable haze of universal human imperfection, and to get on with feeling basically alright about myself. The specific accounting is worse. It keeps particular faces in front of me, particular rooms, particular sentences I actually said, and it does not let me feel basically alright. But I have come to believe that the specific accounting is the only kind that heals anything, in me or in anyone, because grace that is offered to a general sinner is a general grace that changes nothing, and grace that is offered to a man holding the specific memory of the specific woman he sent back to danger is a grace that has something actual to forgive, and can therefore actually be received, and can therefore actually remake the man. Bonhoeffer said sin wants to remain unknown, wants the dark, wants the general blur where it cannot be seen. The specific accounting drags it into the light, and the light is terrible, and the light is the only place forgiveness has ever happened.

Here is why I am telling you all of this in a book, rather than keeping it in the private space where a decent man keeps his failures. I am telling you because you, the reader who was driven

out, have almost never heard a pastor do this. You have heard pastors defend the church, explain the church, minimize what the church did, reframe your wound as your weakness. You have very rarely heard one simply say, without defense, I did this, I drove people out, I owe them a debt I cannot fully pay, and I am sorry, in the specific rather than the general, about actual people and actual harm. And I think that the absence of this, the near-total absence of specific pastoral confession, is one of the reasons the wound has festered, because a wound cannot begin to heal while the one who caused it insists on defending the causing. So I am doing the thing, in public, imperfectly, as one representative of a class of men who mostly will not do it, in the hope that hearing even one of us do it might loosen something, might make it a degree more possible to believe that the church could someday become the kind of thing that tells the truth about itself, because here is one of its ministers trying to.

I do not offer this confession as a down payment on your return. That would corrupt it, and you would be right to distrust it. I offer it because it is true and because you are owed it, the way the woman I could not find is owed it, the way the starving I never named are owed it. If it moves you an inch toward the body, I will be glad, but that is not why I did it. I did it because a book that asks the church to tell the truth has to be written by a man willing to tell it first, about himself, in the specific, undefended, with the faces still in front of him. That is the debt I owe the people I drove out, and this book, this chapter, this undefended account, is one small payment on it, and it is not enough, and it is what I have, and I am laying it down now, in the light, where sin does not want to be, which is exactly why it belongs there.

Chapter Twenty-Four: The Difference Between Deconstruction and Demolition

There is a word that has organized a great deal of the leaving of the last decade, and it is worth stopping on, because it names something real and also, in the way of words that spread fast, has come to mean several different things that need separating. The word is deconstruction. It arrived in the church from philosophy, where it meant something technical, and it has come to mean, in ordinary usage, the process by which a person takes apart the faith they were handed, examines its pieces, and decides which ones, if any, they can still believe. And the church's response to this has been almost entirely one of alarm, deconstruction treated as a synonym for apostasy, as the on-ramp to leaving, as a danger to be prevented, and I think the alarm has been both wrong and revealing, wrong about what deconstruction is and revealing about why the church cannot handle it.

Let me say first that deconstruction, in itself, is not the enemy the church has made it out to be, and the church's inability to see this is one more symptom of the shallowness I named earlier. The examined faith is not a lesser faith. It is, in the long tradition, the only kind of mature faith there is. Every serious believer in the history of the church has, at some point, taken the inherited thing apart and looked at its pieces, because a faith you have never examined is not yet yours, it is your parents', or your culture's, and it will not hold your weight when the weight comes. The alarm the church feels at deconstruction is, at

bottom, the alarm of a system that was running on unexamined inheritance and correctly senses that examination threatens it. But examination only threatens a faith that could not survive being examined, which is to say a false or shallow or idolatrous faith, and a church confident in the truth of what it holds should welcome examination, not fear it, because the truth has nothing to lose from being looked at closely and the idol has everything to lose.

So I want to defend deconstruction, up to a point, and then name precisely where I think it goes wrong, because both halves matter. The defense is this. When a person takes apart the faith they were handed and finds that a great deal of it was not the gospel at all but the culture, the politics, the control, the shallowness, the idols wearing Christ's face, and when they throw those pieces away, they are not committing apostasy. They are doing exactly what the prophets did, what the reformers did, what every renewal movement in the history of the church did, taking apart a corrupted version to get at the true thing underneath. The person deconstructing a nationalist Christianity, a therapeutic Christianity, a Christianity of control, is doing holy work, is tearing down an idol, and the church that calls this apostasy is defending the idol. Much of what gets called deconstruction is really the removal of things that should never have been attached to the faith in the first place, and it is a purification, and the church should be helping rather than resisting, should be handing people the tools rather than confiscating them.

Here is where it goes wrong, and this is the distinction the whole chapter turns on, so let me make it as sharp as I can. There is a difference between deconstruction and demolition, and the difference is what you do after you have taken the thing apart.

Deconstruction, rightly understood, takes the faith apart in order to find and rebuild on what is true underneath, to separate the gospel from the idols and keep the gospel. Demolition takes the faith apart and stops, leaves the pieces on the ground, walks away, and calls the pile of rubble a liberation. And I understand the appeal of stopping, because taking things apart is exhilarating and rebuilding is hard, and because once you have seen through the idols it is tempting to conclude that there was never anything but idols, that the whole thing was rotten all the way down, that under the false Christ there is no true one. But that conclusion is not earned by the deconstruction. It is a separate claim, a leap, and it is usually made not because the person examined the deep tradition and found it empty but because they examined the shallow version they were handed and, having found that empty, assumed there was nothing deeper, which is precisely the mistake the shallowness set them up to make.

The tragedy of much modern deconstruction is that it stops at exactly the moment the real work could begin. The person tears down the nationalist idol, the therapeutic idol, the idol of control, and stands amid the rubble, and this is precisely the point at which the deep tradition, the creedal faith, the two thousand years of tested wisdom, becomes available for the first time, cleared of the debris that was hiding it. But they do not go looking, because they have been taught that the rubble was the whole building, that there is nothing underneath, that Christianity just is the shallow corrupt version they took apart. And so they walk away from a foundation they never knew was there, having demolished the false building and never discovered the true one it was built on top of, and they call this leaving the faith when it is really leaving a counterfeit while never once meeting the original. The saddest sentence I hear from the

deconstructed is some version of, I looked into it and there was nothing there. And I want to say, gently, you looked into the version you were handed, and you were right that there was nothing there, but you did not look into the thing itself, because no one ever showed you the thing itself, they only ever showed you the counterfeit, and you cannot conclude the currency is fake from having examined a forgery.

Rowan Williams has written that the health of a tradition is shown precisely in its capacity to criticize itself, to contain within itself the resources for its own reformation, and that a tradition which cannot be questioned is already dead, already an idol, because only idols demand to be beyond question. This means that the deconstructing believer, far from being the tradition's enemy, may be functioning as the tradition's own immune system, the mechanism by which it clears out its corruptions and renews itself. The church needs its deconstructors. It has always needed them. The reformers were deconstructors. The prophets were deconstructors. The mistake is not the deconstruction. The mistake is the demolition, the stopping, the failure to complete the movement by rebuilding on the foundation the deconstruction uncovered, and that failure is as often the church's fault as the leaver's, because the church, having taught the shallow version, never showed them there was anything to rebuild with.

So to the deconstructed I want to say two things, and they are in tension and both are true. The first is that your deconstruction was probably holy, that you were right to take apart the idols, that the church should have helped you rather than calling you an apostate, and that a great deal of what you tore down deserved tearing down and its removal was a purification and not a loss. The second is that you are standing, right now, at the most

important moment, the moment after the demolition, and that the question of whether this becomes reconstruction or stays demolition is the whole question, and that the deep tradition is available to you now in a way it never was before, cleared of the debris, and that before you conclude there is nothing underneath you owe it to yourself to actually look, to read the serious things, to meet the real Christ of the creeds rather than the counterfeit of the culture, because you have earned the right to that meeting by the very demolition you performed, and it would be a tragedy to have cleared the ground and then walked away before you saw what the ground was for.

Chapter Twenty-Five: The Sacraments You Dismissed

I wrote a chapter earlier about the means of grace, the word and water and table you cannot receive alone, and I made the argument at the level of principle. But I want to come back to it at a different level, the level of experience, because I have found that the argument from principle rarely moves anyone, while the experience, when it finally happens, moves everyone. Most of the people reading this were formed in a tradition that held a low view of the sacraments, that treated baptism and communion as symbols, memorials, illustrations of an inner reality that was the real thing, and I want to gently suggest that this low view, whatever its theological merits, contributed to the ease with which people left, because it had already taught them that the physical practices did not really matter, that the inner private reality was what counted, which is exactly the disembodied Christianity I argued the incarnation forbids.

Let me describe the low view fairly, because I do not want to caricature a position held by faithful people for real reasons. The low view, common across much of evangelical Protestantism, holds that communion is a memorial, a remembering of what Christ did, and that baptism is a symbol, an outward sign of an inward decision already made. The bread is bread. The water is water. Nothing happens in the elements themselves. What happens, if anything happens, happens in the heart of the believer who remembers and symbolizes. This view arose for good reasons, in reaction to genuine abuses, out of a proper horror at the idea that grace could be mechanically dispensed

through ritual regardless of faith. I understand it. I was formed in it. But I have come to think it gave away something precious, and that the giving-away made the leaving easier, because a faith whose physical practices are merely optional illustrations of an inner reality is a faith you can practice entirely inwardly, alone, without the practices at all, which is precisely what the church-leaver does.

Consider what is lost when the table becomes only a memorial. In the older and higher view, held in various forms by most Christians for most of history, something actually happens at the table, Christ actually gives himself, the grace is actually conveyed through the physical eating and drinking, so that to receive communion is not merely to remember something but to be fed something, to have Christ come to you in the bread in a way he does not come to you in your private thoughts. On this view, you cannot get at your desk what you get at the table, because the table gives a thing your desk cannot give, the physical reception of Christ through physical elements in the physical company of the physical body. The memorial view, by contrast, locates everything in the mind, in the remembering, and once everything is in the mind, the body and the elements and the company become dispensable, aids to a remembering you could in principle do anywhere, and so of course people conclude they can do it anywhere, because the theology told them they could.

I am not going to try to settle the theological question here, because it is a real question dividing faithful churches and I promised to handle such questions by naming the positions rather than pretending mine is obviously right. But I will say where I have landed and why, and I will say it as one person's testimony rather than as a verdict binding on you. I have landed

on a higher view than the one I was given, not because I worked out the theology first, but because I experienced something at the table that the memorial view could not account for. I have knelt at a communion rail in a season of such spiritual dryness that my private prayers felt like talking to a ceiling, and I have received the bread and the wine, and something came to me through them that had not come to me in the dry private prayers, some actual grace, some actual presence, mediated through the physical elements precisely when the inner private channel had gone dead. And I understood, kneeling there, that the table was giving me something my interior life could not manufacture, that the grace was coming from outside me, through matter, into a soul too dry to generate anything on its own, and that this was the whole point of a sacrament, that it comes from outside, through the physical, when the inside has nothing left.

This matters for the church-leaver in a specific way, and it is a hopeful way, so let me draw it out. If the sacraments are merely memorials, symbols of an inner faith, then when your inner faith runs dry, when you can no longer feel or believe or generate anything, you have nothing, because the whole thing was located in an interior that has gone empty. But if the sacraments actually convey grace from outside, through matter, then they are precisely what can carry you when your interior fails, the external supply that does not depend on your internal state, the bread that feeds you when you cannot feed yourself. This is why the historic church prized the sacraments most in seasons of darkness and doubt, because they are the grace that comes to you when you cannot come to grace, the objective gift that does not require your subjective competence. The church-leaver who left partly because their inner faith ran dry may have left precisely the thing that could have carried them through the dryness, having been taught that the thing was only a symbol of an inner

reality that had, at that very moment, failed. The tragedy is exact. They abandoned the external supply at the precise moment the internal supply gave out, because their theology had told them the external was only a picture of the internal, so that when the internal died there seemed nothing left to hold onto.

I offer this not to relitigate a denominational dispute but to open a door, because I think that for some who left, the recovery of a higher view of the sacraments is part of the way back, and they do not know it because no one ever offered it to them. When the private inner faith has run dry and cannot be revived by effort, the discovery that there is an external grace, a table where Christ gives himself through matter regardless of how you feel, a water that joined you to a body regardless of the strength of your decision, can be the thing that makes return possible, because it does not require you to first work up an inner faith you no longer have. You can come to the table with nothing, dry, doubting, barely believing, and receive, because the receiving does not depend on your having something to bring. That is grace, the real thing, coming from outside, through the physical, into the empty. And it is available at ten thousand tables this Sunday, to anyone who comes with empty hands, which is the only way anyone has ever rightly come, and it does not check your inner state at the rail, because the whole point is that it gives you what your inner state cannot.

Chapter Twenty-Six: The Pastors Who Are Also Leaving

I have written this whole book as a pastor addressing the people who left, but there is a truth I have circled and not landed on, and it belongs in the book because it changes the picture, and because leaving out the pastors would make the book a lie by omission. The pastors are leaving too. Not in the numbers the laity are leaving, but in numbers that have alarmed everyone who tracks these things, and for reasons that overlap with the reasons the laity left and add a few of their own, and I know these reasons from the inside, because I have felt every one of them, and there were seasons when I nearly became one of the statistics I am about to describe.

The surveys tell a stark story. In the years around the pandemic and its aftermath, the share of pastors who had seriously considered quitting full-time ministry rose to levels that had never been seen, with major studies from the Barna Group finding that something like four in ten had thought seriously about leaving. The reasons they gave were not, mostly, loss of faith. They were exhaustion, isolation, the impossibility of the job, the political fracturing of their congregations, the sense of being caught between factions that each demanded he take their side and treated any refusal as betrayal, and a loneliness peculiar to the role, the loneliness of the man everyone comes to with their burdens and who has nowhere to take his own. The pastor is inside the same failing institution the laity fled, and he cannot flee it, because it is his job and his calling and his mortgage, and so he stays, and burns, and a great many of them are burning out

and walking away, and the ones who stay are often staying on fumes.

I want to be careful not to turn this into a bid for sympathy, the pastor asking the wounded laity to feel sorry for the shepherds, because that would be obscene given what the shepherds have done, and given that the pastor's suffering, real as it is, does not compare to the suffering of the sheep the pastors harmed. So let me be clear about why I am including this. I am including it not to redirect your sympathy but to complicate the picture of the church you are tempted to hold, the picture of a comfortable institution full of satisfied insiders that you righteously left. That picture is not accurate. The institution you left is not comfortable. It is in crisis at every level, the pews emptying and the pulpits emptying too, the shepherds as exhausted and disillusioned and ready to quit as the sheep, and the whole thing groaning under a weight that is crushing the people inside it as surely as it drove out the people who left. This does not excuse what was done to you. It does mean that the church you left is not thriving without you, is not the fat and happy institution your leaving was a protest against, but is itself dying, from the inside, in ways that mirror your own reasons for going.

There is a particular version of the pastoral crisis that speaks directly to the themes of this book, and it is the crisis of the honest pastor caught in a dishonest system. Imagine a man who went into ministry because he genuinely loved God and genuinely wanted to serve people, and who discovers, over years, that the job as it is actually structured is not primarily about loving God and serving people but about keeping an institution running, filling seats, managing budgets, placating factions, protecting the brand, performing a health the institution does not have. Imagine that he sees, more clearly than anyone, the gap

between what the church claims and what it is, because he is the one manufacturing the claim every Sunday. Imagine that he is required, by the logic of his position, to be the chief performer of the very shallowness and dishonesty and reputation-management that drove the laity out, and that he knows it, and that it is killing his own soul to do it. That man is a pastor I recognize, because that man was, for a season, me, and there are tens of thousands of him, and he is leaving, or wants to, for reasons that are the mirror image of the reasons his people left. He too is starving on the gruel. He too cannot stand the dishonesty. He too has been wounded by the machine. He just cannot walk out the door, or believes he cannot, and so he stays, and dies a little more each week, and some Sunday he does not show up and the elders scramble to explain it.

I tell you this because I think it matters for how you hold the people who remain, and specifically the pastors who remain. It is easy, from outside, to see the pastor as the enemy, the face of the institution that harmed you, the man complicit in the whole machine, and in many cases that read is accurate and the man has earned it. But it is also the case that some of the pastors still standing in those pulpits are there not because they endorse the machine but because they are fighting it from inside, trying to feed the gruel-starved a real meal, trying to tell the truth in a system built on performance, trying to be a shepherd in a structure that keeps trying to make them a shopkeeper, and paying for the fight with their own health and joy and sometimes their faith. Not all of them. Maybe not most of them. But some of them, and you cannot tell which from outside, and the man who looks like the face of the institution might be the one most desperately trying to reform it, might be your ally without your knowing it, might be as wounded by the machine as you were and merely unable to leave.

So the picture is darker and more tangled than either side usually paints it. It is not the righteous departed against the complacent remaining. It is a whole institution in crisis, wounding and wounded at every level, the sheep fleeing and the shepherds burning, everyone caught in a machine that is failing all of them, and the machine is not the body of Christ, the machine is the thing that grew up around the body and is now crushing it, and the people best positioned to see this are, strangely, the departed laity and the exhausted pastors, who are seeing the same failure from opposite sides and mostly do not realize they are seeing the same thing. If there is any hope for reform, and I think there is, it lies partly in these two groups recognizing each other, the wounded who left and the wounded who stayed finding that they are natural allies against the machine that harmed them both, and building together the smaller, truer, more honest thing that neither the fleeing nor the remaining can build alone. That is a strange coalition to imagine, the dechurched and the burned-out pastors rebuilding the church together. But it may be exactly the coalition the future requires, and I have seen the first flickers of it, and they are among the most hopeful things I know.

Chapter Twenty-Seven: On Not Being the Hero of Your Own Departure

I have spent this book defending the people who left, and I have meant it, and I do not take back a word of it. But a book that only ever flattered the departed would be its own kind of dishonesty, a mirror image of the church that only ever blamed them, and I promised in the introduction that I was after honesty and not a pitch in either direction. So I have to say a hard thing now, carefully, to the very people I have spent the book defending, and I have to say it in a way that does not undo the defense, because both things are true and holding them together is the whole difficulty. The hard thing is this. It is possible to leave a church for genuinely good reasons and then to build a false identity on the leaving, to make the departure the center of a story in which you are always the hero and the church is always the villain, and this identity, once built, becomes its own kind of prison, and it is worth examining whether you have built it.

Let me describe the identity precisely, because you will only recognize it if I am specific. It is the identity of the enlightened one who saw through it, the person whose whole sense of self now rests on having been clear-eyed enough to leave when the naive stayed. It expresses itself in a certain reflexive superiority toward anyone still inside, a certain eagerness to tell the leaving story, a certain need for the church to have been all bad so that the leaving can have been all good. And here is the tell, the thing

that reveals it as a prison rather than a freedom. The person in this identity cannot let the church be complicated. They need it to be simply evil, simply corrupt, simply the thing they were right to reject, because any goodness in it, any real grace, any acknowledgment that it was a mixed and human thing rather than a monster, would threaten the story in which their departure was pure heroism. And so they become, ironically, as unable to see the church clearly as the naive insider they left behind, just in the opposite direction, the insider unable to see its faults and the departed unable to see anything but its faults, both trapped in a picture that serves their identity rather than the truth.

I have watched this happen to people, and it is a slow tragedy, because it usually begins in something legitimate. The person really was wounded. The church really did fail them. The leaving really was, at the start, an act of integrity. But then the wound becomes an identity, and the identity needs feeding, and it feeds on grievance, on the retelling, on the community of the similarly departed who confirm each other's stories, and over time the person who left for freedom finds themselves less free than when they started, bound now to a narrative that requires the church to stay the villain, unable to move on because moving on would mean letting go of the identity that the leaving became. They wanted to escape a prison and they built themselves a new one out of the escape, and the new one is subtler because it looks like freedom, feels like enlightenment, and is celebrated by everyone else who has built the same cell.

I want to be very careful here, because this is exactly the kind of thing an abusive church says to keep its victims, your grievance is just bitterness, your leaving is just rebellion, you have made an idol of your wound. I have named that manipulation elsewhere in this book and I stand against it. So let me distinguish sharply

between what I am saying and what the abuser says. The abuser says your wound is not real, in order to keep you. I am saying your wound is real, and precisely because it is real it is dangerous to build your identity on it, in order to set you free. The abuser wants you back under their control. I want you free of every control, including the control that a grievance-identity exercises over the person who has built one. The difference is the direction. The abuser's move keeps you bound to them. My move, if it lands, frees you from a bondage to the very wound they caused, which is a bondage they would love for you to keep, because a person defined by their wound is a person still, in a sense, in their power, still organized around what they did to you, still not free.

The freedom I am pointing at is stranger and harder than either staying wounded or pretending you were not. It is the freedom to have been genuinely wronged and to not be defined by it, to hold the wound as real without making it the center, to be able to say the church hurt me and also the church is a complicated human thing that contains real grace and I am no longer going to organize my whole identity around my departure from it. This freedom does not require you to return. It does not require you to forgive on any timeline or to minimize what was done. It requires only that you refuse to let the wound become the load-bearing wall of your self, that you decline to be, for the rest of your life, primarily a person who left, and instead become, again, simply a person, with a wound among your other features, moving forward into a life that is about more than the thing you escaped. That is a harder freedom than the grievance-identity, which is why fewer people reach it, because the grievance-identity is warm and confirming and easy and the real freedom is cold and lonely and requires giving up the one story everyone applauded you for.

Wendell Berry has written that a person who is always leaving, always defining themselves against what they have rejected, never actually arrives anywhere, never becomes a member of anything, remains permanently in the posture of departure, and that this permanent departure is its own kind of death, a life spent forever walking away from things and never toward anything. I think some of the departed are in danger of this, of making a life out of leaving, of a permanent posture of rejection that feels like freedom and is actually a refusal to ever belong to anything again for fear of being hurt again, and this refusal, understandable as it is, slowly starves the person, because human beings are not built to belong to nothing, and a life organized around what you have left is a life with a hole where the belonging should be. The way out is not back to the thing that hurt you. The way out is forward, into some new belonging, when you are ready, which requires first laying down the identity of the one who left, because you cannot both be defined by your departure and arrive somewhere new. You have to stop leaving in order to start arriving, and stopping leaving means the wound stops being the center, and that is the hardest and most freeing thing I can ask of the very people I have spent this book defending.

Chapter Twenty-Eight: What the Early Church Was Actually Like

We have a habit, when we talk about the church, of comparing the disappointing present to a golden past, and the golden past we usually reach for is the early church, the church of the book of Acts, the church before it all went wrong, before Constantine, before the institution, before the corruption, back when it was pure and Spirit-filled and everyone shared everything and loved each other perfectly. This golden-age story is comforting to both the departed and the remaining, because it gives everyone a pure original to measure the corrupt present against, and it is almost entirely a fantasy, and I want to take it apart, gently, because the fantasy does real harm, and the reality is far more useful and far more hopeful than the fantasy it replaces.

Read the actual documents. The New Testament letters are almost all written to churches that were in trouble, and the trouble was not minor, and it was not the persecution from outside, it was the mess inside. Corinth, as I have said, was a disaster, suing each other, getting drunk at communion, splitting into personality cults, tolerating gross immorality and being proud of it. The churches in Galatia were being pulled into a false gospel almost as soon as Paul left. The church at Ephesus, we learn in Revelation, had lost its first love. The church at Laodicea was lukewarm and self-satisfied and did not even know it was poor. The letters of John are written against people who had left the church and were teaching a distorted version. The letter of James is written against churches that were showing favoritism to the rich and neglecting the poor. There is not a

single church in the New Testament that is held up as the pure ideal. Every one of them is a mess, and the letters exist precisely because they were a mess, because if they had been pure no one would have needed to write to correct them.

This is not a discouraging fact. It is one of the most encouraging facts in the whole Bible, and here is why. If the church had a golden age, a period of purity from which it later fell, then the present corruption would represent a decline from an original that we could never recover, and the whole thing would be a story of loss, the pure past forever behind us, the corrupt present all we can hope for. But there was no golden age. The church was a mess from the first week. The church that saw the risen Christ with their own eyes, that received the Spirit at Pentecost, that had the apostles themselves as living leaders, was already, within a few years, suing each other and getting drunk at the table and splitting into factions. Which means the corruption you fled is not a decline from a lost purity. It is the normal condition of the church in every age, including the age of the apostles, and the grace that held the apostolic church together despite its mess is the same grace available now, because it never depended on the church being pure, it depended on Christ, who was holding together a disaster from the very beginning.

There is something deeply freeing in this for the person who left over the church's failures, and I want to draw it out slowly. You may have left believing that the church was supposed to be something it was failing to be, that its corruption was a betrayal of an original purity, that a real church, a true church, a New Testament church, would not do the things your church did. And that belief made the corruption unbearable, because it seemed like a fall from what the thing was supposed to be. But the New Testament church did the things your church did. It covered up,

it played favorites, it split over personalities, it tolerated abuse, it lost its love, it went lukewarm. The corruption is not a betrayal of the New Testament church. It is a continuation of it. And this means the standard you were holding the church to, the standard of purity it was failing to meet, was never the actual standard, was a fantasy standard, and the church has never once met it, not even with the apostles present, and the grace of God has been operating through corrupt churches from the first week, which means it can operate through the corrupt church you knew, and the corrupt church you might someday rejoin, because a grace that required a pure church would have died in Corinth and it did not.

Let me push this into the specific failures I named earlier in the book, because the pattern holds all the way down and it is worth seeing. Spiritual abuse and the misuse of authority. Paul spends whole sections of his letters fighting leaders who were lording it over the churches, false apostles, super-apostles who exploited and dominated the flock, so that the abuse of spiritual authority is documented in the New Testament itself as a present danger from the earliest days. The fusion of the gospel with worldly power. The disciples themselves, before the crucifixion, were arguing about who would be greatest, angling for position, wanting Jesus to be the kind of political messiah who would give them thrones, so that the temptation to make the gospel serve power was present in the inner circle before the church even began. Hypocrisy and cover-up. Ananias and Sapphira, in the book of Acts, lied to the church about their giving to look more generous than they were, performing a holiness they did not have, and it was a scandal in the earliest days. Every failure that drove you out has its exact precedent in the New Testament church, which means every failure that drove you out was survivable, was survived, was forgiven and worked through and

grown past, because it had to be, because the church was made of exactly the kind of people who do exactly those things, and the grace held anyway.

So the fantasy of the golden age does real harm because it sets up a standard the church has never met and makes its inevitable failure to meet that standard seem like a unique betrayal rather than the perennial condition. And the reality, that the church was a mess from the first week, does real good, because it locates the present corruption inside a long history of corruption that grace has always worked through, and it takes the pressure off the church to be pure, which it cannot be, and puts the weight back on Christ, who is holding it together, which he always has been, which is the only reason it exists at all. The church you left was not failing to be the New Testament church. It was being the New Testament church, in all its mess, and the New Testament church was held together by grace and not by its own purity, and so is the one you left, and so is the one you might return to, and the grace does not require you to find a pure church, because there has never been one, not once, not even with the apostles in the room.

I find this changes how I hold my own church's failures, and I offer the change as one you might make too. When my church fails, and it does, constantly, I used to feel it as a betrayal, a falling-short of what we were supposed to be, and the feeling produced either despair or a frantic effort to fix us into the purity we were supposed to have. Now I feel it differently. I feel it as us being the church, the actual church, the Corinthian church, the church that has always been a mess and always been held together by a grace it did not generate, and this does not make me complacent about the failures, I still fight them, but it takes the despair out, because I am no longer measuring us against a

golden age that never existed and finding us uniquely fallen. We are not uniquely fallen. We are ordinarily fallen, the way the church has always been fallen, and the extraordinary thing is not our failure, which is ordinary, but the grace that keeps holding the failures together into something that, despite everything, is still the body of Christ. That is the actual early church. Not the fantasy of purity. The reality of grace holding a mess together. It is a better story than the fantasy, and it is true, and it has room in it for your church, and for mine, and for you.

Chapter Twenty-Nine: The Prayers You Cannot Pray Alone

There is a dimension of the church's life that the individualist framework cannot even see, and I have touched it but not developed it, and it deserves a chapter of its own because it is one of the most concrete things the church gives that you genuinely cannot get alone. It is the shared prayer, the liturgy, the words the church has prayed together for centuries, the great inheritance of common prayer that the private believer, praying spontaneously in their own words, never receives. And I want to make the case for it carefully, because the tradition I come from is suspicious of it, prizes spontaneous prayer from the heart over written prayers from a book, treats the read prayer as somehow less sincere than the improvised one, and I think this suspicion, however well-intentioned, cost people something precious and made the leaving easier.

Consider what happens when you can only pray your own words. Your own words come from your own heart, and your own heart, on any given day, is a limited and often impoverished thing, capable of praying only what it currently feels, only what is currently within its range. On a good day this is fine. But consider the day when you have no words, when grief has emptied you, when doubt has silenced you, when you are so far down that you cannot generate a single sincere sentence toward God. On that day, the person who can only pray their own words has no prayer, because they have nothing to say, and their spontaneous heart, which is the only source they were taught to draw from, has gone dry. This is precisely the day the inherited

prayers exist for. The Psalms, prayed by the church for three thousand years. The written prayers of the tradition, carrying the words of the faithful across centuries. On the day you have no words, the church hands you words, words prayed by millions before you, words that carry you when your own heart cannot, and you pray them not because you generated them but because they were given to you, and they say what you could not say, and they pray you when you cannot pray.

I learned this the hard way, in a season of my own darkness, and I will tell it briefly because it is the kind of thing that only convinces through testimony. There was a stretch when I could not pray. I was a pastor, leading others in prayer every week, and privately I had gone silent, because my own heart had nothing to say and I had only ever been taught to pray from my own heart. And a wiser man handed me a book of the ancient prayers of the church and told me to stop trying to generate prayers and to simply pray these, the given ones, out loud, whether I felt them or not. And I did, and something extraordinary happened, which is that the given words prayed on my behalf when I could not, carried me across the dry season on the strength of the millions who had prayed them before me, held my faith when my faith could not hold itself, until slowly my own heart came back and I could pray again in my own words. The inherited prayers were the bridge across the chasm my spontaneous heart could not leap. And I understood then what the individualist tradition had cost me, that in prizing only the spontaneous prayer it had left me with no resources for the day the spontaneity failed, which is exactly the day I most needed a resource.

This is a corporate gift, and that is the point for this book. The inherited prayers are the church's prayers, prayed by the whole body across time, and when you pray them you are not praying

alone even when you are physically alone, because you are praying the words of the communion of saints, joining your voice to the vast choir of the faithful living and dead who have prayed these same words in their own darknesses. The private believer, praying only their own spontaneous words, is genuinely alone in their prayer, cut off from the great river of common prayer, dependent entirely on their own heart's daily capacity. The believer praying the church's prayers is never alone, is carried by the body even in solitude, is praying with and in and through the whole company. And this is a thing the church offers that you cannot manufacture, because you cannot invent a three-thousand-year tradition of common prayer by yourself in your living room, you can only receive it, and receiving it requires belonging to the body that carries it, and the body that carries it is the church.

There is a specific way this speaks to the doubter, and I want to name it because it is not obvious and it is precious. When you doubt, when your own faith wavers, the spontaneous prayer becomes impossible, because how do you pray sincerely to a God you are not sure is there, in your own words, from your own uncertain heart. The individualist framework leaves the doubter with nothing, because it requires the prayer to be sincere and heartfelt and spontaneous, and the doubter's heart cannot supply sincerity it does not have. But the inherited prayer works differently. You can pray the church's prayer in your doubt, not because you have generated the faith it expresses but because you are borrowing the faith of the church, praying the body's confident words in your own unconfident voice, letting the church believe on your behalf when you cannot believe for yourself. The tradition understood this. It knew that faith is not always individually possessed, that there are times you survive on the borrowed faith of the body, that the church believes as a

whole even when its individual members waver, and that to pray its prayers in your doubt is to be carried by its faith until your own returns. The doubter who can only pray their own sincere prayers is stranded by their doubt. The doubter who can pray the church's prayers is carried through their doubt by the church's faith, and this is one of the deepest gifts of belonging to a body, that the body's faith holds you when yours fails.

So the loss of common prayer, in the traditions that abandoned it for spontaneity, was a greater loss than anyone realized at the time, and it contributed to the fragility that made the leaving easy. A faith that can only be prayed spontaneously from the heart is a faith that fails the moment the heart fails, and hearts fail constantly, and when they failed, people who had only been taught spontaneous prayer found they had no prayer at all, and a faith with no prayer withers, and a withered faith is easy to leave. The recovery of common prayer, the inherited words, the Psalms and the liturgies and the great prayers of the tradition, is part of the way back for many, because it gives them a way to pray that does not depend on their own daily capacity, a way to be carried by the body when they cannot walk on their own. And you cannot get this alone. You can read the prayers alone, yes, but the prayers themselves are the church's, corporate, communal, the body's inheritance, and to pray them is to draw on a reservoir that only the body possesses, which is one more way that the faith was never meant to be solitary, one more thing the private believer cannot manufacture and can only receive, from the body, which is the church, which is the thing you left.

Chapter Thirty: The Long Obedience Nobody Advertises

Eugene Peterson took a phrase from Friedrich Nietzsche, of all people, and made it the title of one of his books, and the phrase is a long obedience in the same direction. Nietzsche, an atheist and no friend of Christianity, observed that the essential thing in heaven and earth is that there should be a long obedience in the same direction, that all the things of value, in art and virtue and mastery and life itself, come from sustained commitment over time rather than from intensity in the moment. Peterson took this pagan insight and applied it to discipleship, arguing that the Christian life is not a series of dramatic experiences but a long, slow, unglamorous faithfulness sustained over decades, and I want to close in on this idea because it names something the modern church abandoned and the abandonment is directly connected to why people leave.

The modern church, formed by the market and by the broader culture of intensity and experience, sold a version of the Christian life that was all about the moment, the decision, the encounter, the mountaintop, the dramatic conversion and the emotional high and the life-changing weekend retreat. And this sold well, because moments are exciting and intensity feels like life, and a church that could reliably manufacture intense moments could fill a room. But it was a lie about what the Christian life actually is, and the lie set people up to leave, because a life built on moments cannot survive the long stretches between moments, the ordinary Tuesdays, the dry seasons, the decades of unglamorous faithfulness that are the actual substance

of any real spiritual life. When the moments stopped coming, when the intensity faded, when faith became a matter of showing up on grey mornings with no emotional payoff, the people formed to expect moments concluded that something had gone wrong, that they had lost their faith, that the fire had died, when in fact they had simply arrived at the ordinary long obedience that is what faith mostly is, and no one had told them it existed, and so they mistook the normal for the failed and they left.

Peterson's insight, drawn from a farmer's sense of time and a pastor's thirty years in one congregation, is that the spiritual life is far more like agriculture than like fireworks. It is slow. It is seasonal. It has long fallow stretches where nothing appears to be happening and the growth is all underground and invisible. It is measured in decades, not in weekends. And it cannot be hurried or manufactured or intensified into producing on demand, any more than a farmer can shout at a field to grow faster. The church that promised fireworks was promising the wrong thing entirely, was setting people up to expect a kind of life the spiritual life does not deliver, and when it did not deliver fireworks on schedule, people felt cheated, and their feeling of being cheated was based on a false advertisement the church itself had run. The church oversold intensity and undersold obedience, and the oversold customers left when the intensity ran out, exactly as oversold customers always do.

And here is the connection to the whole argument of this book, the connection that makes this more than a point about individual discipleship. The long obedience cannot be sustained alone. This is the thing Peterson understood and the individualist cannot see. A dramatic moment can happen to a solitary person, a private encounter, a lonely mountaintop, and much of the church's spirituality of intensity was in fact deeply individualistic, the

solitary soul having its private experience. But the long obedience, the decades of unglamorous faithfulness through the dry stretches, cannot be done alone, because the solitary person, on the grey Tuesday with no emotional payoff, has nothing to keep them going, no reason to show up, no one to show up for, and they drift, because there is nothing holding them to the practice but their own flagging motivation, and motivation is exactly what fails in the dry stretches. What sustains the long obedience is the body, the others, the fact that you show up not because you feel like it but because they are expecting you, because you belong to them, because the rhythms of the community carry you through the seasons when your own motivation is dead. The church is the structure that makes the long obedience possible, the trellis the slow-growing vine climbs, and the solitary believer, without the trellis, cannot sustain the slow growth, and collapses in the first dry season, and calls the collapse the loss of their faith when it was really the absence of the structure that would have carried them through.

I have watched this in my own congregation over decades, and it is one of the things that most convinces me the church is not optional. I have watched people sustain faith through unimaginable stretches of dryness and difficulty, through seasons when they felt nothing and believed little and had every reason to quit, and what carried them was not their own spiritual intensity, which had long since faded, but the sheer fact of belonging, the showing up week after week to a body that expected them, the rhythms and the relationships and the ordinary means of grace administered by other people, the whole external structure of the church holding their faith in place while their internal faith was too weak to hold itself. And I have watched others, formed on intensity, hit the same dry season alone, with no body holding them, and simply drift away, not through any dramatic loss of

faith but through the slow erosion that overtakes any solitary practice when the motivation fails and there is no external structure to compensate. The difference was not the strength of their individual faith. It was whether they were embedded in a body that could carry them when their individual faith could not carry itself.

So the long obedience is a corporate achievement, not an individual one, and this is one more reason the church is not optional but essential, not an add-on to a faith that could be sustained privately, but the very structure that makes sustained faith possible across a lifetime. The dramatic moment is available to the solitary soul. The long obedience is not. And since the Christian life is overwhelmingly long obedience and only occasionally dramatic moment, since it is far more Tuesday than mountaintop, the structure that sustains the long obedience is the structure that sustains the faith, and that structure is the church, the body, the community of the ordinary means of grace administered week after week by unglamorous people who show up for each other through the dry decades. The church-leaver who left over the absence of fireworks left the very thing that could have carried them through the ordinary faithfulness that faith mostly is, having been sold fireworks by a church that should have been building a trellis. The trellis is less exciting than the fireworks. It is also the thing that keeps the vine alive through the winter, and the fireworks are not, and the vine that had only fireworks and no trellis is the vine that is now lying dead on the ground wondering what went wrong. What went wrong is that no one built it a trellis, or told it the winters were coming, or explained that the long obedience through the winters is not the failure of the spiritual life but its actual substance, and cannot be walked alone.

Chapter Thirty-One: The Children You Are Deciding For

I have to write a chapter that will be uncomfortable, and I have put it off, because it touches the tenderest nerve and because I am a father of five sons and cannot write it from a safe distance. It is about the children, about the fact that when you leave the church you are usually deciding not only for yourself but for your children, choosing the shape of the spiritual world they will grow up inside, and that this decision is being made, understandably, in the aftermath of your own wounding, by a person doing their best in hard circumstances, and that it deserves to be made with open eyes rather than by default. I want to write it without manipulation, because the children are exactly the lever a manipulative book would pull, and I refuse to pull it, and I will try to say only true things and let you do with them what you will.

Let me start by conceding the strongest form of the case for leaving with your children, because I mean it. If you were harmed by a church, if the community that was supposed to form your children in love instead formed them in fear or shame or control or taught them a God who was a monster, then removing them from that is not a failure of parenting, it is parenting, it is the protection a parent owes a child. I would remove my sons from a harmful church without a second thought, and I would consider it faithfulness and not abandonment, and I would not care what anyone said about it. So the case for leaving with your children, when the church was harmful, is not just permissible, it is obligatory, and I want that on the record before I say anything

harder, so that the harder thing is not heard as a demand that you expose your children to harm. It is not. Never that.

But most of the leaving is not fleeing a harmful church. Most of it, as the research showed, is drift, or ordinary disappointment, or the shallowness, or the general sense that it is not worth the Sunday morning, and in these cases the decision to leave with the children is a different kind of decision, made not to protect them from harm but as a byproduct of the parent's own disengagement, and it has consequences for the children that are worth seeing clearly even when the leaving is otherwise reasonable. The consequence is simply this. Children absorb their sense of the sacred, their vocabulary for the transcendent, their felt experience of belonging to something larger than themselves, in childhood or largely not at all, and a child raised entirely outside any religious community is a child who will, in most cases, grow up without that vocabulary, without that felt experience, and will have to construct it from scratch as an adult if they want it, which is far harder, or will simply live without it, which is the more common outcome. You are not raising your children in neutral when you raise them outside the church. You are raising them in the secular frame, which is not neutral, which has its own account of what is real and what matters, and which will form them as surely as any church would, just in a different direction.

I want to be honest about the thing that makes this hard, and it is a thing the church rarely admits. Some parents leave precisely because they do not want to lie to their children, because they no longer believe what the church teaches and cannot in good conscience raise their children in a faith they have lost, and to those parents I owe honesty rather than pressure. If you genuinely do not believe, then raising your children in a faith

you have abandoned would be its own kind of dishonesty, a performance for their sake that they would eventually see through, and I am not going to tell you to fake a faith you do not have for the sake of your children's formation, because a faked faith forms children in performance and performance is exactly the disease this whole book has been diagnosing. So this chapter is not for the parent who has genuinely lost the faith and is honestly declining to fake it. That parent is doing something with integrity, and I respect it, and I would only ask them to make sure they have actually examined the deep faith and not just left the shallow one, which is the burden of the whole book and I will not repeat it here.

This chapter is for the other parent, the more common one, the parent who has not exactly lost the faith but has drifted from the church, who still believes in some vague and unpracticed way but has stopped attending, and who is, without quite deciding to, raising their children in nothing, in the vague unpracticed belief that is really just the residue of their own fading formation and that transmits almost nothing to the next generation. That parent is making a decision by default, and it is the decision to let their children grow up without the thing, and I want them to at least see that they are making it, because a decision made by default in the aftermath of one's own disappointment is not the same as a decision made with open eyes, and the children live inside it either way. The research on this is fairly clear and fairly sobering. The transmission of faith across generations depends heavily on practice, on the child actually participating in a religious community, and the vague believing parent who has stopped practicing tends to raise children who do not even vaguely believe, so that the drift of one generation becomes the absence of the next, and the grandchildren grow up in a world where the whole thing is simply not a live option, was never

presented, does not exist for them as a possibility they rejected but as a possibility they never encountered.

I feel the weight of this as a father in a specific way, because of my own history, and I will tell you the piece of it that bears on this chapter. I was raised without a father, which meant I was raised without a great many things a father transmits, and one of them was any relationship to faith, any vocabulary for the sacred, any felt sense of belonging to a religious community. I grew up in the absence, in the nothing, and I came to faith as an adult, from atheism, and I can tell you from the inside that constructing from scratch, as an adult, what most believers absorbed in childhood is brutally hard, that I have spent decades building a house that others were given, that I still feel, sometimes, the draftiness of a faith built late on no childhood foundation. I would not wish that difficulty on my sons. Whatever else I give them or fail to give them, I am determined that they will not have to construct from scratch, as adults, the vocabulary of the sacred that I had to construct, that they will absorb it in childhood the way most believers do, inside a community, so that if they later reject it they will at least be rejecting something they were actually given rather than never encountering it at all.

So my appeal to the drifting parent, and it is an appeal and not a demand, is only this. See the decision you are making. See that raising your children outside the church is not raising them in neutral but raising them in the secular frame, forming them as surely as any church would. See that the vague believing that you have retained but stopped practicing is unlikely to transmit, that your children will probably not even inherit your vagueness but will grow up in the absence, in the nothing I grew up in, and will have to build from scratch as adults if they ever want it, which most will not, because building from scratch is too hard. And

decide, with open eyes, whether that is what you want for them, rather than letting it happen by the default of your own disappointment. If you decide, with open eyes, that you cannot in conscience raise them in a faith you do not hold, I respect it. But make it a decision and not a drift, because the children live inside your drift, and they did not choose it, and it will shape their whole relationship to the deepest questions a human being can ask, and that is too large a thing to happen by default in the aftermath of your own wounding. That is all I will say. I will not pull the lever harder than that. The children are yours, and the decision is yours, and I only ask that it be a decision.

Chapter Thirty-Two: The Witness of the Persecuted Church

There is a fact about the global church that ought to unsettle the comfortable Western church-leaver, and I raise it not to shame anyone but because it is a genuine piece of evidence that belongs on the table, and honesty requires putting it there. It is this. In the very places where being a Christian costs the most, where the church is poorest and most persecuted and has the least to offer in the way of comfort or status or community amenities, the church is growing fastest and its members cling to it most fiercely, and in the very places where being a Christian costs the least, where the church is richest and freest and most comfortable, the church is shrinking and its members leave it most readily. This inverse relationship, between the cost of faith and the tenacity of faith, is a fact, and it should give us pause, because it suggests something about the relationship between comfort and commitment that runs exactly opposite to what we would expect, and that indicts the comfortable more than the persecuted.

Consider the underground church in China, which has grown across decades of official suppression into one of the largest bodies of Christians in the world, meeting in homes, under surveillance, with pastors imprisoned and buildings demolished and every incentive pointing toward quitting. Consider the church across large parts of Africa, growing explosively amid poverty and instability and sometimes violent persecution. Consider the Christians of the Middle East, the ancient churches that have held on through centuries of pressure and now through

waves of displacement and martyrdom, clinging to a faith that has cost them their homes and sometimes their lives. These Christians are not staying because the church offers them comfort, status, community amenities, a good experience, any of the things the Western consumer church learned to offer. It offers them mostly cost. And they stay, and they multiply, and they die rather than deny, and the question this forces on the comfortable Western believer is uncomfortable and worth sitting with. What do they know that we have forgotten. What are they holding onto that we found so easy to put down.

I do not want to romanticize persecution, which is a genuine evil and not a spiritual advantage anyone should wish for, and I do not want to shame the Western believer with the suffering of others, which is a cheap move and I refuse it. But I do want to draw out what the contrast reveals, because it reveals something the whole book has been circling. The persecuted church holds onto the faith fiercely precisely because it has been stripped of everything else, because the faith is not one option among many in a comfortable life but the one thing that remains when everything else has been taken, the treasure worth more than the life that clinging to it might cost. And this stripping-down clarifies what the faith actually is, reveals it in its essence, the way pressure reveals the true strength of a material. The comfortable church, by contrast, wrapped the faith in so many comforts and amenities and options that its members could no longer tell the faith itself from the wrapping, and when the wrapping disappointed them, as wrapping does, they threw out the whole package, faith and wrapping together, never having distinguished the treasure from the packaging it came in.

Here is the specific thing the persecuted church knows that bears on the argument of this book, and it is precisely the thing about

community. In the persecuted church, the body is not optional and no one imagines it is, because the body is survival, literally, the network of believers who hide each other and warn each other and carry each other and worship together at genuine risk, so that to be a Christian alone in those circumstances is not a spiritual preference, it is a practical impossibility, you would not survive it, you need the body to make it through. The persecution burns away the illusion of the solitary Christian faster than any argument could, because under pressure the truth becomes obvious, that you cannot do this alone, that the faith is a shared survival, that the body is the difference between holding on and being picked off. The comfortable church, lacking the pressure, could sustain the illusion of the solitary Christian, could imagine that the body was optional, an amenity you could take or leave, because in comfort you can get away with the illusion for a while, right up until your own dry season or your own crisis reveals, too late, that the solitary faith you imagined you could sustain cannot actually be sustained alone, and you drift, having believed a lie that the persecuted church was never able to believe because their circumstances forbade it.

There is a related thing the persecuted church knows about the cost of discipleship, and it connects to the shallowness I named earlier. The comfortable church, having stripped the faith of cost to make it accessible, produced believers whose faith had never been tested and could not survive testing, whereas the persecuted church, whose faith is nothing but cost, produced believers whose faith had been tested to destruction and survived, and the tested faith is the durable one. Bonhoeffer, who knew something about the cost, wrote against what he called cheap grace, the grace the comfortable church sold, grace without discipleship, grace without the cross, grace as a product that asks nothing, and he contrasted it with costly grace, the grace that costs a person

their life, the grace that is grace precisely because it is worth dying for. The comfortable church sold cheap grace and produced believers who left cheaply, because what costs nothing is worth nothing and is discarded easily. The persecuted church has only costly grace on offer, grace that costs everything, and its believers do not leave, because you do not walk away from the thing you have paid everything for. The cost is not incidental to the tenacity. The cost is the reason for the tenacity, and the comfort is the reason for the leaving, and this is the exact opposite of what the market church believed when it removed the cost to make the faith easier to keep.

I raise all of this not to tell the Western church-leaver that they should want persecution, or that their leaving proves them spiritually inferior to the persecuted, or any of the shaming moves that this material invites and that I refuse. I raise it as evidence, as a fact that belongs on the table alongside all the other facts, because it complicates the story that the intelligent and the free are naturally moving beyond faith while only the oppressed and the desperate cling to it. That story is refuted by the actual global data, which shows the faith growing fastest and held most fiercely exactly where it costs the most and offers the least, and shrinking exactly where it costs the least and offers the most. Whatever that means, it does not mean that faith is a comfort that people outgrow as they gain freedom and prosperity. It means something closer to the opposite, that comfort and prosperity are corrosive to faith in a way that persecution is not, that the church's great danger is not the sword but the sofa, and that the Western church-leaver, walking away from a comfortable faith, may be less the vanguard of an inevitable secular future than the latest casualty of a comfort that has always been more dangerous to the faith than any persecution, which the persecuted church could have told us, and

did, and we did not listen because we were comfortable.

Chapter Thirty-Three: Forgiveness Is Not the Same as Return

I have to write carefully about forgiveness, because it is the most abused word in the whole vocabulary of the wounded church-leaver, the word that was weaponized against them more than any other, the word an abusive church uses to short-circuit accountability and pressure the harmed back into harm. You need to forgive. Bitterness will destroy you. Unforgiveness is a sin. You have to let it go. Every one of these can be true and every one of them has been used as a bludgeon, deployed by the very people who caused the harm to avoid facing it, so that the victim ends up carrying not only the wound but the additional burden of guilt for not having forgiven fast enough or fully enough or in the way the church demanded. So I want to separate forgiveness from the manipulation it has been fused to, and in particular I want to separate it from the one thing the church almost always fuses it to, which is return.

Here is the fusion, and you have probably experienced it. The church tells you that if you have really forgiven, you will come back, that forgiveness and reconciliation are the same thing, that to withhold your return is to withhold your forgiveness, that a truly forgiving heart would not stay away. This fusion is false, and it is important to see exactly why it is false, because seeing it frees you from a trap that has held a great many wounded people in a state of paralysis, unable to forgive because they think forgiving means returning to the harm, and unwilling to return to the harm, and therefore stuck, carrying an unforgiveness they think they are obligated to resolve by an unacceptable return.

The way out is to see that forgiveness and return are two different things, that you can fully do the first without doing the second, and that the church that told you otherwise was, once again, using a true word to accomplish a controlling end.

Forgiveness, at its core, is the release of your claim to revenge, the decision to stop nursing the debt, to stop organizing your life around getting even, to hand the whole matter of justice over to God rather than carrying it yourself as a permanent grievance. It is something that happens in you, that frees you, that does not require the participation or even the presence of the one who harmed you. You can forgive someone who is dead, who is unrepentant, who does not know or care that they harmed you, who would harm you again given the chance, because forgiveness is not about them, it is about the release of your own soul from the corrosive work of carrying a debt forever. Reconciliation, on the other hand, requires two, requires the participation of the one who harmed you, requires their repentance and their change, and requires, crucially, that it be safe, that returning to relationship not mean returning to harm. Forgiveness you can do alone, unilaterally, for your own freedom. Reconciliation you cannot do alone, and you should not do at all if the other party has not changed and the relationship is not safe, because reconciliation without repentance and safety is not reconciliation, it is just re-exposure to harm.

The church that fuses forgiveness with return is almost always doing so to avoid the repentance and change that real reconciliation would require of it. If forgiveness means you come back regardless, then the church never has to change, never has to face what it did, never has to become safe, because your return is framed as your spiritual obligation rather than as something the church has to earn by becoming trustworthy again.

This is the abuser's logic exactly, the demand for reconciliation without repentance, the insistence that the harmed party restore the relationship while the harming party changes nothing, and it is a grotesque inversion of the biblical pattern, in which repentance precedes reconciliation, in which the one who has wronged goes to make it right, in which the burden of restoration falls on the one who caused the harm and not on the one who suffered it. The church that demands your return as proof of your forgiveness has reversed the biblical order, has put the burden on you instead of on itself, and you are under no obligation to accept the reversal, and refusing it is not unforgiveness, it is a proper understanding of what forgiveness is and is not.

So let me say clearly what I hope frees someone. You can forgive the church that harmed you completely, from the heart, releasing every claim to revenge, wishing them genuinely well, handing the whole matter of justice to God, and still never return to that church, and there is no contradiction, because forgiveness and return are different things, and the first does not require the second. You can forgive the pastor who harmed you and never sit under his teaching again. You can forgive the community that failed you and never rejoin it. You can be completely free of bitterness and completely absent from the pews, and the church that tells you these cannot both be true is either confused about what forgiveness is or is using the confusion to pressure your return, and in either case you can decline the pressure with a clear conscience. The freedom that forgiveness offers is real, and it is worth having, and it does not come at the price of returning to harm, and anyone who told you it did was selling you a false forgiveness that was really just a mechanism for getting you back under the harm you rightly fled.

But I have to add the harder half, because a book that only ever

comforted would be dishonest, and there is a harder half here that I owe you. Forgiveness, though it does not require return, does require something, and the something is real and costly, and it is the release I described, the genuine handing over of the debt, the actual letting go of the revenge you are entitled to. And this is hard, and it is hard precisely because you were genuinely wronged and genuinely entitled to the grievance, and letting go of a grievance you are entitled to feels like letting the wrongdoer off, feels like injustice, feels like the wound being minimized. It is none of those things, but it feels like all of them, which is why forgiveness is so hard and why it cannot be rushed and why the church that demanded it fast was cruel. Real forgiveness is slow, and it is a work, and it is done for your own freedom and not for the wrongdoer's benefit, and it does not minimize the wrong, it releases you from the wrong's ongoing power over you. And it is worth doing, not because the church deserves it, but because you deserve to be free, and carrying the grievance forever, however entitled you are to it, slowly makes you into someone organized around a wound, which is the prison I described in an earlier chapter, and forgiveness is the key to that particular prison, and it is a key you hold and not the church, which is the one piece of good news in the whole difficult matter. You do not need the church to repent in order for you to be free. You can be free before it ever does, by forgiving, which you can do alone, for yourself, without returning, which is exactly the freedom the fusion of forgiveness with return was designed to keep from you.

Chapter Thirty-Four: The Small Church That Saved Nobody's Life and Meant Everything

I want to tell you about a kind of church that does not appear in any of the stories we tell about the church, neither the triumphant stories the church tells about itself nor the damning stories the departed tell about it, and I want to tell you about it because it is where a great deal of the real thing actually lives, unnoticed by everyone, and because if you only know the church from the megachurch and the scandal you have never seen it. It is the small church. Not the small church as a stepping stone to a large one, not the church-plant with ambitions, but the small church that has been small for a hundred years and will be small for a hundred more, eighty people in a building built for four hundred, the kind of church I keep returning to in this book because it is the kind I know and the kind I believe in.

This church has no strategy. It is not growing. It is not, in the language of the church-growth movement, healthy, because health in that language means growth, and this church has not grown in living memory and is not going to. Its pastor makes almost nothing and works another job. Its building needs repairs it cannot afford. Its music is provided by whoever can play, badly. It has no programs to speak of, no marketing, no brand, no vision statement that anyone could recite. By every metric the market church taught us to use, it is a failure, a dying church, the kind of church the denominational consultants come to study so they can explain what went wrong. And I have come to believe

that this church, precisely in its unstrategic unimpressive smallness, is closer to the actual body of Christ than almost anything the successful church has produced, and I want to explain why, because the reason matters for everyone who left.

Here is what the small church has that the large one usually does not. It cannot hide anyone. In a church of eighty, everyone is known, not because the church has a strategy for knowing people but because you cannot help knowing people when there are only eighty of them and you have been sitting next to the same ones for thirty years. There is no anonymity available. You cannot slip in and out unnoticed. If you are absent, someone notices, not because they were assigned to notice but because your absence is obvious in a room that small. The old woman knows the teenager and the teenager knows the old woman, because there is nowhere for them to not know each other. This is the thing the megachurch spends enormous money trying to manufacture through small-group programs and connection strategies and assimilation pipelines, and the small church has it for free, structurally, unavoidably, because it is small, and smallness produces knownness the way largeness produces anonymity, automatically, without anyone deciding.

And here is the second thing, which follows from the first. The small church cannot run on the market logic even if it wanted to, because the market logic requires scale, requires a large enough pool of consumers to segment and target and grow, and the small church does not have the numbers, so it is forced back onto the only other thing there is, which is the actual body, the actual carrying of one another, the actual membership in Wendell Berry's sense, the actual being-stuck-with-each-other that is the real substance of the church. The small church keeps its members not by offering a superior product, because it has no

product, but by the sheer fact of belonging, of being known, of being carried, of being the place where these particular people have been doing life together for so long that leaving would be like leaving a family, which it would be, because that is what a small church that has been together for decades actually is. It is a family, with all the difficulty and irreplaceability of a family, and you do not leave a family because you found a better product, because a family is not a product and cannot be replaced by one.

I said in the title that this church saved nobody's life, and I mean that it is not dramatic, it does not produce testimonies, it does not have a story of transformation to tell at the conference, nothing happens there that anyone would put in a book except that I am putting it in a book precisely because nothing happens there in the way the church learned to value happening. What happens there is smaller and slower and realer than a transformation story. What happens there is that people are known and carried across decades, that the same people show up for each other through every season of thirty and forty and fifty years, that a child is baptized by the same congregation that will one day bury her, that the long obedience is sustained by the sheer weight of belonging, that the ordinary means of grace are administered week after week to the same faithful few who have nowhere more impressive to be and would not go if they had. It is not exciting. It is the church. It is the thing the exciting churches were imitating and mostly failed to be, because the exciting churches had scale and scale produces anonymity, and the unexciting small church had only smallness, and smallness produces the body.

I want to say a specific thing to the church-leaver about this kind of church, because I think many of them have never considered it, having formed their whole picture of the church from the large

and impressive and eventually disappointing kind. When you imagine returning, if you ever imagine it, you probably imagine returning to something like what you left, the large church with the production and the crowd and the anonymity, and you rightly recoil, because that thing harmed you or bored you or both. But that is not the only church. There is this other kind, the small unimpressive family-church, and it is a completely different animal, and it is available in nearly every town, sitting there unnoticed in its half-empty building, and it might be exactly the thing you did not know you were looking for, the place small enough to know you and unstrategic enough to not want anything from you and unimpressive enough to have given up on the market logic that harmed you, the place where you could sit near the door for a year giving nothing and be slowly, unhurriedly, folded into a family that would carry you across the decades. It is not the church you left. It is the church the church you left was pretending to be. And it is smaller and duller and realer than anything the impressive church ever produced, and it might be waiting for you, in a building built for four hundred that holds eighty, with a gap in the pew exactly your size.

There is a reason God seems to prefer the small and the unimpressive, and it runs through the whole Bible, and it is worth naming as I close this chapter. God chose the smallest nation, the younger brother, the barren woman, the shepherd boy, the backwater town, the manger, the cross, over and over the small and the weak and the unimpressive over the large and the strong and the magnificent, so consistently that Paul made a doctrine of it, that God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong, the foolish things to shame the wise, the things that are not to bring to nothing the things that are, so that no one could boast. The large impressive church, whatever else it was, was a thing that could boast, that measured itself by the metrics

of strength and success, and God has a long history of bringing exactly such things to nothing. The small church cannot boast. It has nothing to boast about. It is weak and foolish and unimpressive by every worldly measure, which is precisely the kind of thing God has always preferred to work through, so that the treasure would be seen to be in the clay and not in the jar. If you are looking for where God is most likely to be found in the church today, do not look at the impressive places. Look at the small, weak, unimpressive, half-empty ones, because that is where God has always preferred to be, and it is where the body most reliably still lives, unnoticed, unstrategic, and real.

Chapter Thirty-Five: The Objection I Have Not Answered

An honest book names the strongest objection to its own argument and does not pretend to have fully answered it, and I have tried to do this in pieces throughout, but I owe you one concentrated chapter on the objection I think is strongest, the one I have not fully answered and cannot fully answer, because pretending otherwise would be exactly the dishonesty this whole book has stood against. The objection is this. Everything you have said about the body of Christ, the theology of membership, the incarnation, the means of grace, all of it, describes the church as it should be, the ideal church, the church of the New Testament and the creeds. But I do not live in the ideal church. I live in a town with three actual churches, and I have been to all of them, and none of them is the thing you describe, and telling me the ideal church is essential does me no good when the actual churches available to me are the very things I fled. You have defended a church I cannot find.

This is the strongest objection, and I want to state it even more strongly before I say what little I can in response, because a steelman that pulls its punches is not a steelman. The objection, at full strength, is that the whole argument of this book commits a bait and switch, that it spends its length defending an idealized church, the body of Christ in its theological glory, and then quietly implies that this glorious thing is available at the disappointing congregation down your street, when in fact the disappointing congregation down your street is not the glorious thing, is precisely not the glorious thing, is the shallow or corrupt

or lifeless or harmful thing that the glorious theology has nothing to do with. You cannot cash the check the theology writes, the objection says, because the theology describes a heavenly reality and you have to attend an earthly building, and the gap between them is the whole problem, and no amount of beautiful writing about the body of Christ closes the gap between the ideal and the three actual churches in my actual town.

I feel the full weight of this, and I am not going to pretend I can dissolve it, because I cannot. There is a real gap between the theology of the church and the experience of most actual churches, and the theology does not automatically transfer to the building, and a person can believe every word I have written about the body of Christ and still walk into every church in their town and find nothing that resembles it. This happens. It happens often. I will not insult you by denying it. So let me say the three partial things I can say, and let me be clear that they are partial, that they do not add up to a full answer, that the gap remains, and that the honest position is to hold the theology and the gap together rather than to let either erase the other.

The first partial thing is that the gap between the ideal church and the actual church is not new, is not a modern problem, is exactly the gap the New Testament letters were written into, and that the theology of the body was never a description of an ideal church that existed somewhere but a description of what the actual, messy, disappointing churches already were despite their mess. Paul called the Corinthian disaster the body of Christ. He did not mean Corinth was living up to the ideal. He meant that this actual failing congregation was, despite its failures, the body, that the theology applied to the disappointing real thing and not to some ideal elsewhere. So the theology does transfer to the disappointing church down your street, not because that church

is living up to it, but because the theology was always about disappointing churches, was always the truth about failing congregations, was never a description of an ideal that the real thing fails to match. The body of Christ is not the ideal church you cannot find. It is the real church you can find, described truly, including its failures, the way Paul described Corinth.

The second partial thing is that the ideal you are measuring the actual churches against may itself be part of the problem, may be the idealism Bonhoeffer warned would make you a destroyer, the dream of community that you love more than the community and that makes you unable to receive the real thing as a gift. If you walk into the three churches in your town looking for the glorious body of Christ in its ideal form, you will not find it, and you will leave disappointed, because it is not there, because it is nowhere, because the ideal form does not exist on earth and never has. But if you walk in looking for the actual body of Christ, the real disappointing mixed thing that Paul called the body despite its mess, you might find it, might find it in the small church that knows your name, might find it in the slow line at the communion rail, might find it in a single relationship of honest confession, might find it in fragments and flickers rather than in the full ideal, and the fragments and flickers are the real thing, are more real than the ideal you were looking for, and you missed them because you were looking for the wrong thing, the glorious ideal instead of the humble real.

The third partial thing, and it is the least satisfying, is that sometimes the answer is that you have to help build it, that the church you are looking for does not exist in your town because it has not been built yet, and that the reason it has not been built is that the people who could build it, the wounded who know exactly what it must be, are all outside, having left, waiting for

someone else to build the thing that only they can build. I named this earlier as the membership of the wounded, and I raise it again here as a partial answer to the strongest objection, because it is the only answer I have to the person who says none of the churches in my town is the thing you describe. Sometimes that is true, and sometimes the response is not to keep searching for the thing already built, but to become, with a few others, the builders of it, to be the small stubborn nucleus of a church that would not do what the others did, and to build it precisely because you could not find it. This is a hard answer and an expensive one and not everyone is called to it, and I will not pretend it is available to everyone or easy for anyone. But it is the truth that some of the churches worth returning to do not yet exist and are waiting to be built by the very people who most need them, and that the gap between the ideal and the actual is not only a reason to despair but sometimes a call to build.

So I have not fully answered the objection, and I told you I would not, and I want to end the chapter by holding the gap open rather than pretending to have closed it. The gap between the theology of the church and the experience of most churches is real, and it remains, and I cannot dissolve it, and anyone who tells you they can is selling something. What I can say is that the theology applies to the real disappointing church and not only to an ideal one, that the idealism which makes you unable to find the body may be part of what blinds you to it, and that sometimes the church worth returning to has to be built rather than found. These are partial answers. They leave the gap open. And I would rather leave it open honestly than close it dishonestly, because a book that closed the gap with a rhetorical flourish would be exactly the kind of handling I promised in the introduction not to do, and you would be right to distrust it. The gap is real. Hold it open. Live in the tension. That is more honest

than any resolution I could offer, and honesty was the whole point.

Chapter Thirty-Six: What the Body Is For

I have spent this whole book arguing that the church is not optional, that you cannot have Christ without his body, that the faith was never meant to be solitary, and I have defended the body against every objection I could find. But I have not squarely answered a question that sits underneath all of it, and it deserves its own chapter before the end, because without it the whole argument could be misheard as a defense of the church for its own sake, the institution demanding your loyalty because institutions demand loyalty. The question is what the body is actually for. Not what it is, but what it is for. Because if the church exists for itself, for its own perpetuation, for the filling of its own seats, then it deserves exactly the leaving it got. It is only worth belonging to if it is for something beyond itself, and I want to say plainly what that something is.

The church is not for itself. This is the first and most important thing, and the church's forgetting of it is the root of nearly every failure this book has named. The moment the church exists for itself, for its own growth and reputation and survival, it becomes the machine that harmed you, because a thing that exists for itself will sacrifice anything, including its own members, to preserve itself, and that is exactly what the harmful church did. The church that covered up abuse was preserving itself. The church that sold itself to power was preserving itself. The church that treated members as customers was preserving itself. Self-preservation is the disease, and it takes hold precisely when the church forgets that it does not exist for itself, that it is not the

point, that it is a means and not an end, and the moment it makes itself the end it becomes a devouring thing.

So what is it a means to? The New Testament answer is layered, and I want to give it in its layers rather than flattening it. At the first layer, the church exists for the worship of God, for the gathering of a people to give God the glory due his name, and this is worth stating first because the church that forgets it exists first for God rather than for people, even for the good of people, will eventually instrumentalize both God and people toward its own ends. The church is, before it is anything else, a people gathered around God, oriented toward God, existing to know and love and glorify God, and this Godward orientation is the thing that keeps it from collapsing into a self-help club or a political action committee or a social service agency, all of which are things the church becomes when it forgets that it exists first for God. The worship is not a means to something else. It is the first thing the body is for, the reason it gathers, the orientation that keeps all the other things from becoming idols.

At the second layer, the church exists for the formation of its members into the likeness of Christ, for the slow remaking of self-enclosed people into people who can love God and neighbor, and this is the layer I have emphasized most in this book, the church as the community that sands you down, that teaches you to love the people you did not choose, that forms you through the friction of belonging into someone you could not have become alone. The body is for your transformation, not in the shallow sense the market church meant, the improvement of your life, but in the deep sense of your actual remaking into a different kind of person, and this remaking cannot happen alone, requires the body, requires the difficult others, requires the long obedience sustained by belonging, which is the whole argument

of the book. The church is for making you into someone who can love, and it does this through the very difficulty of loving the actual people in the actual pews, which is why the difficulty is not a bug but the mechanism.

At the third layer, and this is the one the inward-facing church forgets, the church exists for the world, for the sake of everyone outside it, as a sign and instrument of what God intends for the whole creation. Lesslie Newbigin, the missionary theologian who spent decades in India and then came home to a secular England that had become its own mission field, argued that the church is meant to be a sign, an instrument, and a foretaste of the kingdom of God, a community that shows the world what God's reign looks like by actually living it, a preview of the healed creation planted in the middle of the unhealed one. The church that turns inward, that exists for its own members' comfort, has forgotten this third layer, has become a club for the saved rather than a sign for the world, and its inward turn is a large part of what made it so ugly, because a body that exists only for itself becomes self-absorbed and self-protective and eventually self-worshipping, whereas a body that exists for the world is turned outward, spent on others, given away, which is the only posture in which it resembles its Lord, who did not come to be served but to serve and to give his life.

Put the three layers together and you have what the body is for, and it is nothing like the self-perpetuating institution that harmed you. The body exists for the worship of God, for the formation of its members into people who can love, and for the sake of the world it is meant to serve and sign and foretaste. A church living these three things is a church worth belonging to, and a church that has forgotten them, that exists for its own growth and reputation and survival, is the machine you rightly fled. And here

is the thing that matters for your decision, whatever you decide. The test of any church you are considering, whether to stay in or return to or help build, is not whether it is impressive or growing or comfortable, but whether it is oriented toward these three things, whether it worships God rather than itself, whether it forms people rather than using them, whether it is turned outward toward the world rather than inward toward its own preservation. A church oriented toward these three things will be worth your belonging even when it is small and unimpressive and disappointing, and a church that has forgotten them will not be worth your belonging even when it is large and exciting and impressive, and this test cuts through everything, because it goes to what the body is for, which is the only thing that finally justifies asking anyone to belong to it.

I want to end this chapter by connecting it back to the wound, because everything in this book has to connect back to the wound or it is just theology floating free of the people it is for. The church that harmed you had forgotten what the body is for. It existed for itself, and because it existed for itself it used you, sacrificed you, treated you as a means to its own preservation, which is the exact inversion of what the body is meant to be, a means to God's glory and your formation and the world's good. So your wound is not evidence against the body. It is evidence against a body that forgot what it was for, that inverted its own purpose, that made itself the end and you the means when it should have been the reverse. And the church worth returning to, if you find it or build it, will be a church that remembers what the body is for, that exists for God and for your formation and for the world, that would spend itself for you rather than spending you for itself, and that church is the real body, the thing the harmful church was a corruption of, and it is worth everything, precisely because it is not for itself, which is the only

kind of thing that is ever worth belonging to.

Chapter Thirty-Seven: The Faith of the Half-Convinced

I want to write one chapter for the reader I have perhaps served least well in this book, the reader who is not sure they believe any of it, who has followed the argument about the church but who is stuck on a prior question, which is whether the whole thing is true at all, whether there is a God, whether Christ rose, whether the body of Christ is a body of anything real or just a warm metaphor for a human community that comforts itself with cosmic language. I came to faith from atheism as a grown man, and I have never lost my memory of standing outside the whole thing looking in, unconvinced, and I owe that reader a chapter, because a book that only addressed the wounded believer and ignored the honest doubter would be leaving out some of the very people who left, the ones who left not because they were hurt but because they stopped believing it was true.

Let me say first that I am not going to try to argue you into belief in a single chapter, because that would be both futile and disrespectful, futile because no one was ever argued into faith by a chapter and disrespectful because it would treat your doubt as a problem to be solved rather than an honest position to be met. I was a serious atheist. I had real arguments. I was not talked out of them by a clever apologist, and I am not going to insult you by pretending I could talk you out of yours. What I can do, what I want to do, is describe honestly what the transition was actually like from the inside, because I think the church usually describes it dishonestly, as a sudden clarity, a moment of certainty, a decisive conviction that settled everything, and it was nothing

like that for me, and the dishonest description does real harm to the honest doubter who is waiting for a certainty that is not coming.

Here is what it was actually like. It was not that I became certain. It was that I became willing. The arguments did not resolve. The doubts did not disappear. What happened, slowly, was that I stopped requiring certainty as the price of participation, stopped standing outside demanding proof before I would take a single step, and started, tentatively, half-convinced, to live as if it might be true and to see what happened. I went to the services still doubting. I prayed the prayers still unsure anyone was listening. I sat with the people still suspecting the whole thing might be an elaborate consolation. And I did this not because I had achieved belief but because I had grown tired of the certainty-demand, tired of standing outside insisting on proof, and willing, finally, to try the thing from the inside and let the trying be part of how I found out whether it was true. Faith, I discovered, was not the certainty I had been waiting for. It was the willingness to proceed without the certainty, to participate while still doubting, to live the thing as an experiment rather than requiring it to be proven before I would live it at all.

This matters enormously for the church, and it is why I have put this chapter here near the end rather than treating it as a separate topic, because the church is where the half-convinced faith is actually sustained and tested and slowly, sometimes, confirmed. You cannot experiment with Christianity alone, from outside, in your head, because Christianity is not primarily a set of propositions to be evaluated but a way of life to be lived, and a way of life can only be tested by living it, and living it requires the body, the practices, the community, the whole embodied reality that the solitary evaluator standing outside never enters.

The half-convinced doubter who tries to resolve their doubt by more thinking, more reading, more argument, from outside, alone, will mostly stay stuck, because the thing cannot be resolved from outside, can only be tested from inside, and the inside is the church. This is why so many people who left over intellectual doubt never resolve the doubt, because they are trying to resolve from outside a thing that can only be tested from inside, and they will not go inside until the doubt is resolved, and so they wait forever for a resolution that only entering could provide.

I am describing, I realize, something that sounds like a trap, believe first and understanding will follow, and I want to distinguish it sharply from the manipulation that phrase can become. I am not telling you to manufacture a belief you do not have, to fake conviction, to talk yourself into certainty. I am describing something more honest than that, which is the willingness to participate in the practices and the community while still doubting, to run the experiment from inside rather than demanding it be concluded from outside, to let the living be part of the finding out. Anselm, in the eleventh century, called this faith seeking understanding, and he did not mean faith as certainty seeking to prove itself, he meant a prior trust, a willingness, a participation, that then seeks and slowly finds the understanding it did not have at the start. The understanding follows the participation. It does not precede it. And the participation happens in the body, in the church, which is why the doubter who will not enter the church until the doubt is resolved has the order backwards, is waiting outside for something that only entering could give.

So to the half-convinced, to the honest doubter who left because they stopped being sure it was true, I offer not an argument but

an invitation to a different posture, the posture of the experiment rather than the verdict. You do not have to be sure. You never have to be sure, not even years in, because faith is not the certainty and the demand for certainty is exactly what keeps you outside. You can enter half-convinced, can participate while doubting, can run the thing as an experiment from inside, can let the living be part of how you find out, and this is not intellectual dishonesty, it is the only honest way to test a thing that can only be tested by living it. I did this. I entered half-convinced, doubting, suspicious, with all my arguments still loaded, and I did not resolve the doubts before I entered, I entered with the doubts and let the entering be part of the answer, and the answer came slowly, from inside, over years, not as a certainty that ended the doubt but as a confirmation that grew alongside it, until one day I noticed that I had become, without quite deciding to, a person who believed, and that the believing had grown in the soil of the participation, in the body, in the church, which is the one place I could never have found it while I was standing outside demanding it be proven before I would enter. The body is not only for the convinced. It is where the half-convinced become, slowly, over years, in the living of it, sure enough to keep going, which is all the certainty anyone actually gets.

Chapter Thirty-Eight: A Letter to the One Still Angry

I have written this book for many readers, and I have tried to serve each of them, but there is one I have circled without addressing directly, and I want to write to that one now, plainly, before the conclusion, because that reader is the one I most do not want to lose in the general argument. It is the reader who is still angry, who has read this far with a rising resistance, who feels that every honest thing I have said about the church's failures has been a setup, a softening, a way of lowering your guard before the pivot back to the pews, and who is angry at me specifically for being a pastor who is going to do to you in the end what pastors always do, which is find a way to make it your responsibility to fix your relationship with the institution that broke you. This chapter is a letter to you, and I am going to write it as directly as I can, and I am not going to ask you for anything at the end of it.

I believe your anger. I want to start there, because you have been told your anger was a sin, a bitterness, a root that would defile you, a sign of your spiritual immaturity, and I do not believe any of that, and I think the people who told you that were using a spiritual frame to avoid facing what they had done. Your anger is not a sin. Your anger is information. It is the accurate registering of a real wrong, the moral sense functioning exactly as it should, refusing to pretend that what happened was acceptable. The Scriptures are full of anger, righteous anger, the anger of the prophets and the psalmists and Jesus himself, who made a whip and drove the merchants out of the temple, who called the

religious leaders whitewashed tombs and broods of vipers, who was angry, visibly, repeatedly, at exactly the kind of religious harm you suffered. If your anger is a sin, then Christ sinned, and he did not, and your anger at religious harm puts you in his company and not outside it, which is the opposite of what you were told.

So I am not going to ask you to stop being angry. I am going to say something else, something I hope you can hear from a pastor even though you have every reason not to trust a pastor. Your anger is accurate, and it is also, if you let it be, incomplete, not wrong but incomplete, and the incompleteness is worth noticing, not for the church's sake but for yours. Anger is accurate about what happened. It is a poor foundation for a life. It can tell you the truth about the past and it cannot build you a future, because a life organized around anger, however justified, slowly becomes an angry life, and an angry life is a diminished life, not because the anger was wrong but because anger was never meant to be a home, only a signal, and a signal you live inside forever stops being a signal and becomes a prison. I said this earlier in the book, about the grievance identity, and I say it again here, directly to you, because you are the one it is for, and I want you to have it not as an accusation but as a key.

Here is what I want you to consider, and I want you to consider it as a possibility and not a demand. Your anger has been, so far, entirely reactive, defined by what was done to you, pointed backward at the harm. And this is right and necessary as a first movement, the naming of the wrong, the refusal to pretend. But there is a second movement available, and it is not the movement the church wants, which is forgiveness-as-return, the resolution of your anger into a comfortable reconciliation that lets the institution off the hook. The second movement I mean is

different. It is the movement from anger at what was done to a fierce and constructive determination that it not be done again, to others, by a church you might help build differently. It is the transformation of the anger from a backward-pointing grievance into a forward-pointing fuel, the same energy redirected from what cannot be changed, the past, toward what can, the future, the church your children or someone else's children will inherit. This is not forgiveness in the sense the church demanded. It is something the church never offered you, which is a use for your anger that honors it rather than suppressing it, that says your anger was right and here is what to do with its energy now that it has told you the truth it had to tell.

I have watched this transformation in people, and it is one of the most powerful things I have ever seen, more powerful than any conversion story, because it takes the very wound and turns it into the thing that heals others. The person who was spiritually abused and who channels their fierce accurate anger into building or reforming or protecting, into making sure the church becomes a place where what happened to them cannot happen to others, is not a person who has gotten over their anger. They are a person who has put their anger to work, who has made it constructive without making it any less fierce, who has become, through the very wound, a guardian against the wound, and this is a holy thing, and it is available to you, and it does not require you to forgive on any timeline or return to anything or pretend anything was acceptable. It requires only that you consider letting the energy of your anger point forward as well as backward, at the church that could be as well as the church that was, and that you consider that you, precisely because you were harmed, might be one of the few people equipped to make sure others are not.

I said I would not ask you for anything, and I meant it, so let me be clear that this is not a request. I am not asking you to do this. I am telling you it exists, as a possibility, so that you know your options are larger than the two the church offered you, which were forgive-and-return or stay-angry-and-leave. There is a third thing, anger transformed into constructive fierceness, and it belongs to you if you want it and it is none of my business if you do not, and I would not dream of pressuring you toward it, because pressuring the wounded is exactly the sin this book exists to name. I am only, as one pastor who has seen it, testifying that it is real, that the anger you carry is not only a burden but potentially a fuel, that the very thing that broke you might be the thing that qualifies you to build what would not break others, and that this transformation, if it ever comes, will come on your timeline and not the church's, in your own way and not anyone else's, and that it is yours, entirely yours, to choose or decline as you see fit.

And if you never do, if you stay angry for the rest of your life, if the wound never becomes a fuel and only ever stays a wound, hear this last thing from a pastor who will not ask you for anything. You are still loved. Not because you got over it, not because you forgave, not because you came back, not because you transformed your anger into anything useful. You are loved as you are, angry and wounded and gone, by the God who was angry too at what was done to you, who made a whip once for exactly this, who does not stand over your anger with his arms crossed waiting for you to resolve it but sits down next to it, next to you, in the parking lot, and stays. That is the God under the church that harmed you, the one the church so thoroughly obscured that you could not see him for the men who claimed to speak for him. He is not angry at your anger. He shares it. And whatever you do with the rest of your life, that is true, and it was

true the whole time, and no church can give it to you or take it away, because it was never theirs to control, it was only ever theirs to witness, and they did that badly, and it is true anyway.

Chapter Thirty-Nine: The Scars He Kept

When the risen Christ showed himself to his friends, he did not show them a body without wounds. He showed them the wounds, and told them to touch.

I want to end the argument, before the conclusion gathers it up, on a single strange detail from the resurrection accounts, because it holds the whole book in miniature and I have been building toward it without saying so. When Jesus rose from the dead, he rose in a body, a real one, that ate fish and could be touched, and that body bore the marks of the crucifixion, the holes in the hands and the feet and the side. The risen Christ, the glorified one, the victor over death, kept his scars. He did not rise into a perfected body that had erased the evidence of what was done to him. He rose into a wounded body, a scarred body, and when he wanted to prove to his terrified friends that it was really him, he showed them the wounds, and to the one who doubted he said, put your finger here, reach out your hand and place it in my side. The proof of the resurrection was the scars. The glory did not erase the wounds. The glory included them.

I have thought about this for years, and I think it is the deepest word the faith has to speak to everyone this book is for, the wounded who left and the wounded who stayed and the wounded who are trying to build something that will not wound others. It says that the body of Christ, the real one, the risen one, the one that will outlast every failure, is not a body without scars. It is a

scarred body, a wounded body, a body that carried the marks of what was done to it into its glory rather than erasing them, and this is the pattern for his people, who are his body, and who are therefore meant to be, not a body that pretends to have no wounds, but a body that bears its wounds openly, that shows them as proof, that says to the doubter, reach out your hand and touch the place where we were broken. The church that pretended to have no wounds, that performed a false perfection, that hid its scars to protect its reputation, was denying the very pattern of its risen Lord, who kept his scars and showed them and made them the proof.

Think about what this means for the church worth returning to, the one I described in the abstract and could not point you to in the concrete. It is not a church without wounds. There is no such church and there never was, not even with the apostles present, not even in the resurrection body of Christ himself, which kept its wounds. The church worth returning to is a church that bears its wounds the way its Lord bore his, openly, as proof rather than shame, that does not hide what was done to it or what it did, that shows its scars to the doubter and says touch them, this is how you know we are real, that our reality is not in our perfection but in our honest woundedness healed. A church of people who have been broken and mended, who show the mending without hiding the breaking, who are proof of resurrection precisely because they carry the marks of death into their new life rather than pretending the death never happened. That is a church that could hold you, because it would not require you to hide your wounds either, would receive you scarred and show you its own scars in return, and the mutual showing would be the fellowship, the body recognizing the body by the wounds they share.

There is a specific comfort here for the one whose faith was

broken and has been, slowly, painfully, mending, and I want to name it because it is precious and rare. You may believe that your wounded faith, your scarred and doubting and hard-won belief, is a lesser thing than the smooth untested faith you had before, or that others seem to have, that your scars are evidence of failure, that a real faith would not carry these marks. The risen Christ says otherwise. His scarred body was not a lesser body than his pre-crucifixion body. It was the same body, glorified, and the scars were part of the glory, the proof of what he had passed through and survived, the evidence that death had been met and defeated rather than avoided. Your scarred faith, if it has passed through the death of your certainty and come out the other side still believing, however waveringly, is not a lesser faith than the untested kind. It is a resurrection faith, a faith that has been to the tomb and come back marked, and the marks are not its shame but its proof, the evidence that it met something that could have killed it and did not, and this is a deeper and truer and more durable faith than the smooth kind that was never tested, the way the risen body is more glorious than the body that never died.

I keep returning, as this book ends, to the image of the communion line in the small church, the slow procession of broken people toward the table, and I understand now why it moves me so much, why it seems to me the truest picture of the church I have. It is a line of scarred bodies moving toward a scarred body, the wounded church approaching the wounded Christ, each of them carrying the marks of what was done to them and what they did, and none of them pretending otherwise, all of them coming with empty hands to receive the broken bread, which is his body, broken, scarred, given. It is not a line of the perfected. It is a line of the wounded and mending, and the bread they receive is the sign of a body that kept its wounds, and

the whole thing is the opposite of the false perfection the harmful church performed, is instead the honest woundedness that is the only real holiness there is, the holiness of people who have been broken and are being mended and are not ashamed of either, moving together toward the one who was broken for them and kept the marks to prove it.

So this is the last thing I want to set beside all the failures I have named, the abuse and the hypocrisy and the politics and the shallowness and the control, all of them real, all of them earning the leaving. The body of Christ is a scarred body. It always was. Its Lord kept his wounds, and his people are his wounded body, and the church worth belonging to is not the one that hides its scars but the one that shows them, that receives you scarred and shows you its scars in return, that finds in the mutual woundedness the proof that it is real and the ground on which it heals. You left a church that pretended to have no wounds, and you were right to leave the pretense, because the pretense was a lie, a denial of the very pattern of the risen Christ. But the real thing, the scarred body, the wounded church of the wounded God, is a different thing than the pretense you fled, and it might, if you ever touch it, feel less like a threat and more like recognition, one scarred body knowing another, which is how the risen Christ was known, and how his body is still known, by the wounds, which he kept, and showed, and told the doubter to touch.

Chapter Forty: The Table Where Enemies Eat

There is one more thing the body does that nothing else in human life does, and I have saved it for last among the chapters because it is the hardest and the most beautiful and the most impossible, and it is the thing that finally separates the church from every other community a person might belong to. The church is the one community on earth that is supposed to seat enemies at the same table, that is built precisely on the reconciliation of people who have every human reason to hate each other, that takes the deepest divisions of the human race and dissolves them, not by ignoring them but by placing something larger over them, and this, when it actually happens, is a miracle, and when it fails to happen, as it constantly does, it is the church's most visible betrayal of its own founding purpose. I want to end the argument here, on the table where enemies eat, because it is the thing the church is for and the thing the church most conspicuously failed at, and both matter.

Consider what Paul thought the church was accomplishing, because it was far more radical than we usually let it be. He wrote to a church divided between Jew and Gentile, two groups separated by centuries of religious and ethnic hostility, groups that did not eat together, did not intermarry, regarded each other with contempt and suspicion, and he told them that Christ had broken down the dividing wall of hostility between them, had made the two into one new humanity, had reconciled them both to God in one body through the cross. The church was, for Paul, the place where the deepest division in his world, the division

between Jew and Gentile, was actually overcome, where people who could not have sat at the same table anywhere else in the ancient world sat at the same table here, ate the same bread here, were one body here, and this reconciliation was not incidental to the gospel, it was the gospel made visible, the proof that Christ had done what he claimed to do, the demonstration in flesh that the divisions of the human race were not final. A church that could seat Jew and Gentile together was a church that was showing the world something the world could not otherwise believe, that enmity could end, that the wall could come down, that enemies could become one body.

Now hold that against what the church actually became in our own time and place, because the contrast is the whole indictment. The church that was supposed to be the one place where the deepest divisions dissolved became, in America, one of the most divided institutions in the country, sorted by race more thoroughly than almost any other, sorted by politics until you could predict a congregation's entire worldview from its zip code, sorted by class and by culture and by every human division the gospel was supposed to overcome. The most segregated hour in America, it was famously said, is eleven o'clock on Sunday morning, and the fact that this was said about the church, the very institution founded to dissolve exactly such divisions, is the sharpest possible measure of the church's failure. The body built to seat enemies at one table had instead sorted itself into a thousand tables, each one full of people who already agreed, each one a chaplaincy to a tribe, and this sorting was not a minor failure, it was a betrayal of the founding purpose, a denial of the very thing the church exists to demonstrate, that in Christ the dividing walls come down.

This is, I think, one of the deepest reasons the politically

homeless and the racially weary and the culturally displaced left the church, and it is worth naming as its own wound distinct from the others. They came to the church looking for the one place where the divisions of the world would be overcome, where they would find people unlike themselves united by something deeper than agreement, and they found instead a tribe that looked and voted and thought exactly like the tribe they could have found anywhere, plus a cross on the wall. They found that the church had not overcome the divisions, it had baptized them, had given the tribe a theological justification and a Sunday gathering and called the whole arrangement the body of Christ, when it was really just the world's divisions with a religious veneer. And they left, because they could get the tribe without the veneer anywhere, could find people who agreed with them at the coffee shop or online or at the political meeting, and the church offered them nothing the tribe did not already offer except the additional insult of pretending the tribe was the body of Christ. The failure to seat enemies at the table emptied the church of exactly the people who most longed for a table where enemies could sit, which is a bitter irony, because those were the people who understood best what the church was supposed to be.

But I have to turn this, as I have turned everything, because the failure of the church to be the table where enemies eat does not prove that the table is not real, it proves that this particular church betrayed the table, and the two are different. The table where enemies eat is still the church's founding purpose, still what it is for, still what happens when the church actually is the church, and it does still happen, in the small unimpressive places, in the congregations that have refused to sort themselves, where the person who votes one way takes communion beside the person who votes the other way, where the races that the culture separates are one body, where the class divisions that

structure everything else dissolve at the rail. It is rare. It is precious. It is the hardest thing the church ever does and the thing it most often fails at. But where it happens it is a miracle, a genuine sign that the walls can come down, a preview of the healed creation planted in the middle of the divided one, and it is the thing the church-leaver who left over the divisions most longs for and most doubts is possible, and it is possible, and it exists, and it is the truest thing the church ever is when it manages to be it.

So I want to leave the argument here, on this hardest and most beautiful thing, because it gathers up everything the book has been about. The church is the body that seats enemies at one table, and it mostly failed to do this, and its failure was a genuine betrayal that drove out the very people who most understood its purpose. And the table is still real, still the church's reason for being, still what happens when the body actually is the body, still a miracle where it occurs. The person who left over the church's divisions was right about the divisions and wrong, maybe, to conclude that the table was a lie, because the table is not a lie, the table is the truth the divided church betrayed, and the truth remains true even where the church betrays it, the way the risen Christ remains risen even where the church denies him. The table where enemies eat is set. The church mostly abandoned it for a thousand tables where friends confirm each other. But the one table is still there, in the small faithful places, with room for enemies to become one body, and it is the deepest thing the church is for, and it is worth everything, and it did not stop being real because the church stopped setting it. It is still set. There is still room. And enemies still, sometimes, in the small stubborn faithful places, sit down together and eat, and become, in the eating, the one thing the world swears is impossible, which is a body made of people who should have hated each other and

instead share the bread.

Chapter Forty-One: On Being Fathered by a Broken Thing

I have kept myself mostly out of the personal story in this book, because a pastor who makes the argument about himself has quietly changed the subject from the reader's wound to his own, and I did not want to do that. But I owe you one chapter of the personal, here at the end, because the whole book rests on a thing I have said in passing and never explained, that the church is where I was fathered, late, by broken men who did it badly and did it anyway, and that this is why I cannot write about the church cheaply. I want to explain what I meant, because it is the ground under everything, and because it holds the paradox the whole book has been living inside, that a broken thing can still give you what you most need, that the failure and the gift can come from the same source, that you can be genuinely harmed and genuinely saved by the same imperfect body.

I was raised without a father. I have said this a few times, plainly, without dwelling on it, and I am not going to dwell on it now, because self-pity is its own forbidden language and I have no use for it. But I will say what it did, because it bears on the argument. A boy raised without a father grows up with a hole shaped like a man who is supposed to show you how to be one, and the hole does not fill itself, and the boy either finds men to fill it or he does not, and if he does not he carries the hole into his own manhood and often into his own fathering, passing the absence down. I came to faith from atheism as a grown man, with that hole still unfilled, and I did not come to the church looking to be fathered, I came looking to argue, with my

objections loaded, an adversary probing for the weak seam. And what happened to me in the church was not that my arguments were answered, though some of them were. What happened was that I was fathered, without asking for it, by men who had no idea they were doing it, and it changed me more than any argument could have, and it is the reason I am a pastor and not still standing outside with my objections.

Here is the part that matters for you, the part that is not just my story but the argument the whole book has been making, incarnate in one life. The men who fathered me were broken. They were not wise sages or perfect saints or the impressive spiritual fathers you read about. They were ordinary, flawed, limited men, men who said the wrong thing as often as the right one, who had their own unaddressed wounds and their own blind spots and their own failures, some of which I saw up close and some of which harmed me in small ways. The church that fathered me was the disappointing mixed real church I have described throughout, not the ideal, and the men in it were the disappointing mixed real members, and they fathered me anyway, badly, imperfectly, through their limitations rather than despite them, and the fathering was real and it saved my life and it came through broken vessels, because broken vessels are the only kind there are, and the treasure was in the clay precisely because there was no other container available. If I had waited for perfect fathers, for an ideal church, for men who would not fail me, I would have waited forever, and I would have died unfathered, and the hole would have passed to my sons.

I have five sons now, and every one of them is a daily referendum on whether the fathering I received got through, whether the hole was filled enough that I do not pass it down, and I will tell you honestly that I fail them constantly, that I am a

broken vessel fathering them the way I was fathered, badly, imperfectly, through my limitations, and that my only hope is the same hope that fathered me, that the treasure can be in the clay, that broken men can give what they do not perfectly possess, that the grace runs through the cracks rather than around them. And this is the church, exactly this, the whole thing in a single family, broken people giving each other what they cannot perfectly give, the grace running through the cracks, the treasure in the clay, the fathering that happens not despite the brokenness but somehow through it, because that is the only way anything real has ever been given, hand to hand, flawed to flawed, the wounded raising the wounded, the mended mending the breaking. I am a father because I was fathered by a broken thing, and I would not trade the broken fathering for the perfect fathering I never got, because the broken fathering was real and it reached me and the perfect fathering was a fantasy that would have left me waiting forever.

So when I make the case for the church, understand that I am not making it from theory, I am making it from the hole in my own chest that the church filled, imperfectly, through broken men, when nothing else could fill it. I know the church is broken because it broke me in small ways even as it saved me. I know it fails because it failed me even as it fathered me. And I know it gives what nothing else gives, because it gave me the thing I most needed, the fathering I never had, through vessels too cracked to have given it if the giving depended on their wholeness, which it did not, which it never does, which is the whole point. The church fathered me the way it does everything, badly and truly, through brokenness, and the badly and the truly were not two different things but one thing, one broken gift, and I received it, and it made me, and here I am, a broken father of five, a broken pastor of a broken church, telling you that the broken thing can still give you what you most need, because it

gave it to me, and I am the evidence, cracked and leaking and fathered and alive.

This is the last thing I know how to say about why the church is not optional, and it is not an argument, it is a testimony, and I offer it as one. You have a hole in you. Everyone does. The specific shape differs, a father, a belonging, a meaning, a home, but the hole is there, and it does not fill itself, and the culture around you cannot fill it, and the solitary spiritual life you have constructed cannot fill it, because holes shaped like other people can only be filled by other people, and the church, broken as it is, is the community God appointed to be the other people, the flawed vessels through which the grace runs to reach the hole. It will not do it perfectly. It will harm you a little even as it heals you. It will father you badly and truly, through its cracks, and the badly and the truly will be one thing. But it will reach the hole, if you let it, the way it reached mine, and nothing else will, and that is not a threat, it is a testimony, from one broken man who was fathered by a broken thing and would not trade it, to another broken person with a hole that is waiting, still, to be filled by the only thing that has ever filled it, which is a body, broken, and given.

Conclusion: The Body You Left, the Body That Did Not Leave You

I have come to the end, and I want to end the way I promised in the beginning, without an altar call, without a pitch, without the manufactured urgency that would betray everything the book has tried to be. So let me gather what I have said and lay it down, and then leave you with the weight rather than lifting it, because the weight is the truest thing I have to give you and I would be cheating you to resolve it into a comfortable close.

I said at the start that I believed most of the people who left the church were telling the truth about why, and I have spent the book trying to prove I meant it, naming the abuse and the hypocrisy and the politics and the consumerism and the shallowness and the control, naming them plainly, from inside the institution's failures, as a man who committed versions of most of them and drove real people out and owes debts he cannot fully pay. I have not taken any of that back. I do not take it back now. The church earned its empty seats. The leaving was often an act of integrity. The wound was real, and it was inflicted, and it was inflicted by the very thing that should have healed it, and if that were the whole story it would be a story of pure loss and I would have no business adding my voice to it.

But I said there was an and, and the and was the reason for the book, and I have spent most of these pages on it, so let me say it one final time as plainly as I know how. The thing you left was not the thing itself. You left a building, a brand, a bloc, a machine, and some of you left a wolf, and you were right to

leave all of it. But underneath it, older than it, is a body, the body of Christ, which is not optional to the faith because the faith was never solitary, because the New Testament does not know what a churchless Christian is, because God has a body and refuses to be met apart from it, because you cannot have the head while cutting off every hand and foot, because the salvation the gospel describes is precisely the remaking of a self-enclosed person into a member, and a member cannot be made in isolation, by definition, because membership is the cure and isolation is the disease. This is the hard, unsellable thing I believe, and I have tried to earn the right to say it to you, and now I have said it, and whether I earned it is yours to judge.

The body you left did not leave you. That is the sentence the whole book has been building toward, and I want to set it down carefully, because it can be heard as a threat and I mean it as a promise. The body of Christ is not the institution that harmed you, and it did not walk out on you when you walked out on the institution, because it was never the institution in the first place, it was the thing the institution was a corruption of, and it has been there the whole time, in the small unimpressive churches that know your name, in the slow line at the communion rail, in the single relationship of honest confession, in the communion of saints stretching back two thousand years who wrestled and doubted and suffered exactly as you have, in the persecuted church that clings to what we found so easy to drop, in the ordinary means of grace that come to you from outside when your inside has failed, in the long obedience that only a body can sustain. It has been there the whole time, and it did not leave you, and it is not surprised by your anger, and it is not keeping score, and it has a gap in the line exactly your size, and it is waiting, unhurried, patient, with the patience of a God who has been setting tables in the ruins of failed churches for two

thousand years and has not stopped.

I am not going to tell you to go back. I told you that in the introduction and I have kept it through thirty-eight chapters and I am not going to break it in the last paragraph. If you finish this book and stay gone, you stay gone, and there is grace for that, and God is more likely to be found on your side of the closed door than standing behind it with his arms crossed. What I have tried to give you is not a reason to return but a truer picture of what you left, so that if you stay gone you stay gone knowing what the thing actually was, and if you ever come back you come back to the right thing and not the counterfeit, and either way you carry a truer picture than the one the church gave you, which is all I promised and all I have.

Here is the weight I will leave you with, and I will not lift it. You were made for a body. The isolation you are living in, however justified its cause, however righteous your leaving, is not the shape a human soul was made to hold, and something in you knows it, which is why the leaving still aches years later, why the anger has not fully freed you, why the freedom is lonelier than you expected. That ache is not the church manipulating you. The church is not even in the room. That ache is your own nature, made for membership, registering the cost of the severance, and it will not resolve by more leaving, because leaving is not the cure for it, leaving is the wound it is registering. I cannot tell you what to do with that ache. I can only tell you what it is, that it is real, that it is accurate, that it is the deepest part of you refusing to pretend that you were made to be alone.

The body you left is still your body. The line still has your gap in it. The table is still set in the ruins. And the ache you carry is the truest thing about you, truer than your anger, truer than your leaving, the ache of a member for the body it was cut from, and I

will not tell you what to do with it, but I will not let you believe it is nothing. It is not nothing. It is everything. It is the body you left, calling, in the only voice it has, which is the shape of the space where it used to be. Carry that. I have nothing else to give you, and I would not insult you by pretending the ache resolves. It does not resolve. It waits. And so, patient as its Lord, does the body you left, which did not leave you, and is not going to.